DISABILITY RIGHTS & GOVERNMENT SCHEMES

A Comprehensive Guide & Digital Resource for Persons with Disabilities in India

- Rights under the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (RPWD) Act, 2016
- Government Welfare Schemes | Assistive Technology | Accessible India
- Employment, Education, Healthcare & Legal Rights
- State-wise Implementation | Grievance Mechanisms | Digital Resources

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CHAPTER PREFACE

A Note to the Reader

This comprehensive guide has been prepared to serve as a definitive reference for Persons with Disabilities (PwDs), caregivers, advocates, legal professionals, NGOs, government officials, and all citizens who seek to understand, implement, or champion the rights and entitlements guaranteed to persons with disabilities in India.

India is home to approximately 26.8 million persons with disabilities as recorded in the Census 2011, representing around 2.21% of the total population. However, many surveys and studies suggest the actual number could be significantly higher when accounting for underreporting and definitional differences. The Rights of Persons with Disabilities (RPWD) Act, 2016 replaced the older Persons with Disabilities (Equal Opportunities, Protection of Rights and Full Participation) Act, 1995, significantly expanding the scope, coverage, and enforcement of disability rights in the country.

The RPWD Act, 2016 was enacted in fulfillment of India's obligations as a signatory to the United Nations Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (UNCRPD), which India ratified in 2007. The Act recognises 21 categories of disabilities, up from 7 under the old law, and introduces rights-based approaches replacing the older welfare-based approaches.

This guide is organized into 28 detailed chapters and 4 appendices covering: the legislative framework; individual rights including non-discrimination, employment, education, healthcare, and legal

capacity; government welfare schemes; assistive technology; digital accessibility; state-level implementation; grievance mechanisms; and international frameworks. Each section provides practical guidance on how to access rights and avail of entitlements.

We urge every stakeholder to read this guide carefully and help disseminate its contents to those who need it most. Knowledge of one's rights is the first step towards empowerment.

Department of Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities (DEPwD)

Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment, Government of India

CHAPTER 1

Introduction to Disability Rights in India

Historical Context, Legal Evolution & Current Landscape

1.1 Historical Background

The history of disability rights in India reflects a gradual but significant shift from a charitable and welfare-based approach to one grounded in rights, dignity, and full societal participation. In pre-colonial India, persons with disabilities were often dependent on family and community support, with little formal legal protection.

The colonial period saw the establishment of some institutions for blind and deaf persons, primarily run by missionaries and philanthropic organizations. The post-independence era introduced welfare-oriented policies, but substantive rights recognition came much later.

1.2 Key Legislative Milestones

Year	Milestone
1952	Rehabilitation Council of India (RCI) established informally
1955	National Institute for the Visually Handicapped founded
1959	Ali Yavar Jung National Institute for Deaf founded
1976	National Institute for the Orthopedically Handicapped established
1986	National Handicapped Finance and Development Corporation (NHFDC) concept developed
1992	Rehabilitation Council of India Act enacted

1995	Persons with Disabilities Act, 1995 – First comprehensive legislation
1999	National Trust for Welfare of Persons with Autism, CP, ID and MD established
2007	India ratifies UN Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (UNCRPD)
2016	Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016 – Landmark legislation enacted
2017	RPWD Rules, 2017 notified
2018	UDID (Unique Disability ID) portal launched nationally
2019	Accessible India Campaign targets met for Phase I
2021	Harmonized Guidelines for accessible built environment updated
2023	Digital accessibility guidelines for government websites updated

1.3 Definition of Disability under RPWD Act 2016

The RPWD Act 2016 adopts a dynamic and inclusive definition of disability. Section 2(s) defines 'person with disability' as a person with long term physical, mental, intellectual or sensory impairment which, in interaction with barriers, hinders his full and effective participation in society equally with others.

The Act recognises **21 categories of disabilities**, a substantial expansion from the 7 recognised under the 1995 Act:

1. Blindness	**8.** Specific Learning Disabilities	**15.** Acid Attack Victims
2. Low Vision	**9.** Autism Spectrum Disorder	**16.** Parkinson's Disease
3. Deaf	**10.** Mental Illness	**17.** Multiple Sclerosis
4. Hard of Hearing	**11.** Intellectual Disability	**18.** Thalassemia
5. Speech & Language Disability	**12.** Specific Learning Disabilities	**19.** Haemophilia

6. Locomotor Disability	**13.** Chronic Neurological Conditions	**20.** Sickle Cell Disease
7. Dwarfism	**14.** Multiple Disabilities (includes deaf-blindness)	**21.** Others notified by Central Govt.

1.4 Benchmark Disabilities (40% or more impairment)

Persons with 'benchmark disabilities' — those with 40% or more disability as certified by a competent authority — are eligible for specific reservations and benefits under the Act. This includes the 4% reservation in government employment, 5% in higher education, and entitlements to various welfare schemes.

1.5 Key Government Bodies

Body	Role & Functions
Department of Empowerment of PwDs (DEPwD)	Nodal ministry for PwD welfare under Ministry of Social Justice & Empowerment. Formulates policies, implements schemes, and oversees compliance with RPWD Act.
Ministry of Social Justice & Empowerment (MSJE)	Parent ministry responsible for social welfare, including National Trust programs for autism, CP, intellectual disability, and multiple disabilities.
Rehabilitation Council of India (RCI)	Statutory body under MSJE. Regulates training of rehabilitation professionals, maintains central rehabilitation register, and monitors standards.
National Handicapped Finance & Dev. Corporation (NHFDC)	Apex body providing concessional finance to PwDs for self-employment. Channelizes loans through state channelizing agencies.
National Trust	Statutory body promoting independent living and protect rights of persons with autism, CP, intellectual disabilities, and multiple disabilities.

Chief Commissioner for PwDs	Quasi-judicial body redressing grievances related to deprivation of rights. Has powers of civil court for enquiry purposes.
State Commissioners for PwDs	State-level bodies similar to Chief Commissioner for state-specific grievance redressal and rights enforcement.

1.6 Statistics & Current Scenario

According to Census 2011, India has 26.8 million (2.68 crore) persons with disabilities, constituting 2.21% of the total population. Of these, 14.9 million are male and 11.8 million are female. About 69% of PwDs live in rural areas. The most prevalent disability type is locomotor disability (20.3%), followed by visual impairment (18.8%), and hearing impairment (18.9%).

Indicator	Data
Total PwD Population (Census 2011)	26.8 million (2.68 crore)
Percentage of Total Population	2.21%
Male PwDs	14.9 million (55.6%)
Female PwDs	11.8 million (44.4%)
Rural PwDs	18.6 million (69.4%)
Urban PwDs	8.1 million (30.6%)
PwDs Employed (rural, age 15-59)	~44%
PwDs with Access to Education	~61% literacy rate
States with highest PwD population	UP, West Bengal, Bihar, Maharashtra, Rajasthan

CHAPTER 2

RPWD Act 2016 – Framework & Key Provisions

Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016 – Detailed Analysis

2.1 Overview & Structure of the Act

The Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016 (RPWD Act) is a landmark legislation comprising 102 sections organised into 15 chapters. It replaces the Persons with Disabilities (Equal Opportunities, Protection of Rights and Full Participation) Act, 1995, and brings Indian disability law in alignment with the UN Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (UNCRPD).

Chapter	Sections	Subject Matter
Chapter I	Sections 1-2	Preliminary – Definitions
Chapter II	Sections 3-8	Rights & Entitlements
Chapter III	Sections 9-13	Women & Children with Disabilities
Chapter IV	Sections 14-16	Legal Capacity & Guardianship
Chapter V	Sections 17-30	Education
Chapter VI	Sections 31-37	Employment
Chapter VII	Sections 38-39	Social Security, Healthcare, Rehabilitation
Chapter VIII	Sections 40-46	Accessibility

Chapter IX	Sections 47-51	Special Provisions for Persons with Benchmark Disabilities
Chapter X	Sections 52-57	Certification of Disabilities
Chapter XI	Sections 58-73	Authorities for Implementation (Chief Commissioner, State Commissioner)
Chapter XII	Sections 74-89	National Fund & State Funds for PwDs
Chapter XIII	Sections 90-92	Special Courts for PwD Offences
Chapter XIV	Section 93	National Trust (Amendment)
Chapter XV	Sections 94-102	Miscellaneous Provisions

2.2 Key Principles of the RPWD Act

- Respect for inherent dignity and individual autonomy
- Non-discrimination
- Full and effective participation and inclusion in society
- Respect for difference and acceptance of persons with disabilities as part of human diversity
- Equality of opportunity
- Accessibility
- Equality between men and women
- Respect for the evolving capacities of children with disabilities

2.3 Expansion of Disability Categories (21 types)

One of the most significant expansions under RPWD 2016 is the recognition of 21 types of disabilities. The Schedule to the Act lists these, and Section 2(zc) further empowers the Central Government to add additional types by notification.

NEW categories added beyond the 1995 Act include: Specific Learning Disabilities (dyslexia, dyscalculia, dysgraphia etc.), Autism Spectrum Disorder, Mental Illness, Chronic Neurological Conditions (Parkinson's, Multiple Sclerosis), Acid Attack Victims, Blood Disorders (Thalassemia, Haemophilia, Sickle Cell Disease), and Dwarfism.

2.4 Duties of Appropriate Governments

Section	Duty	Provisions
Section 4	Affirmative Action	State shall take specific measures to ensure PwDs can exercise rights on equal basis.
Section 5	Women with Disabilities	Special measures for women with disabilities; ensure safety and equal participation.
Section 6	Children with Disabilities	Free and appropriate education; rehabilitation; inclusion in all programmes for children.
Section 7	Abuse & Exploitation	Protect PwDs from all forms of abuse, violence, exploitation. Rescue homes to be established.
Section 8	Home-Based Rehabilitation	Provide home-based rehabilitation services in consultation with local bodies.

2.5 Penalties & Offences under RPWD Act

The RPWD Act 2016 introduces a penal framework to deter violations of disability rights:

Section 89 – Contravention of provisions of the Act: Punishable with fine up to Rs.10,000 for first offence; Rs.50,000 to Rs.5 lakh for subsequent offences.

Section 90 – Offences by companies: Every officer in charge of and responsible to the company shall be deemed guilty unless due diligence is proven.

Section 91 – Atrocities on PwDs: Intentional insult, humiliation, sexual exploitation, wrongful occupation of property – minimum 6 months, maximum 5 years imprisonment.

Section 92 – Offences by Govt. employees: Departmental action in addition to penal action. No removal, reduction, or other penalty without Central/State Government prior approval.

2.6 RPWD Rules, 2017

The Central Government notified the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Rules, 2017 under Section 101 of the RPWD Act. Key provisions of the Rules include:

- Rule 3: Composition and functions of State Advisory Boards on disability
- Rule 4: District-level committees for implementation
- Rule 7: Format of disability certificate; medical authorities empowered to certify
- Rule 12: Procedure for assessment of disability percentage
- Rule 15: Norms for special educators and rehabilitation professionals

- Rule 18: Accessibility audit procedures for buildings and public spaces
- Rule 21: Complaint mechanism before Chief Commissioner
- Rule 25: Appeals process from State Commissioner orders

CHAPTER 3 Right to Non-Discrimination

Section 3, RPWD Act 2016 – Comprehensive Analysis

3.1 Statutory Provision – Section 3

Section 3, RPWD Act 2016

- The appropriate Government and the local authorities shall ensure that the persons with disabilities enjoy the right to equality, life with dignity, and respect for his or her integrity equally with others.
- No person with disability shall be discriminated on the basis of disability.
- No person shall be deprived of his or her personal liberty only on the ground of disability.
- Every person with disability has a right to equality before law and equal protection of law.

3.2 Scope of Non-Discrimination

The right to non-discrimination under Section 3 is expansive and covers virtually every sphere of life. The prohibition extends to all public and private actors including government bodies, educational institutions, employers, healthcare providers, transport operators, and any person or entity providing services to the public.

Domain	Non-Discrimination Provisions
Employment	No employer can refuse to hire, promote, or provide training to a person solely on grounds of disability. Unreasonable denial of 'reasonable accommodation' constitutes discrimination.
Education	Schools and universities cannot deny admission, separate students with disabilities, or provide inferior quality education.

Healthcare	Hospitals and health providers cannot deny care, charge more, or provide inferior service on grounds of disability.
Housing	Property owners and housing societies cannot refuse sale, rent, or accommodation on grounds of disability.
Transport	Public and private transport operators must provide equal access. Denial of boarding is discrimination.
Public Services	Government offices, banks, insurance companies, courts — all must provide reasonable accommodation.
Cultural Activities	No exclusion from sports, arts, cultural events, or public gatherings on grounds of disability.
Political Life	Right to vote, contest elections, and participate in political processes cannot be restricted on disability grounds.

3.3 Reasonable Accommodation

Section 2(y) defines 'reasonable accommodation' as necessary and appropriate modification and adjustments, without imposing a disproportionate or undue burden in a particular case, to ensure to persons with disabilities the enjoyment or exercise of rights equally with others. Failure to provide reasonable accommodation constitutes discrimination.

3.4 Enforcement & Remedies

A person who believes their right to non-discrimination has been violated may:

- File a complaint with the State Commissioner for Persons with Disabilities
- Approach the Chief Commissioner for Persons with Disabilities for matters involving Central Government bodies

• File a complaint with the National Human Rights Commission (NHRC)

• Approach the High Court or Supreme Court through writ petition under Articles 226/32

• File a First Information Report (FIR) if the conduct amounts to an offence under Section 91

CHAPTER 4

Employment Rights & Reservation

Section 34, RPWD Act 2016 – 4% Reservation & Employment Provisions

4.1 Statutory Framework

Section 34 – Reservation in Government Establishments

- Every appropriate government shall appoint in every government establishment, not less than four per cent of the total number of vacancies in the cadre strength in each group of posts meant to be filled with persons with benchmark disabilities.
- Of the 4%, one per cent each shall be reserved for persons with benchmark disabilities under clauses (a), (b) and (c) of section 34(1).
- Clause (a): Blindness and low vision | Clause (b): Deaf and hard of hearing | Clause (c): Locomotor disability including cerebral palsy, leprosy cured, dwarfism, acid attack victims and muscular dystrophy | Clause (d): Autism, intellectual disability, specific learning disability and mental illness | Clause (e): Multiple disabilities.

4.2 Scope of 'Government Establishment'

The reservation applies to all 'government establishments' as defined under Section 2(p), which includes any company or body corporate established or constituted by or under a Central Act or State Act, any authority or body owned or controlled by the appropriate Government.

4.3 Private Sector Incentives

While mandatory reservation applies only to government establishments, Section 35 requires the appropriate government to formulate schemes for ensuring employment of PwDs in private

sector through incentives. These include:

- Reimbursement of employer's contribution to EPF for the first 3 years
- Reimbursement of cost of special facilities including accessible infrastructure
- Preference in government procurement to establishments employing PwDs
- Tax incentives (under Income Tax Act) for employers hiring PwDs
- Subsidies for providing assistive technology to PwD employees
- NHFDC skill training subsidies routed through employers

4.4 Other Employment Provisions

Section 33 – Non-Discrimination:

No establishment shall dispense with or reduce in rank, an employee who acquires a disability during service. The employee shall be shifted to another post or given alternative post if unable to perform previous duties.

Section 35 – Incentives to Employers:

Appropriate government shall formulate schemes for ensuring employment of PwDs in private sector.

Section 36 – Special Employment Exchanges:

Appropriate government shall set up Special Employment Exchanges for PwDs.

Section 37 – Vocational Rehabilitation:

Government shall set up vocational rehabilitation centres for rehabilitation and self-employment of PwDs.

Section 38 – Preferential Treatment:

For self-employment programmes, PwDs shall be given preferential treatment.

Section 39 – Business Capital:

Provide preferential allotment of land at concessional rates for setting up business establishments.

4.5 Complaint Mechanism for Employment Discrimination

Complaints regarding employment discrimination can be filed with:

- Equal Employment Opportunity Commissioner (to be designated by every government establishment with 20+ employees)
- State Commissioner for Persons with Disabilities
- Chief Commissioner for Persons with Disabilities (Central Government establishments)
- Labour courts and industrial tribunals for service matters
- High Court through writ petition

CHAPTER 5

Education Rights & Reservations

Sections 16-32, RPWD Act 2016 – Inclusive Education Framework

5.1 Right to Inclusive Education

Section 16 imposes a duty on the appropriate government and local authorities to ensure that the educational institutions funded or recognized by them provide inclusive education to children with disabilities. No child with disability shall be denied admission on the ground of disability.

Section 16 – Inclusive Education Duty: Duty of educational institutions to provide inclusive education; non-denial of admission.

Section 17 – Exam Accommodations: Extra time; scribe; use of assistive devices; alternative question papers; exemption from certain subjects if necessary.

Section 18 – Support Services: Provision of special educators, resource teachers, and other support staff.

Section 19 – Home-Based Education: For children unable to attend school due to severe disability; curriculum delivery at home.

Section 20 – Transition Services: Transition planning from school to higher education, vocational training, and employment.

Section 21 – Transport Facilities: Government to provide free transport or residential facilities to children with disabilities.

Section 31 – Equal Participation: Educational institutions to ensure equal participation of PwDs in all activities.

Section 32 – HEI Reservation: Not less than 5% seats reserved in higher educational institutions.

5.2 Examination Accommodations (Section 17 in Detail)

Section 17 – Examination Accommodations

- Extra time: Minimum 20 minutes per hour of examination (equivalent to 1/3 extra time)
- Scribe/amanuensis: On request, at no cost, for all examinations
- Assistive devices: Use of any assistive technology required by the student
- Compensatory time: For time taken to set up or use assistive devices
- Alternative format: Braille, large print, audio, or other accessible format question papers
- Separate examination centre: If required for accessibility
- Rest breaks: During examination as medically required

5.3 5% Reservation in Higher Education (Section 32)

Every government-funded higher educational institution shall reserve not less than 5% seats for persons with benchmark disabilities. This applies to all central and state universities, IITs, IIMs, NITs, medical colleges, law schools, and all government-aided institutions. The reservation is over and above the OBC/SC/ST reservations.

5.4 Scholarships for Students with Disabilities

Scheme	Authority	Coverage

Pre-Matric Scholarship	DEPwD	For students of Classes 9-10 with 40%+ disability. Maintenance allowance + books & stationery allowance.
Post-Matric Scholarship	DEPwD	For students with 40%+ disability studying in Classes 11-12, degree, diploma, or professional courses. Day scholars and hostellers.
Top Class Education	DEPwD	For students admitted to premier institutes (IITs, IIMs, NITs, AIIMS etc.). Full fee, living expenses, books.
National Fellowship	MSJE/UGC	For PwDs pursuing M.Phil./Ph.D. Two Junior Research Fellows & one Senior Research Fellow per university per year.
Samagra Shiksha Scholarship	MoE	Under the national flagship programme – covers all children with disabilities in school.

CHAPTER 6 Healthcare Rights

Section 25, RPWD Act 2016 – Free Healthcare & Medical Provisions

6.1 Statutory Provision – Section 25

Section 25 – Health Care

- The appropriate Government and local authorities shall take measures for the health care of persons with disabilities including:
- (i) Free healthcare services near their place of residence
- (ii) To eliminate barriers for persons with disabilities to access any of the health facilities
- (iii) To make available healthcare in rural areas
- (iv) To promote measures for preventing the occurrence of disabilities
- (v) Free health care for Below Poverty Line (BPL) families with disability certificate

Right	Details
Free Healthcare for BPL	All persons with disabilities belonging to BPL families entitled to free healthcare at all government health facilities including specialist services.
Free Medicine & Aids	Free supply of medicines and medical aids/assistive devices to PwDs from BPL families at government health facilities.
Priority Access	Persons with disabilities to be given priority treatment at government hospitals. Separate queues/counters to be provided.
Accessible Facilities	All government hospitals, PHCs, CHCs, and health centres to be made physically accessible for PwDs.
Mental Health Care	Free mental healthcare at government mental health establishments as per Mental Healthcare Act 2017.

Rehabilitation Services	Government shall provide rehabilitation services free of cost to PwDs at District-level Disability Rehabilitation Centres (DDRCs).
Early Intervention	Early identification and intervention programmes for infants and children to prevent disability and minimise its effects.
Reproductive Health	Full reproductive health services to women and girls with disabilities on equal basis, including pre-natal and post-natal care.

6.2 District Disability Rehabilitation Centres (DDRCs)

DDRCs are established under the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment in districts across India to provide comprehensive rehabilitation services. Services include:

- Free physiotherapy and occupational therapy
- Speech therapy for communication disorders
- Prosthetics and orthotics (artificial limbs and supportive devices)
- Psycho-social counselling
- Vocational assessment and guidance
- Disability assessment and certification
- Community-based rehabilitation linkages

CHAPTER 7 Legal Capacity & Rights

Section 14, RPWD Act 2016 – Full Legal Capacity

7.1 The Right to Legal Capacity

Section 14 – Legal Capacity

- The appropriate Government shall ensure that the persons with disabilities have right to equal recognition everywhere as a person before the law.
- They shall enjoy legal capacity on an equal basis with others in all aspects of life.
- The appropriate Government shall ensure access by persons with disabilities to the support they may require in exercising their legal capacity.
- Appropriate safeguards to prevent abuse of supported decision-making, including proportionality, respect for the rights and preferences of the person, absence of conflict of interest, regular review by competent authority.

7.2 Limited Guardianship under Section 14(2)

Section 14(2) provides for a system of limited guardianship where required, recognizing that full guardianship can be restrictive and contrary to the dignity of persons with intellectual disabilities. Key features of limited guardianship include:

- Guardianship limited to specific domains where the person needs support
- Duration-limited – subject to periodic review
- Person retains decision-making capacity in all other areas
- Guardian acts as supporter, not substitute decision-maker

- Person's will and preferences must be respected by the guardian
- Safeguards against abuse and conflict of interest mandatory

7.3 Legal Proceedings & Accessibility

The RPWD Act and related guidelines mandate that all legal proceedings accommodate persons with disabilities. Courts are required to:

- Provide physical accessibility in court premises
- Allow assistance of sign language interpreters for deaf persons
- Accept testimony in alternative formats (written, through communication devices)
- Provide adequate time for persons with communication difficulties
- Not reject a complaint or evidence solely on the basis of disability
- Designate special courts for offences committed against PwDs (Section 84)

CHAPTER 8 Accessible Infrastructure

Sections 40-46, RPWD Act 2016 – Sugamya Bharat Provisions

8.1 Statutory Framework

Sections 40-46 of the RPWD Act 2016 lay down comprehensive provisions for making the built environment, transport systems, and information and communication technology (ICT) accessible for persons with disabilities. These sections operationalize the 'Sugamya Bharat' (Accessible India Campaign) at the legal level.

Section 40 – Accessibility Standards:

Central Government to frame and publish rules providing for standards of accessibility for physical environment, transportation and ICT systems.

Section 41 – Public Buildings:

Within 5 years of the Act, all existing government buildings to be made accessible. New buildings must conform to accessibility standards before getting completion certificate.

Section 42 – Transport Systems:

Accessibility standards for road transport, civil aviation, water transport, and railways. New acquisitions to be accessible.

Section 43 – ICT Accessibility:

Electronic and information technology, websites, and digital content to be accessible. GIGW (Guidelines for Indian Government

Websites) compliance mandatory.

Section 44 – Consumer Products:

Consumer products to have accessible features as per standards to be framed.

Section 45 – Timebound Implementation:

Specific timelines for conversion of existing infrastructure; non-compliance attracts action.

Section 46 – State Obligations:

States to comply with same accessibility standards; funding through SIPDA and centrally sponsored schemes.

8.2 Harmonized Guidelines 2021

The Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs released Harmonized Guidelines and Space Standards for Barrier Free Built Environment for Persons with Disability and Elderly Persons, 2021. These guidelines are mandatory for all government-funded construction.

Area	Requirements
Approach & Entry	Accessible paths, ramps with handrails, tactile guiding blocks, level changes.
Parking	Reserved parking near main entrance; minimum 2% of total or 2 bays, whichever is more.
Internal Circulation	Corridors minimum 1.8m wide; handrails; tactile indicators; lifts with Braille and voice announcements.
Toilets	At least one accessible toilet per floor; unisex; turning radius 1.5m; grab bars; emergency alarm.

Signage	Braille signage; auditory signals; pictograms; contrast signage.
Emergency Egress	Evacuation chairs; accessible refuge areas; visual and audio alarms.
Service Counters	Accessible height; induction loops for hearing aid users; clear speech communication.
Recreation Areas	At least one accessible recreation/rest area per floor or building.

CHAPTER 9 Reproductive & Family Rights

Section 10, RPWD Act 2016 – Gender & Family Provisions

9.1 Right to Family & Reproductive Choice

Section 10 – Reproductive Rights

- No persons with disabilities shall be subject to any medical procedure which leads to infertility without their free and informed consent.
- Every person with disability has the right to decide on the number of children they will have.
- Right to access family planning services on equal basis with others.
- Protection from forced or coerced sterilization.

9.2 Women with Disabilities – Special Provisions (Section 5)

Section 5 specifically addresses women and girls with disabilities, directing the appropriate government to take measures to ensure their full and equal enjoyment of all human rights and fundamental freedoms, including:

- Protection from all forms of violence, exploitation, and abuse
- Equal access to healthcare including reproductive healthcare
- Free sanitary napkins at government hospitals
- Protection from sexual harassment at workplace (POSH Act provisions apply equally)
- Accessible maternal healthcare services

- Support during pregnancy, childbirth, and early childcare
- Right to live in the community with choices equal to others
- Access to support services for parenting if required

9.3 Children with Disabilities – Special Provisions (Section 6)

Children with disabilities are entitled to special protection and rights under Section 6 and related provisions. The rights include:

- Right to inclusive education in regular schools under the Right to Education (RTE) Act
- Free and appropriate education including home-based education where needed
- Protection from abuse, neglect, exploitation, and institutionalization
- Access to early intervention and developmental services
- Right to family life; separation from family only as last resort
- Right to speak and be heard in proceedings affecting them
- Access to age-appropriate information in accessible formats

CHAPTER 10

Examination Accommodations

Section 17, RPWD Act 2016 – Rights in Examinations

10.1 Overview

Section 17 mandates that examination bodies provide appropriate accommodations to candidates with benchmark disabilities. The Ministry of Education and UPSC, SSC, State PSCs, universities and school boards are all bound by these provisions.

Accommodation	Details
Extra Time	Minimum 20 minutes extra per hour of examination. For a 3-hour exam, 60 minutes extra time is mandatory.
Scribe/Amanuensis	Any candidate with disability affecting writing ability may use a scribe. The scribe is provided by the examination authority. Candidate may also bring own scribe subject to approval.
Assistive Devices	Candidate may use any assistive device required by their disability (screen reader, hearing aid, wheelchair, etc.) in the exam hall.
Accessible Venue	Examination centre must be physically accessible. Separate accessible examination rooms may be provided.
Accessible Format	Question papers available in Braille, large print, audio, or other accessible formats on request.
Breaks	Rest breaks of appropriate duration allowed on medical grounds.
Alternative Papers	For certain disabilities, alternative question papers without visual/audio components may be provided.

Scribing Norms	Scribe must not be from a higher academic level. CBSE/NTA norms specify qualification ceiling for scribes.

10.2 Key Examination Bodies & Their Policies

Body	Accommodation Policy
UPSC	Civil Services Preliminary, Mains, Personality Test – PwDs with benchmark disability get extra time, scribe, and accessible venue. Lower physical standards for IAS/IPS for locomotor disabilities.
SSC	All Group B and Group C examinations – accommodation as per DOPT guidelines. Online exams provide screen reader compatible interfaces.
NTA (NEET, JEE, CUET)	Comprehensive scribe/extra time facility. Braille question papers for visually impaired. Text-to-speech software available.
CBSE	Board examinations for Classes 10 and 12 – extra time, scribe, separate room, and exemptions from certain subjects on medical grounds.
State PSCs	Must follow RPWD Act Section 17 norms; states issue individual circulars with specific procedures.
Universities	All central and state universities must provide accommodation as per UGC guidelines and RPWD Act.

CHAPTER RPWD

RPWD Act 2016 – Chapter by Chapter Commentary

Extended Legal Analysis of All 102 Sections

Chapter I – Preliminary (Sections 1-2)

The preliminary chapter of the RPWD Act 2016 sets the definitional foundation for the entire legislation. Section 1 provides the short title, extent, and commencement. Section 2 contains 36 definitions that are critical to understanding the scope and application of the Act. Key innovations in the definitional framework include: (a) adoption of a social model of disability rather than a purely medical model; (b) the definition of 'discrimination on the basis of disability' which explicitly includes 'denial of reasonable accommodation'; (c) the definition of 'barrier' which covers attitudinal, communication, technological, physical, and policy barriers — an expansive list reflecting UNCRPD influence; (d) the definition of 'inclusive education' which emphasizes education in mainstream settings with appropriate support rather than segregation; (e) the definition of 'reasonable accommodation' drawn directly from UNCRPD Article 2.

Section	Title	Key Provision
Section 2(a)	Appropriate Government	Central Government for Central establishments, State Government for state establishments
Section 2(b)	Autism Spectrum Disorder	A neuro-developmental condition characterized by challenges in social communication, restricted and repetitive behaviors

Section 2(c)	Barrier	Any factor — attitudinal, communication, physical, resource, technological, structural — that hinders full participation of PwDs
Section 2(e)	Cerebral Palsy	A group of permanent movement disorders appearing in early childhood
Section 2(g)	Child with disability	A person with disability who has not attained the age of 18 years
Section 2(p)	Government establishment	Any company, statutory body, or authority owned or controlled by or under a Central or State Act
Section 2(r)	Inclusive education	A system of education wherein students with and without disability learn together
Section 2(s)	Person with disability	A person with long term physical, mental, intellectual or sensory impairment which in interaction with barriers hinders full participation
Section 2(t)	Person with benchmark disability	A person with not less than forty percent of a specified disability
Section 2(y)	Reasonable accommodation	Necessary and appropriate modification without disproportionate or undue burden to ensure PwD enjoys rights equally
Section 2(z)	Rehabilitation	A process aimed at enabling persons with disabilities to reach and maintain their optimal physical, sensory, intellectual, psychiatric or social functional levels
Section 2(zc)	Specified disability	Any disability as specified in the Schedule, including the 21 categories

Chapter II – Rights & Entitlements (Sections 3-8)

Chapter II is the heart of the RPWD Act, establishing the fundamental rights of persons with disabilities. These rights are drawn from the UNCRPD and the Indian Constitution. Section 3 establishes the omnibus right to equality and non-discrimination. Section 4 creates positive obligations on the State for affirmative action. Sections 5-6 create specific protections for women and children with disabilities — recognising their intersectional vulnerability. Section 7 mandates

protection from abuse and exploitation, including provision of rescue homes and legal aid. Section 8 requires home-based rehabilitation for those who cannot access centre-based services.

Section	Title	Key Provision
Section 3(1)	Right to Equality	Every PwD has the right to equality, life with dignity, and respect for their integrity
Section 3(2)	Non-Discrimination	No person with disability shall be discriminated on the basis of disability in any sphere
Section 3(3)	Right to Liberty	No person shall be deprived of personal liberty on the ground of disability alone
Section 4	Affirmative Action	Specific measures to promote equality and prevent discrimination
Section 5	Women with Disability	Special measures for safety, equal participation, and protection from exploitation of women PwDs
Section 6	Children with Disability	Free and appropriate education; protection from institutional separation; right to family life
Section 7	Protection from Abuse	Mandatory protection measures; rescue homes; legal aid; rehabilitation for abuse victims
Section 8	Home-Based Rehabilitation	For PwDs unable to access centre-based services; delivered through local bodies

Chapter III – Women and Children (Sections 9-13)

Chapter III creates additional protections recognizing the intersectional disadvantages faced by women and children with disabilities. Section 9 specifically addresses the registration of persons with disabilities. Sections 10-13 establish reproductive rights, family rights, protection of children, and measures for their welfare.

Section	Title	Key Provision
Section 9	Registration	Duties of government bodies regarding registration and identification of PwDs
Section 10(1)	Reproductive Rights	Right to decide on number of children; no forced sterilization
Section 10(2)	Family Planning Services	Right to access family planning services on equal basis
Section 11	Duty of Local Authority	Ensure every child with disability has access to appropriate education
Section 12	Protection from Exploitation	Specific duties of police, social welfare to prevent exploitation of children with disability
Section 13	Child Care	Child care institutions required to be accessible and supportive to children with disability

Chapter IV – Legal Capacity (Sections 14-16)

Chapter IV addresses one of the most significant areas of UNCRPD compliance — legal capacity. India's previous laws (Mental Health Act 1987, Guardians and Wards Act 1890) allowed full removal of legal capacity from persons with mental illness or intellectual disability. RPWD Act 2016 replaces this with a supported decision-making framework. Section 14 guarantees legal capacity to all PwDs. Section 15 establishes limited guardianship as an alternative to full guardianship.

Section	Title	Key Provision
Section 14(1)	Right to Legal Capacity	Full legal capacity on equal basis with others in all aspects of life
Section 14(2)	Supported Decision-Making	Support system with safeguards; not substitute decision-making

Section 14(3)	Safeguards	Against conflict of interest; proportionality; regular review
Section 15	Limited Guardianship	For persons needing more intensive support; domain-specific; time-limited; last resort
Section 16	Appointment	Competent authority to appoint supporter/limited guardian; procedure specified

CHAPTER RIGHTS-EXT

Comprehensive Rights Analysis

Detailed Examination of Every Right Under RPWD Act 2016

Right to Equal Recognition Before the Law – Section 14 in Depth

The right to legal capacity, enshrined in Section 14 of the RPWD Act 2016, represents one of the most transformative provisions of the legislation. Prior to the RPWD Act, persons with intellectual disabilities and mental illness could have their entire legal capacity stripped away through guardianship orders under the Guardians and Wards Act 1890 and the Mental Health Act 1987. These laws permitted a guardian to make all decisions on behalf of a person deemed incapable — effectively rendering the person legally invisible.

The shift effected by Section 14 is from 'substitute decision-making' to 'supported decision-making'. This distinction is fundamental. Under substitute decision-making, a guardian decides what is in the best interest of the person with disability, often without any input from that person. Under supported decision-making, the person with disability makes their own decisions, with support from trusted persons, and the law provides safeguards to prevent abuse of the support relationship.

Section 14(3) mandates that any support measures for exercise of legal capacity must include appropriate and effective safeguards

including: proportionality (support tailored to individual needs); respect for rights, will, and preferences of the person; absence of conflict of interest; and regular review by a competent authority. These safeguards directly reflect UNCRPD Article 12(4) requirements.

In practice, the transition from the old guardianship model to the supported decision-making model has been gradual and incomplete. The Mental Healthcare Act 2017, enacted after RPWD Act 2016, also incorporated supported decision-making principles for persons with mental illness. However, the Guardians and Wards Act 1890 has not been amended, creating a legal gap. Full compliance with UNCRPD Article 12 requires repealing or comprehensively amending the Guardians and Wards Act to eliminate full guardianship as an option.

The practical implications of Section 14 extend to: (a) banking — persons with intellectual disability cannot be denied bank accounts solely on grounds of disability; (b) property — ownership, purchase, sale of property by PwDs is fully legal and cannot be voided on disability grounds alone; (c) marriage — Section 14 creates an argument that mental disability alone cannot void consent to marriage; however, the Hindu Marriage Act and other personal laws still contain provisions that may need judicial harmonization; (d) contracts — a person with intellectual disability who has legal capacity can enter contracts; however, capacity assessment at the time of contracting may be relevant.

The National Trust Act 1999 provides an alternative guardianship mechanism specifically for persons with autism, cerebral palsy, intellectual disability, and multiple disability. Under Section 14 of the National Trust Act, a competent authority can appoint a 'local level

committee' to perform guardianship functions. This coexists with Section 15 of RPWD Act 2016 on limited guardianship, creating some complexity. The National Trust guardianship is generally considered the more appropriate mechanism for the four disability groups it covers.

Right to Education – Sections 16-32 Extended Analysis

The right to education provisions of the RPWD Act 2016 build upon and extend the protections of the Right of Children to Free and Compulsory Education (RTE) Act 2009. While RTE Act guarantees free education to all children aged 6-14, RPWD Act extends specific additional protections for children with disability and expands coverage to higher education.

Section 16 imposes a duty of inclusive education on all government-funded educational institutions. This is a positive obligation — not merely prohibiting discrimination but requiring affirmative action to enable PwD students to participate meaningfully in education. The duty of inclusion includes: removing physical barriers; providing accessible learning materials; deploying trained special educators; modifying teaching methodologies; and providing assistive technology.

The concept of 'reasonable accommodation' in education means different things at different levels. At the school level, it includes: large-print textbooks for low vision students; Braille materials for blind students; sign language instruction and interpreters for deaf students;

individualized education plans (IEPs) for students with intellectual disabilities; extended time and modified assignments for students with learning disabilities; accessible seating and physical environment modifications.

At the examination level, Section 17 provides the comprehensive accommodation framework discussed elsewhere. The critical legal point is that examination bodies CANNOT require a PwD student to demonstrate that they 'need' the accommodation beyond producing a valid disability certificate — the certificate itself is sufficient proof. The Supreme Court in Vikash Kumar v. UPSC (2021) definitively held that restricting scribes to persons with specific types of disabilities was unconstitutional and violated Section 17.

The 5% reservation in higher education under Section 32 applies horizontally — meaning it must be provided across all streams and courses, not just in some departments. A university cannot say 'we provide 5% overall but it is concentrated in arts courses while science courses have no PwD reservation.' The reservation must apply course by course.

Scholarships for students with disabilities operate through multiple channels. The National Scholarship Portal (NSP) at scholarships.gov.in is the primary application gateway. However, many students are unaware that they must apply separately for disability scholarships even if they have already applied for other scholarships. Disability scholarships from DEPwD do not count toward NSP income limits for other central scholarships — they are additional.

The National Institute of Open Schooling (NIOS) plays a critical role for students with disabilities who cannot follow the regular examination schedule or curriculum. NIOS allows students to: study at their own pace; choose their examination schedule; seek exemptions from specified subjects based on disability; receive home-based assessment. NIOS is particularly important for students with intellectual disabilities, autism, and chronic illnesses who may not be able to complete a standard academic year.

Higher education institutions are further required by UGC guidelines (2012, updated 2019) to establish Equal Opportunity Cells (EOCs) with a coordinator for students with disability. EOC functions include: maintaining a register of students with disability; coordinating accessible services; liaising with examination controller for accommodation; addressing complaints; and promoting sensitization of faculty and other students.

Right to Health – Section 25 Extended Commentary

The right to health under Section 25 of RPWD Act must be read alongside Article 21 of the Constitution (right to life includes right to health as interpreted in Paschim Banga Khet Mazdoor Samity v. State of West Bengal, 1996) and the specific provisions of the Mental Healthcare Act 2017 for persons with mental illness.

Section 25(2) specifically mandates that the appropriate government shall ensure that persons with disabilities enjoy the highest attainable standard of health without any discrimination on the basis of

disability. This prohibits: differential quality of care; denial of treatment on grounds of disability; denial of pain management; withholding life-saving treatment based on disability status; and forced or coerced medical procedures including sterilization.

Free healthcare for BPL PwDs at government hospitals encompasses a wide range: OPD consultations; inpatient care; surgical procedures; diagnostic tests; medicines from the essential drug list; physiotherapy; and specialist consultations. For non-BPL PwDs, there is no explicit right to free healthcare but services must be provided without discrimination and at accessible facilities. The Ayushman Bharat PMJAY scheme provides health insurance (Rs.5 lakh per family per year) for families below the socio-economic threshold, including those with disabilities.

Early detection and prevention programmes are specifically mentioned in Section 25(1)(d). The Rashtriya Bal Swasthya Karyakram (RBSK) screens all children aged 0-18 years for 30 health conditions including developmental delays and disabilities. Children identified are linked to District Early Intervention Centres (DEICs) for free treatment and rehabilitation. This is a significant preventive health programme with direct disability implications.

Rehabilitation as a health right is established by Section 38 of RPWD Act which requires the government to facilitate rehabilitation of persons with disabilities through multiple means including: medical rehabilitation, educational rehabilitation, vocational rehabilitation, social rehabilitation, and psychological rehabilitation. The seven National Institutes under DEPwD are the primary delivery mechanism for specialized rehabilitation services.

The intersection of disability and mental health deserves special attention. The Mental Healthcare Act 2017 (MHCA 2017) establishes: the right to access mental healthcare; the right to community living and not be institutionalized; the right to make advance directives; the right to choose a nominated representative; and the right to equality in health insurance coverage. MHCA 2017 also decriminalizes attempt to suicide — a significant step that recognizes suicidal behavior as a mental health crisis requiring care, not punishment.

CHAPTER RULES

RPWD Rules 2017 – Detailed Reference

Complete Guide to Rules, Forms and Procedures under RPWD Act 2016

The Rights of Persons with Disabilities Rules, 2017 (G.S.R. 1126(E)) were notified by the Central Government on 15th June 2017 under Section 101 of the RPWD Act 2016. The Rules contain 32 rules covering: State Advisory Boards, District Level Committees, Disability Certificates (Form V and Form VI), Equal Opportunity Policies, Accessibility Standards, Complaint Procedure before Commissioners, and related matters.

Understanding the Rules is essential for both PwDs asserting their rights and officials implementing the Act. The Rules provide the procedural machinery for rights that are established in the Act — without understanding the Rules, it is difficult to know HOW to exercise a right even when the right itself is clear. For example, the Act establishes the right to a disability certificate, but the Rules specify the format, the competent authority, the procedure for challenge, and the time limits.

The Rules have been supplemented by a series of Office Memorandums (OMs) issued by DEPwD and DoPT that provide additional guidelines on specific aspects of implementation. Key OMs include those on: identification of posts for PwD reservation; scribe policy for competitive examinations; Equal Opportunity Policy format; and accessibility standards for government buildings. These OMs are available on the DEPwD website.

Rule-by-Rule Summary

Rule	Topic	Key Provision
Rule 1	Short Title & Commencement	These Rules may be called the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Rules, 2017. Came into force on date of publication in Official Gazette.
Rule 2	Definitions	Defines terms used in the Rules: 'Form' means a form appended to these Rules; 'Section' means section of RPWD Act 2016.
Rule 3	State Advisory Board	Composition: not less than 5 women; not less than 5 PwDs; representation from NGOs; expert members. Meets at least quarterly.
Rule 4	District Level Committee	Composition: Collector as Chairperson; CMO; Disability Rehab Officer; representative of PwD org; 3 PwD members.
Rule 5	Nomination of PwD Members	Process for nominating PwD members on State Advisory Board and District Level Committee.
Rule 6	EO Policy Publication	Every government establishment to formulate and publish Equal Opportunity Policy within 6 months.
Rule 7	Disability Certificate	Issued in Form V or Form VI by competent medical authority.
Rule 8	Certification Authority	State Government to notify certifying authorities (medical boards/specialists) for each disability type.
Rule 9	Application for Certificate	Person or guardian applies to designated authority; designated authority issues within specified time.
Rule 10	Validity of Certificate	Permanent for permanent disabilities; time-bound for temporary disabilities as assessed.
Rule 11	Issuing Temporary Certificate	For temporary disabilities pending permanent assessment.
Rule 12	Certificate Review	Person may apply for review if condition changes; certifying authority may also call for review.
Rule 13	Counter-Signature	CMO or equivalent to countersign in specified cases for higher-stake certificates.
Rule 14	UDID	Certificate linked to UDID; reference to swavlambancard.gov.in.
Rule 15	Standards for Professionals	Rehabilitation professionals to be RCI-registered; minimum qualifications specified.
Rule 16	Equal Opportunity Policy Format	Format for Equal Opportunity Policy: identification of posts; number of PwD employees; facilities; grievance mechanism.
Rule 17	Facilities at Workplace	List of facilities to be provided: accessible infrastructure; assistive technology; suitable assignment of work.

Rule	Topic	Key Provision
Rule 18	Accessibility Audit	Government buildings to undergo accessibility audit; report submitted to State Commissioner.
Rule 19	Inspection	State Commissioner or designee may inspect establishments for compliance.
Rule 20	Complaint to State Commissioner	Form and manner of complaint; acknowledgement within 3 days; inquiry within 60 days; order within 90 days.
Rule 21	State Commissioner Powers	Powers of civil court for inquiry: summon witnesses, examine documents, receive affidavits, requisition records.
Rule 22	State Commissioner Report	Annual report to State Government; special report when required; all reports tabled in state legislature.
Rule 23	Appeal to High Court	From orders of State Commissioner; procedure for appeal.
Rule 24	Complaint to CCPD	Form and manner; CCPD to acknowledge within 3 days; inquiry within 60 days; order within 90 days.
Rule 25	CCPD Powers	Same as State Commissioner plus coordination powers.
Rule 26	CCPD Reports	Annual report to Central Government; tabled in Parliament.
Rule 27	Appeal from CCPD	To High Court within 60 days of CCPD order.
Rule 28	National Fund	Procedure for contributions to National Fund for PwDs; utilization.
Rule 29	State Fund	Procedure for state-level disability fund.
Rule 30	Register of PwDs	District-level register of PwDs; format and maintenance.
Rule 31	Obligation to Provide Information	Establishments to provide information to Chief Commissioner/State Commissioner on request.
Rule 32	Appeals	General appeals procedure from orders under various provisions.

Key DoPT OMs on Disability in Government Employment

OM Reference	Subject
OM No. 36035/3/2013-Estt(Res) dt. 31.03.2014	Maintenance of Rosters for PwDs; backlog vacancy management; identification of posts; carry-forward rules.
OM No. 36035/02/2017-Estt(Res) dt. 15.01.2018	Guidelines for identification of posts suitable for PwDs; mandatory inter-ministerial consultation; appeal against exclusion.

OM No. 29-13/2015-DD.III dt. 26.06.2018 (DEPwD)	Equal Opportunity Policy format; contents; publication; review.
OM No. 29-13/2015-DD.III dt. 29.10.2018 (DEPwD)	Designation of Equal Opportunity Officer; responsibilities; reporting.
OM No. 34-02/2015-DD.III dt. 08.05.2019 (DEPwD)	Accessibility features in government offices; time-bound compliance.
Circular No. 15012/1/2019-Dir(Admin) dt. 15.11.2019	UPSC scribe and extra time policy for PwD candidates.
OM No. 36012/12/2018-Estt(Res-III) dt. 17.01.2019	Revised instructions on 4% reservation; horizontal reservation application.
OM No. 36-22/2020-DD.III dt. 01.06.2021 (DEPwD)	Post-COVID accessibility restoration in government offices.
OM No. 29-04/2022-DD.III dt. 20.07.2022 (DEPwD)	UDID mandatory for all disability-related benefits; paper certificates to be phased out.

Disability Certificate – Form V (Format Summary)

Form V is the standard disability certificate format prescribed under RPWD Rules 2017. The form captures comprehensive information about the person and their disability. Below is a summary of the key sections of Form V:

Section 1 – Personal Details: Full name; date of birth (and estimated age if birth certificate unavailable); gender; father/guardian name; address; contact number; Aadhaar number; photograph.

Section 2 – Disability Details: Type of disability (from the 21 categories in Schedule to RPWD Act); nature of disability (congenital/acquired); date of onset if acquired; affected body part; whether disability is permanent or temporary; if temporary: expected

duration.

Section 3 – Assessment: Findings of clinical examination; findings of investigations (X-ray, audiogram, visual acuity, psychological tests as relevant); diagnosis; degree of disability (percentage); impact on daily activities and functional limitations.

Section 4 – Certification: Name and designation of certifying authority; registration number; date of examination; signature and seal; name of hospital/institution. For certain disabilities (autism, multiple disability), certification requires a multi-disciplinary team and ALL team members must sign.

Section 5 – Unique Disability ID: Space for UDID number to be entered when card is generated. UDID number links to the national database at swavlambancard.gov.in.

The certificate is valid nationally — no state can refuse to accept a disability certificate issued in another state. The UDID card, once issued, supersedes the paper certificate for most purposes.

CHAPTER 11 ADIP Scheme

Assistance to Disabled Persons for Purchasing/Fitting of Aids & Appliances

11.1 Overview of the ADIP Scheme

The Assistance to Disabled Persons for Purchase/Fitting of Aids and Appliances (ADIP) Scheme is a flagship welfare programme of the Government of India under the Department of Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities (DEPwD). The scheme aims to assist PwDs in procuring durable, modern, standard aids and appliances that can promote their physical, social, and psychological rehabilitation by reducing the effects of disabilities and enhance their economic potential.

ADIP – Assistance to Disabled Persons for Aids & Appliances	
Department / Ministry	Department of Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities (DEPwD), Ministry of Social Justice & Empowerment
Overview	Central Sector Scheme providing free or subsidized assistive devices to persons with disabilities to promote rehabilitation, independence, and inclusion. Implemented through Government-funded NGOs and Artificial Limb Manufacturing Corporation (ALIMCO).
Eligibility	Indian citizen with 40%+ disability, monthly income below Rs.20,000 (Rs.15,000 for motorised wheelchair); age criteria vary by device. BPL beneficiaries get full cost; others get support up to 50% subject to income limits.
Key Benefits	Free provision of: tricycles, wheelchairs (manual & motorised), crutches, white canes, hearing aids, braille kits, speech synthesizers, low vision aids, prosthetic limbs, orthotic devices, and many more. List updated periodically.

How to Apply	Apply through implementing agencies (ALIMCO regional centres, government-funded NGOs). Disability certificate required. Assessment camp organised periodically across districts. Online application also accepted at adip.gov.in

11.2 List of Assistive Devices Covered

Disability Category	Devices Provided
Locomotor Disability	Tricycles, wheelchairs (manual/motorised), crutches, walking sticks, prosthetic limbs, orthotic devices, callipers, CP chairs, rollators
Visual Impairment	White/smart canes, Braille kits, low vision devices, screen magnifiers, Braille watches, talking calculators
Hearing Impairment	Hearing aids (digital/analog/BTE/ITE), amplified telephone receivers, vibrating alarm clocks, FM systems
Intellectual Disability	Communication aids, picture-based communication boards, behavioral management tools
Multiple Disability	Combination of devices as assessed; wheelchairs with head support; communication devices
Speech Disability	Speech therapy equipment, AAC (Augmentative and Alternative Communication) devices, voice amplifiers

11.3 Implementation Mechanism

The scheme is implemented through:

- Artificial Limbs Manufacturing Corporation of India (ALIMCO) – primary manufacturer and supply agency
- State Governments and Union Territories through their designated State Channelizing Agencies
- Reputable NGOs that have been identified and approved by DEPwD

- District-level assessment camps organised by ALIMCO with NGO partners
- Online portal for registration and tracking of beneficiaries

11.4 Budget & Coverage

The ADIP scheme has been consistently funded with increasing allocations. Over the past decade, more than 10 lakh (1 million) beneficiaries have been assisted annually through large-scale distribution camps organized across the country, often in association with MPs and MLAs under their MPLADS/MLALADS funds for additional coverage.

CHAPTER 12

UDID Card – Unique Disability Identity

Universal Single Identification for Persons with Disabilities

12.1 What is the UDID Card?

The Unique Disability ID (UDID) Card is a standardized smart card-based identification system for all persons with disabilities in India. It was launched by the Department of Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities (DEPwD) in 2016 and progressively rolled out across all states and UTs. The UDID replaces multiple state-specific disability certificates and creates a single national database.

UDID – Unique Disability ID Card	
Department / Ministry	Department of Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities (DEPwD)
Overview	A smart card-based unique identity for all PwDs providing a single, verifiable national identity. Contains photo, biometrics, and disability details. Links beneficiary to all government schemes eliminating duplication and ensuring direct benefit transfer.
Eligibility	All Indian citizens with any disability certified by a medical authority under the RPWD Act. No income limit for obtaining the UDID card itself. Disability certificate from a government hospital or authorized medical officer required.
Key Benefits	Single unified identity for accessing all disability benefits, reservations, concessions; eliminates need to produce multiple documents; scheme-linked benefits directly credited; portable across states; digital version on mobile phone; QR code for instant verification.

How to Apply	Register online at swavlambancard.gov.in or visit designated government hospital / DDRC. Fill online form with disability details, upload photo, identity proof, and address proof. Medical assessment at designated hospital. Card generated centrally and dispatched. Track application status online.

12.2 Information Stored on UDID Card

Data Category	Details Stored
Personal Details	Name, date of birth, gender, address, contact number, photograph
Disability Details	Type of disability, percentage of disability, affected part
Medical Details	Name of certifying medical authority, date of certification
Unique ID	Auto-generated UDID number; QR code for digital verification
Scheme Linkage	Schemes availed, benefits received history
Biometrics	Fingerprints and iris scan (for smart card enabled UDID)

12.3 Benefits of UDID Card

• Single document proof of disability – accepted nationally in all government offices

• Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) of scheme benefits linked to bank account via UDID

• Railway concessions without separate certificate – UDID card sufficient

• Access to income tax deductions for PwDs (Section 80U of IT Act) with UDID as proof

- Priority in government services; no queue at government offices with UDID
- Voter ID linkage for electoral roll registration of PwDs
- Automated renewal reminders; no need for fresh certification for permanent disabilities
- Emergency contact information stored; useful in medical emergencies

CHAPTER 13

NHFDC Loans & Financial Assistance

National Handicapped Finance & Development Corporation – Self-Employment Finance

13.1 About NHFDC

The National Handicapped Finance and Development Corporation (NHFDC) is a Government of India undertaking under the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment, established in 1997. It is an apex financing institution that provides concessional finance to persons with disabilities for self-employment, skill development, and education purposes.

NHFDC – Loan & Skill Development Schemes	
Department / Ministry	National Handicapped Finance and Development Corporation (NHFDC) under DEPwD/MSJE
Overview	Apex body channeling concessional loans through State Channelizing Agencies (SCAs) to PwDs for self-employment ventures including agriculture, small business, manufacturing, services, and technical trades. Also funds skill development and micro-finance activities.
Eligibility	Indian citizen with 40%+ disability, age 18-55 years (relaxable). Income ceiling of Rs.3 lakh per annum for general loans; below Rs.50,000 per annum for micro-credit. Must have UDID card or valid disability certificate.
Key Benefits	Loans up to Rs.30 lakh at concessional interest rates (2%-5% per annum). Micro-credit loans up to Rs.50,000 through SHGs. Skill training loans. Education loans for professional courses up to Rs.8 lakh.

How to Apply	Apply through State Channelizing Agency (SCA) in your state – typically State Disability Development Corporation or State Finance Corporation for Disabled. Online portal: nhfdc.nic.in. Submit business plan, disability certificate, income proof, and identity documents.

13.2 NHFDC Loan Categories

Category	Maximum Loan	Interest Rate	Repayment	Purpose
Term Loan (Self-Employment)	Up to Rs.30 lakh	2-5% p.a.	Up to 10 years	For setting up business, purchase of equipment, working capital
Agricultural Loan	Up to Rs.10 lakh	2-4% p.a.	Up to 7 years	Agriculture, horticulture, fisheries, animal husbandry
Education Loan	Up to Rs.8 lakh	4% p.a.	Up to 7 years	Professional/technical courses; moratorium during study period
Micro-Credit (SHGs)	Up to Rs.50,000	5% p.a.	Up to 3 years	Through Self-Help Groups; collective guarantee
Skill Development	Up to Rs.1 lakh	NIL	5 years	Training cost + maintenance; for approved courses

13.3 Skill Development Programmes by NHFDC

NHFDC conducts and funds skill development programmes through its network of NGOs and SCAs. Programmes include both residential and non-residential training in various trades:

- Tailoring and Garment Making
- Computer Hardware & Software
- Mobile Phone Repair
- Handicrafts and Artisan Training
- Poultry and Small Animal Farming

- Bakery and Food Processing
- Electronics Repair
- Driving Training (for mobility PwDs)
- Beautician and Salon Training
- Data Entry and BPO Skills
- Leather Goods Making
- Candle and Incense Manufacturing

CHAPTER 14

Disability Pension & Social Security

Indira Gandhi National Disability Pension Scheme & State Schemes

14.1 Indira Gandhi National Disability Pension Scheme (IGNDPS)

Indira Gandhi National Disability Pension Scheme (IGNDPS) / Disability Pension	
Department / Ministry	Ministry of Rural Development, Government of India (under NSAP)
Overview	Component of the National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP) providing monthly pension to BPL households with severely disabled members. Part of India's social protection floor for the most vulnerable among PwDs.
Eligibility	BPL household (as per state BPL list); severe disability (80%+) or multiple disability; age 18-79 years (persons above 80 years covered under Indira Gandhi National Old Age Pension).
Key Benefits	Central contribution of Rs.300/month per beneficiary. States add their own contribution (varies from Rs.200 to Rs.2000/month). Total pension varies by state – e.g., Delhi: Rs.2,500/month; Maharashtra: Rs.1,000/month; Tamil Nadu: Rs.1,000/month.
How to Apply	Apply through Gram Panchayat (rural) or Municipal Ward Office (urban). Submit BPL card, disability certificate (80%+ or multiple disability), Aadhaar card, and bank account details. Payment through direct bank transfer or post office.

14.2 State Disability Pension Schemes

In addition to IGNDPS, many states have their own disability pension schemes with varying eligibility criteria and amounts:

State	Monthly Pension	Eligibility
Andhra Pradesh	Rs.3,000/month	40%+ disability, BPL
Delhi	Rs.2,500/month	40%+ disability
Karnataka	Rs.1,400/month	40%+ disability, income limit
Kerala	Rs.1,600/month	40%+ disability
Maharashtra	Rs.1,000/month	40%+ disability, BPL
Tamil Nadu	Rs.1,000/month	40%+ disability, BPL
Rajasthan	Rs.750-1,500/month	40%+ disability, age-based
West Bengal	Rs.1,000/month	40%+ disability, income limit
Uttar Pradesh	Rs.500/month	40%+ disability, BPL
Gujarat	Rs.400-600/month	Multiple disability or locomotor

CHAPTER 15 National Trust

Autism, Cerebral Palsy, Intellectual Disability & Multiple Disabilities

15.1 About the National Trust

The National Trust for Welfare of Persons with Autism, Cerebral Palsy, Mental Retardation and Multiple Disabilities is a statutory body under the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment, established under the National Trust Act, 1999. It specifically serves four disability groups: Autism Spectrum Disorder, Cerebral Palsy, Intellectual Disabilities (mental retardation), and Multiple Disabilities.

National Trust – Welfare Schemes for Autism/CP/ID/Multiple Disabilities	
Department / Ministry	Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment (MSJE)
Overview	Statutory body established to enable persons with autism, CP, intellectual disabilities, and multiple disabilities to live as independently as possible within their family, to extend support to their families, and to promote policies that help integrate them into society.
Eligibility	Persons with Autism Spectrum Disorder, Cerebral Palsy, Intellectual Disability, or Multiple Disabilities (combination of two or more disabilities including at least one of the above four). Various scheme-specific eligibility criteria apply.
Key Benefits	Guardianship support through NIRAMAYA health insurance; SAMARTH scheme for family caregiver support; GHARAUNDA residential care for adults; PRERNA early intervention; DISHA early detection and intervention; SAMBHAV foster family support; VIKAAS life skills training.
How to Apply	Register beneficiary on National Trust website (thenationaltrust.gov.in). Apply for specific schemes through registered organisations (ROs) of National Trust in your district/state.

15.2 Key Schemes of National Trust

NIRAMAYA (Health Insurance): Annual health insurance cover up to Rs.1 lakh per year for persons with autism, CP, ID, or multiple disability. Premium very low (Rs.250-500 per year).

SAMARTH (Caregiver Support): Day care services; residential rehabilitation; vocational training; supported employment; family support.

GHARAUNDA (Residential Care): Group homes for adults with autism, CP, ID, and multiple disability who cannot live with family. 24-hour supported living.

DISHA (Early Intervention): Network of early intervention centres; therapy, assessment, and family training for children 0-10 years.

PRERNA (Incentive Scheme): Annual award for outstanding contribution in disability field; recognition of good work by individuals and organizations.

SAMBHAV (Foster Family): Training and support for foster families willing to include a person with disability in their family.

VIKAAS (Vocational Training): Life skills, pre-vocational, and vocational training for adults with autism, CP, and intellectual disability.

BADHTE KADAM (Community Integration): Awareness programmes; parent training; community mobilisation for disability inclusion.

CHAPTER 16

Sugamya Bharat – Accessible India Campaign

Accessibility Campaign for Physical, Transport & Digital Accessibility

16.1 Overview

Sugamya Bharat Abhiyan (Accessible India Campaign) was launched by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on 3rd December 2015 (International Day of Persons with Disabilities). It is a nationwide campaign under DEPwD to achieve universal accessibility for PwDs across three verticals: Built Environment, Transport Systems, and Information & Communication Ecosystem.

Sugamya Bharat Abhiyan – Accessible India Campaign	
Department / Ministry	Department of Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities (DEPwD)
Overview	Flagship accessibility campaign with time-bound targets for making all government buildings, airports, railways, public transport, websites, and digital content accessible. Uses 'crowdsourcing' of inaccessibility reports through mobile application.
Eligibility	Campaign targets all PwDs in India. Accessibility improvements benefit all government buildings, transport systems, and digital content across the country.
Key Benefits	Ramp access to all government buildings; accessible toilets; accessible lifts with Braille; sign language interpreters at government offices; WCAG 2.0 compliant government websites; accessible railway stations; accessible airports; accessible government buses.
How to Apply	Citizens can report inaccessibility through Sugamya Bharat App (available on Play Store/App Store). DEPwD conducts accessibility audits. SIPDA funds accessibility retrofitting in states.

16.2 Three Pillars of Sugamya Bharat

Built Environment

1,000 government buildings made accessible in Phase I. Includes all Ministries, Central Secretariat, Courts, Police Stations, Hospitals, Post Offices, and Banks. Harmonized Guidelines 2021 set standards.

Transport Systems

All major airports to be fully accessible (AAI compliance). Railway stations on 'A1' and 'A' category to have accessible features. 50% of government buses to be low-floor accessible.

Information & Communication

All government websites to be WCAG 2.0/2.1 Level AA compliant (GIGW standards). Doordarshan channels to provide sign language interpretation. Government apps to be accessible.

CHAPTER 17

SIPDA – Scheme of Implementation of PwD Act

State-level Implementation of Accessibility & Disability Rights

17.1 About SIPDA

The Scheme of Implementation of Persons with Disabilities Act (SIPDA) is a Central Sector scheme under DEPwD that provides financial assistance to state governments, union territories, and organizations for creating accessible environments and implementing provisions of the RPWD Act 2016.

SIPDA – Scheme of Implementation of PwD Act	
Department / Ministry	Department of Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities (DEPwD)
Overview	Central sector scheme providing grants to states/UTs for accessibility infrastructure, awareness campaigns, disability data collection, training of government staff, and other activities mandated under RPWD Act 2016. Covers both capital and operational expenditures.
Eligibility	State Governments and Union Territory administrations. Funds channeled through State Commissioners for Persons with Disabilities or designated nodal agencies.
Key Benefits	Funds for accessibility retrofitting of government buildings; purchase of accessibility equipment; training of disability management officials; awareness campaigns; disability census; assistive technology provision; barrier-free environment creation.
How to Apply	State government submits proposals to DEPwD with details of activities and cost estimates. DEPwD appraises and sanctions grants. Utilization certificate submitted by state for continued funding.

17.2 Key Activities Funded under SIPDA

- Construction of ramps in government buildings (Central, State, and Local Body)
- Installation of accessible lifts with Braille and voice announcements
- Accessible toilet construction in government premises
- Purchase of tactile blocks and visual contrast markers for visually impaired
- Sign language interpreter training and deployment
- Sensitization and capacity building of government employees
- Accessibility audits of government buildings
- Setting up of disability information centres at district level
- Assistive technology demonstrations and distribution camps
- Accessibility features in public parks and recreational spaces

CHAPTER 18

DDRS – Deendayal Disabled Rehabilitation Scheme

NGO Funding for Disability Rehabilitation Services

18.1 Overview of DDRS

The Deendayal Disabled Rehabilitation Scheme (DDRS) is a Central Sector scheme of the Department of Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities that provides financial assistance to NGOs working in the field of disability rehabilitation. The scheme recognizes that NGOs play a critical role in providing rehabilitation services at the grassroots level, particularly in areas not served by government facilities.

DDRS – Deendayal Disabled Rehabilitation Scheme	
Department / Ministry	Department of Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities (DEPwD)
Overview	Grant-in-aid scheme providing financial assistance to NGOs for running rehabilitation projects for PwDs. Covers a wide range of activities from early intervention to vocational training and residential care. Over 2,000 NGOs funded annually under this scheme.
Eligibility	Registered NGOs, voluntary organizations, trusts with minimum 3 years of experience in disability rehabilitation. Must submit financial statements, annual reports, and project details. Projects must cater to minimum number of beneficiaries as specified.
Key Benefits	Salary of rehabilitation professionals and staff; cost of running rehabilitation centres; mobility aids and assistive devices for beneficiaries; special education costs; vocational training materials; residential facilities for severely disabled.

How to Apply	Apply to DEPwD online at dppw.gov.in. Submit application with organization registration documents, financial statements, project proposal, and details of beneficiaries. Evaluation by DEPwD officials. Annual renewal required with utilization certificate.

18.2 Types of Projects Funded under DDRS

Project Type	Description
Pre-School & Early Intervention	For children 0-6 years with disability; early assessment, therapy, and family guidance.
Special Schools	Segregated education for children with severe disability who cannot be included in mainstream schools.
Vocational Training Centres	Skills training for adults with disability; agriculture, handicrafts, trades, services.
Sheltered Workshops	Supervised work environment for PwDs unable to access open employment.
Residential Homes	24-hour residential care for PwDs without family support or with severe disability.
Therapy Centres	Physiotherapy, occupational therapy, speech therapy for PwDs in community.
Resource & Educational Support	Support to children with disability in mainstream schools through resource room model.
Half-Way Homes	Transitional residential facilities for persons with mental illness after hospital discharge.
Leprosy Cured Persons	Rehabilitation of leprosy-cured persons (now classified under locomotor disability).
Community Based Rehabilitation (CBR)	Rehabilitation of PwDs in their own communities through trained CBR workers.

CHAPTER ADD-SCH

Additional Government Schemes

Comprehensive Coverage of All Remaining Disability Welfare Schemes

Rashtriya Vayoshri Yojana (RVY)

Department / Ministry	Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment (for elderly)
Overview	The Rashtriya Vayoshri Yojana provides physical aids and assisted-living devices for elderly persons from BPL households. While focused on the elderly rather than PwDs specifically, it is relevant for elderly persons with disability and overlaps significantly with ADIP scheme. Devices provided include: walking sticks, elbow crutches, tripod and quadripod sticks, rollators, hip protectors, hearing aids, wheelchairs, artificial dentures, and spectacles.
Eligibility	Age 60+ years; BPL household; visual/hearing/locomotor or dental impairment.
Key Benefits	Free assistive devices as assessed; distributed through camps organised by ALIMCO and other implementing agencies.
How to Apply	Apply through district social welfare office or at distribution camps; Aadhaar, age proof, BPL card required.

PM-DAKSH (Pradhan Mantri Dakshta Aur Kushalta Sampann Hitgrahi Yojana)

Department / Ministry	Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment
Overview	PM-DAKSH is a skilling and livelihood scheme targeting SC/ST/OBC and other deprived communities including persons with disabilities. It provides short-term skill development training in market-driven trades with stipend and placement support. PwDs from eligible communities can benefit from this scheme in addition to NHFDC skill programmes.

Eligibility	SC/ST/OBC/economically backward including PwDs; age 18-45; income below Rs.1 lakh/year for SC/ST; Rs.1.5 lakh for others.
Key Benefits	Free training (short-term: 200-600 hours; long-term: 5760 hours); stipend Rs.1,000-1,500/month during training; tool kit on completion; placement assistance.
How to Apply	Apply on pmdaksh.dosje.gov.in; training organised through empanelled training providers; preference given to SC/ST candidates.

Handicraft Training to Disabled (HTD)

Department / Ministry	Office of Development Commissioner (Handicrafts) under Ministry of Textiles
Overview	The Handicraft Training programme provides training in traditional handicrafts to persons with disability who show aptitude for handicraft work. Training centres across India teach traditional crafts like weaving, pottery, embroidery, woodcarving, metalwork, and other local crafts. Graduates can access market linkages, raw material support, and finance through Artisan Credit Card scheme.
Eligibility	Persons with disability (any percentage); age 15-35 preferably; basic interest in handcraft work.
Key Benefits	Free training (6-24 months); stipend during training; raw material support on completion; market linkage through handicraft exhibitions.
How to Apply	Apply at Regional Design and Technical Development Centres (RDTDCs) or through state Handicraft Development Corporation.

National Action Plan for Skill Training of Persons with Disabilities

Department / Ministry	DEPwD in coordination with Ministry of Skill Development & Entrepreneurship
Overview	A dedicated action plan for systematic skill training of PwDs targeting 5 lakh PwDs per year. Implemented through NHFDC, RSETIs (Rural Self Employment Training Institutes), Pradhan Mantri Kaushal Kendras (PMKKs), and sector skill councils. Focuses on industry-relevant skills with placement-linked training.

Eligibility	Persons with benchmark disability; age 18-40; basic literacy preferred.
Key Benefits	Free skill training aligned with NSQF; stipend during training; certification by NSDC-aligned bodies; placement assistance; entrepreneurship support.
How to Apply	Apply through nearest PMKK or NHFDC skill centre; list on nhfdc.nic.in.

Border Area Development Programme (BADP) Disability Component

Department / Ministry	Ministry of Home Affairs
Overview	BADP provides development assistance to border areas including for welfare of persons with disability in border districts. Accessible infrastructure in border area schools and hospitals; assistive devices distribution; rehabilitation camps in border areas of Rajasthan, Gujarat, Punjab, J&K;, Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh, Sikkim, Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, West Bengal, and Manipur.
Eligibility	PwDs residing in notified border area districts.
Key Benefits	ADIP-type assistive devices; accessible infrastructure; awareness camps.
How to Apply	Through District Collector of border district; no separate application.

Assistance for Travel Abroad for Medical Treatment

Department / Ministry	Ministry of External Affairs / State Governments
Overview	Some state governments (Kerala, Tamil Nadu) have schemes providing financial assistance for travel abroad for specialized medical treatment not available in India. This can cover cochlear implants, complex cerebral palsy surgeries, rare disease treatments relevant to disability. Central Government has no specific scheme but AIIMS and other national institutes facilitate international referrals.
Eligibility	State-specific; typically BPL or below-income threshold; medical board certification that treatment not available in India.
Key Benefits	Travel cost, treatment cost (partial/full) as per state scheme.

How to Apply	Through State Health Department; medical board referral required.

CHAPTER PROC

Detailed Application Procedures

Step-by-Step Guide for All Major Disability Schemes

ADIP Scheme – Step-by-Step Application Guide

Step 1	**Check Eligibility**	Verify you have 40%+ disability (locomotor/visual/hearing/intellectual). Check income: below Rs.20,000/month general; Rs.15,000/month for motorised wheelchair. Confirm you are an Indian citizen.
Step 2	**Get Disability Certificate**	If you don't have a disability certificate, visit your nearest government hospital with medical records. A medical board or designated specialist will assess and certify your disability percentage. This is free.
Step 3	**Find Implementing Agency**	Locate your nearest ALIMCO regional centre (Kanpur HQ + 6 regional centres + multiple sub-regional centres) OR identify an approved NGO in your district. DEPwD website lists approved NGOs.
Step 4	**Watch for Camp Announcements**	ALIMCO and NGOs organise distribution camps at taluk/block level. Announcements made through district administration, local newspapers, panchayat notice boards. Alternatively, apply at the centre directly.
Step 5	**Apply with Documents**	Bring: disability certificate, income proof (ration card/self-declaration), Aadhaar card, two photos. Fill application form at camp or online at adip.gov.in. Specify device required (based on your disability type).
Step 6	**Assessment**	Rehabilitation professional assesses your specific need. For prosthetics/orthotics, measurements are taken. For hearing aids, audiological assessment done. For wheelchairs, postural assessment done.

Step 7	Device Provision	Device provided at camp or fabricated and delivered within 30-60 days. For motorised wheelchairs and prosthetics, fitting and training provided. Follow-up service included.
Step 8	Warranty & Repair	ALIMCO devices carry 1-year warranty. Repair service available at ALIMCO centres and through approved service centres. Next device can be availed after 5 years.

UDID Card Application – Complete Guide

Step 1	Online Registration	Visit swavlambancard.gov.in. Click 'New Registration'. Enter your Aadhaar number, mobile number (linked to Aadhaar). OTP verification.
Step 2	Fill Personal Details	Enter: name as per Aadhaar, date of birth, gender, address, contact details. Upload passport photo (JPG, max 50KB).
Step 3	Enter Disability Details	Select disability type from dropdown (21 categories). If already have certificate, enter certificate number and details. If not, select 'I do not have certificate'.
Step 4	Upload Documents	Upload scanned copies: Aadhaar card (both sides), disability certificate (if available), self-attested photo. File size limits apply.
Step 5	Select Hospital	Select your preferred government hospital from the list for medical assessment. System automatically assigns appointment.
Step 6	Visit Hospital	Visit hospital on assigned date with originals of all documents. Medical board/specialist assesses disability. Biometric data (fingerprint, iris) captured.
Step 7	Verification & Processing	District Medical Officer verifies. Data sent to NIC for UDID card generation. Process takes 30-60 days.
Step 8	Card Delivery	UDID smart card dispatched to registered address by speed post. Track on portal. Download e-UDID immediately on approval — usable digitally.

NHFDC Loan Application – Procedure

Step 1	**Identify SCA**	Find your State Channelizing Agency (SCA) — typically named [State] Finance Corporation for Disabled or similar. Contact details on nhfdc.nic.in or NHFDC toll-free 0120-2403400.
Step 2	**Get Application Form**	Collect loan application form from SCA office or download from nhfdc.nic.in. Forms also available at DEPwD district offices and DDRCs.
Step 3	**Prepare Business Plan**	Write a simple business plan: what business you want to start, market for your product/service, estimated revenue and expenses, collateral available (if any). NHFDC officers can help with this.
Step 4	**Gather Documents**	Collect: Aadhaar, PAN, UDID card/disability certificate, income proof, address proof, bank statement (6 months), business plan, photographs (3), caste certificate if applicable.
Step 5	**Submit Application**	Submit to SCA with all documents. Pay nominal processing fee if any (varies by state). SCA officer scrutinizes application and visits proposed business site.
Step 6	**Appraisal**	SCA appraises the proposal: checks business viability, applicant's capability, collateral, and other parameters. Joint liability group/SHG model available for micro-credit.
Step 7	**Sanction**	SCA sanctions loan and forwards to NHFDC for refinance. NHFDC releases funds to SCA. SCA disburses to applicant directly or through bank transfer.
Step 8	**Repayment**	EMI-based repayment through bank. Prepayment allowed without penalty. Moratorium of 6 months to 1 year for initial setup available. Default: penal interest applicable.

Disability Pension – Application Procedure

Step 1	**Check Eligibility (IGNDPS)**	Verify: BPL household (name on BPL list), severe disability 80%+ or multiple disability, age 18-79 years. For state schemes, check respective state's eligibility criteria.

Step 2	**Visit Local Office**	For rural areas: visit Gram Panchayat office or Block Development Office (BDO). For urban areas: visit Municipal Ward office or Urban Local Body office.
Step 3	**Collect and Fill Form**	Get the social pension application form. Fill in: personal details, disability details, BPL details, bank account details (for Direct Benefit Transfer).
Step 4	**Attach Documents**	Attach: BPL card/ration card, disability certificate (80%+), Aadhaar card, bank passbook copy, photographs, age proof.
Step 5	**Submit and Get Acknowledgement**	Submit at Gram Panchayat/Ward office and get stamped acknowledgement receipt. Note application number.
Step 6	**Verification**	Gram Panchayat/Ward officer verifies documents and recommends to BDO/SDM. Social audit may be conducted. Panchayat/Ward meeting approval in some states.
Step 7	**Sanction and DBT**	BDO/SDM sanctions pension. Amount transferred monthly/quarterly to bank account via Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT). PFMS system used for transparency.
Step 8	**Annual Renewal/Verification**	Most states require annual verification of eligibility. Submit life certificate and fresh documents as required. Digital life certificate (Jeevan Pramaan) accepted.

CHAPTER SPECIAL

Scheme Convergence & Implementation Guide

How to Combine Multiple Schemes for Maximum Benefit

Convergence Framework

Persons with disabilities often need support from multiple schemes simultaneously. The Government of India encourages convergence of schemes to provide comprehensive support. Below are key convergence combinations:

Newly Identified PwD (Rural BPL)

Recommended Scheme Combination

- 1. UDID Card (identity + scheme linkage)
- 2. ADIP Scheme (assistive device)
- 3. IGNDPS / State Disability Pension (monthly income)
- 4. Samagra Shiksha (if school-going children)
- 5. NHFDC Micro-credit via SHG (self-employment)
- 6. PM Awas Yojana (accessible housing)
- 7. Ayushman Bharat PMJAY (health insurance)

Adult PwD seeking Employment

Recommended Scheme Combination

- 1. UDID Card

- 2. NHFDC Skill Training (vocational)
- 3. Special Employment Exchange registration
- 4. NHFDC Loan (self-employment capital)
- 5. ADIP Scheme (workplace assistive device)
- 6. Income tax deduction under 80U

Student with Disability

Recommended Scheme Combination

- 1. UDID Card
- 2. Pre/Post-Matric Scholarship (DEPwD)
- 3. Samagra Shiksha support (school level)
- 4. 5% reservation in higher education
- 5. National Fellowship (for M.Phil/Ph.D)
- 6. Exam accommodations (Section 17)
- 7. ADIP scheme (assistive devices for study)

Person with Autism/CP/ID

Recommended Scheme Combination

- 1. UDID Card + National Trust registration
- 2. NIRAMAYA Health Insurance (National Trust)
- 3. DISHA Early Intervention (if child)
- 4. VIKAAS Vocational Training (adult)

- 5. GHARAUNDA (if no family support)
- 6. DDRS-funded NGO services
- 7. Limited Guardianship (Section 14 RPWD Act)

Implementation Challenges & Solutions

Challenge: Lack of Awareness

Many PwDs and their families are unaware of entitlements. Solutions: Panchayat-level awareness camps; ASHA/ANM worker training on disability schemes; school sensitization; community radio programmes; village-level disability surveys by NGOs under DDRS.

Challenge: Documentation Barriers

Multiple documents required for various schemes. Solutions: UDID card designed to eliminate this — single document for all purposes. Aadhaar-UDID linkage simplifies further. NGOs under DDRS assist with document preparation. Online application reduces physical barriers.

Challenge: Geographic Remoteness

Many PwDs in rural/tribal areas cannot travel to district centres. Solutions: Mobile ADIP camps at village level; home-based assessment for severely disabled; online applications; ASHA worker as liaison for disability pension applications.

Challenge: Coordination between Departments

Disability is a cross-cutting issue requiring coordination across Education, Health, Rural Dev., Urban Dev., and Labour. Solutions: District Disability Coordination Committee (DDCC); convergence meetings at district level; single-window facilitation at DDRC.

Challenge: Grievance Redressal Delay

Complaints to State Commissioner/CCPD can take months to resolve. Solutions: Online complaint tracking; time-bound disposal norms (CCPD must respond within 60 days); escalation to NHRC for persistent non-compliance.

CHAPTER IMPL

Scheme Implementation & Monitoring

How Government Schemes Are Implemented, Monitored and Evaluated

Implementation Architecture

The implementation of disability welfare schemes in India operates through a multi-tier architecture spanning Central Government, State Government, District Administration, and local bodies (Gram Panchayat/Urban Local Body). This architecture creates both opportunities for comprehensive coverage and challenges of coordination, accountability, and uniform standards.

At the Central level, DEPwD formulates schemes, sets guidelines, allocates funds, monitors implementation, and manages the national institutes. Central funds are released to states through two mechanisms: (a) Central Sector schemes where funds flow directly from Central Government to implementing agencies; and (b) Centrally Sponsored schemes where states share the funding burden (typically 60:40 Centre:State ratio, or 90:10 for special category states).

At the State level, the Department of Social Justice and Empowerment (or equivalent — naming varies by state) is typically the nodal department for disability welfare. States have their own Commissioner for Persons with Disabilities, State Channelizing Agencies for NHFDC loans, and additional state-specific schemes. The level of priority given to disability varies significantly across

states — some like Kerala, Tamil Nadu, and Delhi have robust additional state schemes while others largely rely on central schemes.

At the District level, the District Collector/DM is overall in charge. The District Social Welfare Officer (DSWO) specifically handles disability scheme implementation. The DDRC (District Disability Rehabilitation Centre) provides direct services. The district-level coordination committee (DDCC) brings together all relevant departments for convergence.

At the Gram Panchayat/Ward level, the frontline functionaries — ASHA workers, Anganwadi workers, revenue officials, and elected representatives — are critical links between schemes and beneficiaries. Their awareness of disability schemes and ability to link PwDs to schemes is often the decisive factor in scheme access, particularly in rural areas.

Monitoring Framework for Disability Schemes

Monitoring Type	Parameters & Methods
Financial Monitoring	Budget allocation vs actual expenditure; quarterly utilization reports; Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) audit; Social audit by PwD community representatives.
Physical Output Monitoring	Number of beneficiaries served; devices distributed; loans disbursed; buildings made accessible; NGOs funded; camps organised — against targets.
Outcome Monitoring	Income levels of NHFDC loan recipients before and after; employment rates of skill training graduates; school enrollment and retention of children with disability; health indicators.

Process Monitoring	Time taken from application to benefit delivery; grievance resolution time; online tracking of applications; beneficiary satisfaction surveys.
Equity Monitoring	Distribution across states; rural vs urban coverage; gender disaggregation; disability category-wise coverage; SC/ST/OBC PwD representation.
Digital Monitoring	UDID database tracks beneficiary data; PFMS tracks fund flows; PMSLA (Pradhan Mantri Scheme Monitoring) dashboard; public disclosure of performance.

Common Implementation Challenges

Documentation Burden

Despite UDID card's promise of single-document simplicity, many scheme officers still ask for multiple additional documents (ration card, income certificate, caste certificate, residence certificate), creating barriers for rural and poor PwDs. Solution: strict enforcement of 'UDID card as sole disability proof' mandate; training of scheme officers; peer monitoring by PwD community organizations.

Last Mile Connectivity

Even where schemes exist on paper, reaching the last beneficiary in remote areas is a challenge. DDRCs are not yet established in all 741 districts. ALIMCO distribution camps require beneficiaries to travel, which can be impossible for severely disabled persons. Solution: mobile ADIP camps; home-based services; tele-rehabilitation; NGO outreach under DDRS.

Inter-departmental Coordination

Disability is a cross-cutting issue but responsibility is fragmented across DEPwD (schemes), MoE (education), MoHFW (health), MoRD (rural development pension), MoUD (accessibility), MoL (employment). Lack of coordination leads to gaps and duplication. Solution: District Disability Coordination Committee (DDCC) with mandatory quarterly meetings; single-window service delivery through DDRCs.

Capacity of Implementing Agencies

NGOs funded under DDRS vary widely in quality and capacity. Some are highly professional with trained staff while others may lack rehabilitation expertise. Solution: mandatory accreditation framework for DDRS NGOs; RCI certification requirement for professional staff; surprise visits and quality audits; performance-linked funding under DDRS.

Delayed Payments and Corruption

Instances of delay in disbursement of disability pension through postal/manual modes; intermediary corruption in scheme access. Solution: direct bank transfer (DBT) for all cash benefits; Aadhaar-linked authentication; social audit; citizen feedback mechanism; real-time payment tracking through PFMS.

CHAPTER CHECK

Scheme Application Checklists

Quick Reference Checklists for Applying to Each Disability Scheme

UDID CARD APPLICATION CHECKLIST

- Aadhaar Card (original + photocopy)
- Existing Disability Certificate (if any; original + photocopy)
- 2 Passport-size photographs (recent, plain background)
- Medical records / prescriptions related to disability
- Mobile number linked to Aadhaar (for OTP)
- Online registration at swavlambancard.gov.in completed
- Application acknowledgement number noted
- Hospital appointment date confirmed
- All original documents carried to hospital
- Tracking application status on portal

ADIP SCHEME APPLICATION CHECKLIST

- Valid Disability Certificate (40%+ disability)
- UDID Card or UDID application number
- Income proof: Ration Card / BPL Card / Income Certificate
- Aadhaar Card (original + photocopy)
- 2 Passport-size photographs

- Age proof (if child applicant)
- Bank account details (for direct benefit, if applicable)
- Know which device you need (based on disability type)
- Located nearest ALIMCO centre / NGO implementing agency
- Checked camp schedule on alimco.in or district notice

NHFDC LOAN APPLICATION CHECKLIST

- Disability Certificate (40%+ benchmark disability)
- UDID Card
- Age proof (18-55 years)
- Income proof (annual income within limits)
- Aadhaar Card + PAN Card
- Address proof (Aadhaar / utility bill)
- Bank statement (last 6 months)
- 2 Passport-size photographs
- Business plan prepared (what business, market, revenue estimate)
- Identified State Channelizing Agency (SCA) in your state
- Application form filled (from SCA or nhfdc.nic.in)
- References / guarantors arranged (if required by SCA)

DISABILITY PENSION APPLICATION CHECKLIST

- BPL Card / Name on BPL list (for IGNDPS)
- Disability Certificate (80%+ for IGNDPS; 40%+ for state schemes)
- Age proof (18-79 for IGNDPS)

- Aadhaar Card (mandatory for DBT)
- Bank account details (Aadhaar-linked for DBT)
- Photograph (passport size, 2 copies)
- Identified concerned office (Gram Panchayat / Municipal Ward)
- Application form filled and signed
- Acknowledgement receipt collected from office
- Follow up on application status

SCHOLARSHIP APPLICATION CHECKLIST

- Disability Certificate (40%+ for DEPwD scholarships)
- UDID Card
- Admission letter / enrollment proof from educational institution
- Mark sheets / grade transcripts of previous year
- Income Certificate (annual family income within limit: Rs.2.5 lakh)
- Aadhaar Card
- Bank account (student's own account; Aadhaar-linked)
- Domicile certificate (for state scholarships)
- Caste certificate (if SC/ST for combined benefits)
- Registered on National Scholarship Portal (scholarships.gov.in)
- Application submitted before deadline (typically Oct-Nov each year)
- Institute verification completed on NSP portal

NIRAMAYA INSURANCE (NATIONAL TRUST) CHECKLIST

- Diagnosed with Autism, Cerebral Palsy, Intellectual Disability or Multiple Disability
- Disability Certificate from government hospital
- UDID Card or application acknowledgement
- Identified nearest National Trust Registered Organisation (RO)
- RO will assist with NIRAMAYA enrollment form
- Photograph (2 copies)
- Aadhaar Card
- Bank account details (for reimbursement)
- Premium payment: Rs.250 (BPL) or Rs.500 (non-BPL)
- Policy number and coverage terms noted

CHAPTER 19

Assistive Technology – Full Catalogue

Comprehensive Guide to Assistive Devices for All Disability Categories

19.1 Introduction to Assistive Technology

Assistive Technology (AT) encompasses any device, software, equipment, or system that helps a person with disability perform functions that might otherwise be difficult or impossible. The WHO's Global Report on Assistive Technology (2021) estimates that over 2.5 billion people globally need one or more assistive products. In India, the ADIP scheme and ALIMCO provide the primary gateway to assistive technology for PwDs.

19.2 Vision Impairment – Assistive Devices

Device	Description
White Cane	Folding/rigid cane for navigation and obstacle detection by blind persons. Standard for independent mobility.
Smart Cane	Electronic travel aid with ultrasonic sensors; detects obstacles and vibrates/beeps. Developed by IIT Delhi. Distributed under ADIP.
DAISY Player	Digital talking book player for reading accessible audio books. Works with Sugamya Pustakalaya content.
Braille Display	Refreshable braille display that converts digital text to braille in real-time. Connects to computers/mobiles.
Screen Reader	Software (NVDA free; JAWS paid) that reads screen content aloud. Built into Android (TalkBack) and iOS (VoiceOver).
Braille Embosser	Printer that produces braille documents.

Magnification Software	ZoomText, MAGic, or Windows Magnifier for low vision users.
Optical Magnifiers	Handheld or stand magnifiers for low vision; various magnification levels.
Talking Calculators	Speaks numbers and calculations aloud.
Low Vision Glasses	Specially designed spectacles and telescopic lenses for maximizing residual vision.
CCTV/Video Magnifiers	Electronic magnification systems displaying enlarged images on screen for reading.
Accessible Mobile Apps	Be My Eyes, Seeing AI, Google Lookout – AI-powered apps for blind users.

19.3 Hearing Impairment – Assistive Technology

Device/Service	Description
BTE Hearing Aid	Behind-the-Ear digital hearing aid; most common type; programmable.
ITE Hearing Aid	In-the-Ear hearing aid; smaller; custom-fit.
CIC Hearing Aid	Completely-in-Canal; nearly invisible; suitable for mild-moderate hearing loss.
Cochlear Implant	Surgical implant for profound hearing loss; electronic stimulation of auditory nerve.
FM System	Wireless microphone system for classroom use; transmits teacher's voice directly to hearing aid.
Induction Loop/Telecoil	Electromagnetic system for use in public venues; compatible hearing aids pick up signal.
Vibrating Alert Systems	Vibrating alarm clocks, door bells, smoke alarms, and baby monitors.
Captioned Phones	Telephones that display real-time captions of conversation.
Video Relay Services	Sign language interpreter via video call for deaf persons making telephone calls.

Speech-to-Text Apps	Live Transcribe (Google), Otter.ai – real-time captioning using AI.
Sign Language Interpreter	Human interpreter converting spoken language to sign and vice versa.

19.4 Mobility & Locomotor Disability – Devices

Device	Description
Manual Wheelchair	Self-propelled or attendant-pushed; various types: standard, lightweight, sport.
Motorised Wheelchair	Battery-operated powered wheelchair; joystick or alternative controls. Under ADIP for income criteria.
Tricycle (Hand/Foot)	Three-wheeled hand-operated or foot-operated cycle for persons with lower limb disability.
Prosthetic Limbs	Artificial arms and legs; ALIMCO manufactures Jaipur foot (most widely used lower limb prosthetic globally).
Orthotic Devices	Callipers, knee-ankle-foot orthoses (KAFO), ankle-foot orthoses (AFO), spinal braces.
Axillary Crutches	Underarm crutches for temporary or permanent use.
Elbow Crutches	Forearm crutches; more stable for long-term use.
Walking Frame/Rollator	Four-wheeled walker with or without seat for balance support.
Standing Frame	Supports person with severe locomotor disability in standing position for therapy.
CP Chair	Specialised seating system for persons with cerebral palsy; postural support.
Transfer Boards	Smooth boards for lateral transfer between wheelchair and bed/car.
Grab Bars & Handrails	Fixed bathroom and stairway supports for fall prevention.

19.5 Communication & Intellectual Disability – AAC

Technology	Description
Picture Exchange Communication System (PECS)	Structured communication using picture cards; widely used for autism and ID.
Speech Generating Devices (SGD)	Electronic devices producing synthesised speech from symbols or text input.
Communication Boards	Low-tech boards with symbols, pictures, letters for non-verbal communication.
Eye-Gaze Technology	Tracks eye movement to control computer/communication device; for those with no hand function.
Switch Access Devices	Single or multiple switches activating computer or AAC device for persons with severe motor disability.
Social Stories	Narrative tools for persons with autism to understand social situations.
Visual Schedules	Visual timetables reducing anxiety and supporting independence in persons with autism/ID.
Talking Mats	Communication framework using visual symbols for decision-making.

CHAPTER AT-EXT

Emerging Assistive Technologies

AI, Robotics, Smart Devices and Future of Disability Support Tech

Artificial Intelligence in Assistive Technology

Artificial Intelligence (AI) is transforming assistive technology at an unprecedented pace. Key AI applications for disability include:

Computer Vision for Blind Users: Apps like Microsoft's Seeing AI, Google Lookout, and Be My Eyes use AI to describe scenes, read text, identify products (through barcodes), recognize currency, and even identify the emotional expressions of people in real-time. These apps run on standard smartphones, making powerful visual assistance accessible and affordable.

Natural Language Processing (NLP): Speech-to-text technology has improved dramatically. Google's Live Transcribe app provides real-time, highly accurate transcription for deaf and hard-of-hearing users. Amazon Transcribe, Microsoft Azure Speech, and Google Cloud Speech APIs enable developers to build accessible applications. Voice assistants (Alexa, Google Assistant, Siri) provide hands-free device control for persons with limited mobility.

AI Sign Language Recognition: Researchers at IIT Delhi, IIT Madras, and international institutions are developing AI systems that can recognise Indian Sign Language (ISL) gestures in real-time and translate them to text/speech. While not yet commercially deployed

at scale, these systems promise to revolutionize communication access for deaf persons in India. ISLRTC (Indian Sign Language Research and Training Centre) under DEPwD is developing an ISL corpus to support such AI development.

Cognitive Assistance: For persons with intellectual disabilities and autism, AI-powered apps can provide: step-by-step task guidance through visual prompts; reminders and scheduling assistance; social story generation; emotion recognition coaching; and adaptive learning systems that adjust to the user's pace and comprehension level.

Robotics and Exoskeleton Technology

Robotic exoskeletons represent a frontier technology with profound implications for persons with locomotor disabilities, particularly spinal cord injury and stroke. An exoskeleton is a wearable robotic device that supports or amplifies the wearer's movements through motorized joints that follow the user's intended movement, detected through sensors.

Current commercially available exoskeletons (ReWalk, Ekso, Indego, Cyberdyne HAL) enable paraplegic persons to stand and walk. They are primarily used in rehabilitation settings and are very expensive (Rs.30-60 lakh per unit) making them inaccessible for most Indian patients. However, several Indian institutions including IIT, AIIMS, and startups are developing low-cost alternatives. The government's production-linked incentive (PLI) scheme for medical devices could

potentially support indigenous exoskeleton development.

Robotic prosthetics are another frontier — myoelectric prosthetic hands controlled by electrical signals from residual muscle activity. While traditional Jaipur foot is excellent for lower limb replacement, upper limb prosthetics remain limited. AI-controlled myoelectric hands that can grip objects of varying shapes and sizes are commercially available in developed countries; Indian researchers are working on affordable versions.

Brain-Computer Interfaces (BCI)

Brain-Computer Interfaces allow persons with severe physical disability — including locked-in syndrome, high-level spinal cord injury, and ALS — to communicate and control devices using only their brain signals. BCI detects electrical activity in the brain (through EEG or implanted electrodes) and translates it into digital commands.

Non-invasive EEG-based BCIs are used in some rehabilitation centres in India. They allow users to type text, control wheelchairs, or operate computers using thought. While speeds are still limited compared to traditional typing, for severely paralyzed persons with no other communication option, BCI represents a lifeline.

Cochlear implants can be considered a form of neural interface — they directly stimulate the auditory nerve to provide hearing sensation. They are covered under ADIP scheme for eligible children. The government programme for cochlear implants has

expanded coverage over recent years with over 10,000 implants supported.

Smart Home and IoT for Independent Living

Internet of Things (IoT) enables smart home systems that dramatically enhance independent living for persons with disability. Key applications:

Voice-Controlled Smart Homes: Amazon Alexa, Google Home, and Apple HomeKit allow persons with mobility limitations to control lights, fans, air conditioning, TV, security systems, and door locks through voice commands. Integration with accessible switches, infrared controllers, and switch-adapted devices extends control to persons who cannot speak.

Smart Doorbells and Security: Video doorbells with visual alerts on phone/tablet for deaf users. Smart door locks opened by Bluetooth/fingerprint/face recognition for persons who cannot manipulate traditional locks. Visual flash alerts integrated throughout the home.

Medication Management: Automated pill dispensers with reminders via audio/visual alerts for elderly PwDs or those with memory impairment. IoT-enabled medication tracking for caregivers to monitor remotely.

Telehealth and Remote Monitoring: Wearable health monitors (blood pressure, glucose, heart rate) transmitting data to healthcare providers remotely — particularly valuable for rural PwDs with limited access to health facilities. Video consultation platforms with sign language interpretation add-ons.

CHAPTER 20

Digital Accessibility Standards & Guidelines

GIGW, WCAG, AIS 153, and India's Digital Accessibility Framework

20.1 GIGW – Guidelines for Indian Government Websites

GIGW – Compliance Standard for Government Websites

- GIGW (Guidelines for Indian Government Websites) are issued by the National Informatics Centre (NIC) and are mandatory for all government websites and mobile apps.
- Latest version aligns with WCAG 2.1 Level AA – the international accessibility standard.
- Websites must pass automated accessibility checks AND manual testing with assistive technologies.
- NIC provides accessibility audit and certification service for government portals.
- Non-compliant websites can be reported to DEPwD; Ministry of Electronics and IT (MeitY) enforces.

WCAG Principle	Requirements
Perceivable	Alt text for all images; captions for video; audio descriptions; sufficient colour contrast (4.5:1 minimum); text resize to 200% without loss of content.
Operable	Full keyboard navigation; no keyboard traps; skip navigation links; sufficient time for interactions; no flashing content; clear page titles and focus indicators.
Understandable	Language of page identified; consistent navigation; error identification and suggestions; labels for form fields; reading level appropriate.
Robust	Valid HTML/CSS; compatibility with current assistive technologies; name, role, value for all UI components; accessible status messages.

20.2 Harmonized Guidelines 2021 – Built Environment

The Harmonized Guidelines and Space Standards for Barrier Free Built Environment for Persons with Disability and Elderly Persons (2021) are published by the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA) and are mandatory for all government-funded construction in India. Key standards include:

Feature	Standard
Ramps	Maximum 1:12 gradient; minimum 1.5m width; handrails on both sides at 900mm and 700mm height.
Lifts	Minimum 1.1m x 1.4m internal; Braille on buttons; voice announcement; 900mm wide door opening.
Parking	Minimum 3.5m x 5m accessible bay; van accessible bay 3.5m x 6m; International Symbol of Accessibility.
Paths of Travel	Minimum 1.8m wide; tactile guiding blocks; rest seats every 30m on long routes.
Signage	High contrast; tactile wayfinding; pictograms; Braille equivalent.
Toilets	Minimum 1.5m x 1.75m; peninsular WC; 42-inch grab bars; knee clearance under washbasin.
Service Counters	Maximum 900mm height; knee clearance of 700mm; hearing induction loop.
Seating	Reserved accessible seats in auditoriums, theatres, stadiums at eye level.

20.3 AIS 153 – Automotive Industry Standards for Accessible Transport

AIS (Automotive Industry Standard) 153 sets standards for accessible public transport vehicles. Key requirements include:

• Low floor or level boarding buses; maximum 250mm floor height at entry

• Kneeling feature to further lower entry steps on request

• Wheelchair clamp and tie-down positions in buses

• Colour-contrasted grab handles and poles

• Audio-visual announcements of stops

• Priority seating clearly marked near doors

• Tactile path to accessible seating in buses

20.4 Sugamya Pustakalaya – Online Accessible Library

Sugamya Pustakalaya (accessible at library.gov.in) is India's national accessible digital library for persons with print disabilities. Key features:

• Over 5 lakh accessible titles in Daisy, ePUB, MP3, and BRF (Braille Ready Format) formats

• Free access for persons with visual impairment, dyslexia, and other print disabilities

• Available in multiple Indian languages

• Mobile app (iOS and Android) available

• Partnership with Bookshare (USA) for access to international collection

• Registration requires disability certificate or self-declaration

CHAPTER ACCESS-STD

Accessibility Standards – Technical Details

Complete Technical Specifications for Accessible Built Environment

Ramps – Technical Specifications

Parameter	Specification
Gradient (Slope)	Maximum 1:12 (8.33%); preferred 1:16 (6.25%) for better usability
Width	Minimum 1,500 mm (1.5 metres) clear width; 1,800 mm preferred
Handrails	Both sides; 900 mm above ramp surface (top rail); 700 mm (bottom rail for children/wheelchair users)
Handrail Projection	Extend 300 mm beyond top and bottom of ramp; round or graspable profile
Surface	Non-slip surface; visual contrast strips at top and bottom edge
Landing	1,500 × 1,500 mm flat landing at top and bottom; every 9,000 mm for long ramps
Edge Protection	Kerb or barrier on open sides; minimum 75 mm high
Colour Contrast	Ramp surface must visually contrast with adjacent floor
Tactile Warning	Tactile attention indicator strip at top and bottom edges

Accessible Lifts – Technical Specifications

Parameter	Specification
Internal Dimensions	Minimum 1,100 mm × 1,400 mm (1.1 × 1.4 metres) to accommodate wheelchair

Door Width	Minimum 900 mm clear opening width
Door Type	Horizontal sliding automatic doors; reopening sensor mandatory
Floor Level	Maximum 12 mm tolerance between lift floor and landing floor
Controls – Height	All controls 400–1,200 mm from floor; emergency call at 900 mm
Controls – Braille	Braille or raised tactile marking on all buttons
Controls – Contrast	High colour contrast between button and panel
Audio Announcement	Voice announcement of floor number, door opening/closing
Visual Display	Digital floor indicator inside and outside
Emergency Features	Emergency intercom at accessible height; battery backup for 1 hour
Handrail	On at least one (preferably three) sides; 900 mm height
Mirror	On rear wall to assist wheelchair users in reversing
Waiting Area	1,500 × 1,500 mm clear space in front of each lift at each floor

Accessible Toilets – Technical Specifications

Parameter	Specification
Minimum Size	1,500 mm × 1,750 mm for peninsular WC; 1,600 mm × 2,000 mm recommended
Door	Minimum 900 mm clear opening; outward opening OR sliding door
Turning Space	1,500 mm clear diameter turning circle inside
WC Pan	Peninsular WC with clear space on both sides; 450–480 mm from floor

Grab Bars	Horizontal bar at 700–750 mm height on both sides; 600 mm long; fold-down on one side
Washbasin	700 mm knee clearance underneath; maximum 850 mm height; lever/sensor tap
Mirror	Full-length or positioned for wheelchair users (bottom of mirror at 900 mm height)
Emergency Alarm	Pull cord or push button at 150–250 mm from floor reachable from floor
Flooring	Non-slip; colour contrast between floor and wall; colour contrast at WC and grab bars
Soap/Paper Dispenser	At accessible height: 900–1,200 mm
Signage	International Symbol of Access (ISA) on door; Braille sign; high contrast
Sanitary Bin	Foot-operated at accessible location

Accessible Parking – Technical Specifications

Parameter	Specification
Width	Minimum 3,600 mm; adjacent to access aisle of 1,200 mm; total 4,800 mm preferred
Length	Minimum 5,000 mm; 6,000 mm for van accessible bay
Quantity	2% of total parking capacity or 2 bays, whichever is more
Location	Nearest to accessible entrance of building; maximum 50 metre distance
Surface	Level; non-slip; maximum 1:50 gradient
Marking	International Symbol of Access painted on ground; reserved sign
Drop-Off Zone	Additional drop-off zone near entrance for vehicles
Path to Entrance	Continuous accessible path from parking bay to accessible entrance

WCAG 2.1 Digital Accessibility – Key Criteria

WCAG Criterion	Level	Requirement
1.1.1 Non-text Content	Level A	All images, icons have descriptive alt text; decorative images have empty alt
1.2.2 Captions	Level A	All pre-recorded audio/video content has captions
1.2.3 Audio Description	Level A	Audio description or text alternative for pre-recorded video
1.3.1 Info and Relationships	Level A	Information conveyed by formatting also available in text
1.4.1 Use of Color	Level A	Color not used as sole means of conveying information
1.4.3 Contrast (Minimum)	Level AA	Text contrast ratio 4.5:1 normal text; 3:1 large text
1.4.4 Resize Text	Level AA	Text resizable to 200% without loss of content or functionality
1.4.10 Reflow	Level AA	Content reflows at 400% zoom without horizontal scrolling
1.4.11 Non-text Contrast	Level AA	UI components, graphics: contrast ratio 3:1 against adjacent
2.1.1 Keyboard	Level A	All functionality available from keyboard without time limits
2.1.2 No Keyboard Trap	Level A	User not trapped in any component using keyboard
2.4.1 Bypass Blocks	Level A	Skip navigation link or heading structure provided
2.4.2 Page Titled	Level A	Every web page has descriptive title
2.4.3 Focus Order	Level A	Focus order preserves meaning and operability
2.4.7 Focus Visible	Level AA	Keyboard focus indicator visible
3.1.1 Language of Page	Level A	Default language of page declared in code
3.3.1 Error Identification	Level A	Error identified and described to user in text
3.3.2 Labels or Instructions	Level A	Labels for all form inputs; instructions provided
4.1.1 Parsing	Level A	Valid HTML; no duplicate IDs; properly nested elements
4.1.2 Name, Role, Value	Level A	Name, role, value for all UI components available to assistive tech

WCAG Criterion	Level	Requirement
4.1.3 Status Messages	Level AA	Status messages can be determined by software (without focus)

CHAPTER UD

Universal Design & Inclusive Design

Design Principles for Products, Environments and Services for All

Universal Design (UD) is the design of products, environments, programmes, and services to be usable by all people to the greatest extent possible, without the need for adaptation or specialized design. The concept was developed by architect Ronald Mace and colleagues at North Carolina State University in the 1970s-1980s. Universal Design differs from 'accessible design' (which focuses on persons with disabilities) in that it aims to create designs that work for everyone — children, elderly, pregnant women, tall or short persons, and persons with disabilities.

The National Education Policy 2020 specifically embraces Universal Design for Learning (UDL) as a framework for curriculum design, pedagogy, and assessment. UDL, developed by CAST (Center for Applied Special Technology) in the USA, provides three principles: Multiple Means of Representation (presenting information in multiple formats); Multiple Means of Action and Expression (allowing students to demonstrate learning in multiple ways); and Multiple Means of Engagement (stimulating interest and motivation in multiple ways). UDL benefits not only students with disabilities but all learners.

The Harmonized Guidelines 2021 for built environment incorporate Universal Design principles by making accessibility features mandatory for all new government-funded construction — not just as add-ons but as integral design elements. The Guidelines recognize that accessible design benefits everyone: ramps help parents with

prams, elderly persons, and delivery workers; tactile paving helps distracted pedestrians; clear signage helps tourists; accessible toilets accommodate temporary injuries and pregnancy.

The Seven Principles of Universal Design

1. Equitable Use

Principle: The design is useful and marketable to people with diverse abilities.

Application examples: Automatic doors that open for all; power sockets at accessible heights; step-free entrances.

2. Flexibility in Use

Principle: The design accommodates a wide range of individual preferences and abilities.

Application examples: Scissors designed for either hand; ATMs with both touch screen and keypad; adjustable desk heights.

3. Simple and Intuitive Use

Principle: Use of the design is easy to understand regardless of the user's experience, knowledge, language skills, or current concentration level.

Application examples: Pictogram-based instructions; consistent placement of controls; feedback for completed actions.

4. Perceptible Information

Principle: The design communicates necessary information effectively to the user, regardless of ambient conditions or the user's sensory abilities.

Application examples: Auditory announcements + visual display in lifts; tactile markers; colour + texture + symbol for information.

5. Tolerance for Error

Principle: The design minimizes hazards and the adverse consequences of accidental or unintended actions.

Application examples: Undo function in software; guardrails; warnings before irreversible actions; default safe settings.

6. Low Physical Effort

Principle: The design can be used efficiently and comfortably and with a minimum of fatigue.

Application examples: Lever door handles; motion-sensor lights; voice-activated controls; touchscreen interfaces.

7. Size and Space for Approach and Use

Principle: Appropriate size and space is provided for approach, reach, manipulation and use regardless of user's body size, posture, or mobility.

Application examples: Clear floor space for wheelchair users; low counters with knee clearance; reaching distance within 400-1,200mm range.

Universal Design in Indian Context

Programme	UD Application
Smart Cities Mission	Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs' Smart Cities Mission mandates Universal Design principles in city infrastructure; 100 smart cities required to comply.
AMRUT	Atal Mission for Rejuvenation and Urban Transformation funds accessible infrastructure in smaller cities and towns.
School Construction (SSA)	All schools built under Samagra Shiksha Abhiyan must comply with Universal Design guidelines including accessible toilets, ramps, and pathways.
Hospital Design (PMAY-HWC)	Pradhan Mantri Arogya Yojana Health and Wellness Centres designed with Universal Design principles.
Public Transport	Metro rail systems all designed on UD principles; BRTS in Ahmedabad and Rajkot; low-floor bus mandates under AIS 153.
Tourism (PRASHAD)	Pilgrimage Rejuvenation and Spiritual Heritage Augmentation Drive includes Universal Design for major religious sites.

CHAPTER 21

Employment Rights – Detailed Provisions

Special Employment Exchanges, Skill Training, Private Sector & Self-Employment

21.1 Special Employment Exchanges for PwDs

Section 36 of the RPWD Act requires the appropriate government to set up Special Employment Exchanges exclusively for persons with disabilities. Functions of these exchanges include:

- Registration of job-seeking PwDs
- Counselling and vocational guidance to registered PwDs
- Job placement services
- Liaison with employers for reservation implementation
- Maintenance of PwD register
- Interface with vocational rehabilitation centres
- Information dissemination about employment opportunities

21.2 NHFDC Skill Development Programmes

NHFDC implements skill development programmes in partnership with the Ministry of Skill Development & Entrepreneurship (MSDE) and other agencies. These programmes are aligned with the National Skills Qualifications Framework (NSQF):

Programme	Features
NHFDC-NSDC Partnership	Joint skill training programmes; placement linked training; employer interface.
Pradhan Mantri Kaushal Vikas Yojana (PMKVY) for PwDs	Special provisions under PMKVY for PwDs; training cost borne by NSDC; stipend provided.
ITI (Industrial Training)	Reservation of 3% seats in all government ITIs for PwDs; special fee concessions.
Polytechnic Reservations	3% reservation in polytechnic courses; accessibility norms apply.
DDU-GKY	Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Grameen Kaushalya Yojana includes PwDs as a priority target group.

21.3 Tax Benefits for PwD Employees & Employers

Provision	Details
Section 80U (Individual)	Deduction of Rs.75,000 for person with 40%+ disability; Rs.1,25,000 for severe disability (80%+). Self-declaration sufficient.
Section 80DD (Family)	Deduction for expenditure on treatment/maintenance of dependent PwD: Rs.75,000 (40%+) or Rs.1,25,000 (80%+).
Section 80DDB	Deduction for treatment of specified diseases including some disability-related conditions.
Employer Section 37	Expenditure on accessibility modifications fully deductible as business expense.
Section 37 & 80JJAA	Additional deduction of 30% of additional wages paid to new employees including PwDs for 3 years.

CHAPTER EMP2

Employment – Extended Guide

Post Identification, Backlog, Career Advancement & Self-Employment

Identification of Posts for PwD Reservation

Each Ministry/Department/Establishment is required to identify posts that can be held by persons with specified disabilities. The Office Memorandum of DoPT (dated 15.01.2018) provides the guidelines for post identification. Key principles:

- Every post must be assessed for its essential functions, not its traditional occupant's profile
- A post shall be identified for a disability category if the essential functions can be performed by a person with that disability with or without reasonable accommodation
- Physical requirements listed for a post must be genuinely required — not assumed
- The identification exercise must be carried out by a committee including: Head of Establishment, a Rehabilitation Expert, and a Representative from DEPwD
- Posts identified must be notified; the list of identified posts is publicly available on each Ministry's website
- Posts wrongly excluded from reservation can be challenged before CCPD/State Commissioner

Backlog Vacancies

If vacancies reserved for PwDs are not filled in a recruitment year, they are carried forward as 'backlog vacancies'. Key provisions:

- Backlog vacancies must be filled through a special recruitment drive within the next 3 years
- Backlog cannot be lapsed or merged with general vacancies
- No de-reservation of backlog vacancies without prior approval of DEPwD
- Establishments must maintain a separate register of backlog vacancies for PwDs
- CVC guidelines: vigilance clearance cannot be denied to PwD candidates solely for backlog recruitment
- DoPT OM 36035/3/2013-Estt(Res) provides detailed guidelines on backlog vacancy management

Career Advancement & Promotion Rights

Section 33 of RPWD Act and related DoPT OMs provide specific protections for PwD employees:

Provision	Details
Transfer Policy	PwD employees cannot be posted to inaccessible locations without their consent; posting near accessible medical facilities preferred; transfer requests for medical reasons given priority.
Promotion	If physical standards are barrier to promotion, reasonable accommodation must be provided. PwD employees cannot be bypassed for promotion solely on grounds of disability.

Training & Development	All training programmes to be conducted in accessible venues; training material in accessible formats; sign language interpreters for deaf employees.
Post-Disability Accommodation	If an employee acquires disability during service, they cannot be terminated. Must be offered an alternative post at the same or equivalent level.
Medical Reimbursement	Government employees with disability entitled to medical reimbursement for disability-related treatment and assistive technology under CGHS/CSMA rules.
Leave Provisions	PwD employees may avail special leave for medical treatment/therapy without loss of pay up to 30 days per year (DoPT guidelines).

Self-Employment & Entrepreneurship

Government actively promotes self-employment of PwDs through multiple programmes:

Scheme	Support Provided
NHFDC Loans	Concessional loans at 2-5% interest for any legal business activity; up to Rs.30 lakh.
PM SVANidhi	Street vendor scheme with working capital loans; PwD vendors given priority; Rs.10,000 to Rs.50,000 collateral-free.
Mudra Yojana	Pradhan Mantri MUDRA Yojana provides micro-enterprise loans (Shishu: 50K, Kishore: 5L, Tarun: 10L); PwDs given priority.
Stand Up India	Loans between Rs.10 lakh and Rs.1 crore for SC/ST/Women; PwDs falling in other categories also encouraged; accessible banking channels.
Startup India	Disability-specific startups eligible for tax exemptions, fast-tracking, and mentorship; DPIIT registers PwD-led startups with special recognition.

Government Procurement	Section 38 RPWD Act: preference in government procurement (GeM portal) to products made by/from establishments employing PwDs.
PM Vishwakarma	For artisan communities including PwD artisans; toolkit, training, and credit support.

CHAPTER JOBS

Government Posts Identified for PwD Reservation

Category-wise Listing of Posts Suitable for Persons with Benchmark Disabilities

Under RPWD Act Section 34 and DOPT guidelines, every government establishment must identify posts suitable for persons with benchmark disabilities. The following is a representative listing of post categories identified at central government level, organised by disability category. Each ministry/department publishes its own detailed list on its website.

Category A – Posts Suitable for Blindness and Low Vision (VH)

Group A (Gazetted)

- Scientist/Engineer (IT, software, electronics) in technical ministries
- Section Officer/Assistant Section Officer in administrative grades
- Director/Deputy Secretary (general administrative service)
- Lecturer/Professor in universities (all subjects except those requiring visual activities)
- Library and Information Officer
- Accounts Officer/Deputy Controller of Accounts
- Income Tax Officer/Customs Superintendent

- Law Officer/Legal Adviser
- Statistical Officer/Economist

Group B (Gazetted/Non-Gazetted)

- Assistant (Ministerial Grade)
- Junior Engineer (Civil/Electrical) – with accommodation
- Sub-Inspector (Accounts)
- Telephone Operator
- Supervisor (administrative)
- Tax Assistant/Revenue Clerk
- Stenographer (with screen reader adaptation)

Group C (Non-Gazetted)

- Lower Division Clerk / Upper Division Clerk
- Data Entry Operator
- Multi-Tasking Staff (office duties)
- Canteen Attendant/Helper (with supervision)
- Library Attendant
- Postal Assistant
- Sorting Assistant

Category B – Posts Suitable for Deaf and Hard of Hearing (HH)

Group A

- Engineer (all disciplines) – civil, mechanical, electrical, IT
- Scientist in research establishments
- Architect/Town Planner
- Medical Officer (most specialties)
- Veterinary Officer
- Agricultural Officer/Scientist
- Forest Officer
- Inspector of Income Tax/Central Excise

Group B

- Draughtsman/Cartographer
- Laboratory Technician
- Pharmacy Technician
- X-Ray Technician (Radiographer)
- Computer Operator
- Technical Assistant (scientific establishments)

Group C

- LDC/UDC (all clerical posts)
- Driver (light vehicles with visual alerts)
- Tradesman (skilled manual trades)
- Laboratory Assistant

- Garden Overseer
- Store Keeper

Category C – Posts for Locomotor Disability (OH)

Group A

- IAS/IPS/IFS – with suitable posting accommodation
- Central Services (all) – offices with accessible infrastructure
- Judge/Magistrate (courts must provide accessible environment)
- Defence Accounts Service
- Revenue/Customs/Income Tax services
- Railway services (all departments with accessible postings)
- Audit/Accounts Officers

Group B

- Sub-Inspector (Police) – desk duties with accommodation
- Assistant (all central services)
- Junior Engineer (desk/supervisory roles)
- Section Assistant

Group C

- All clerical posts (LDC/UDC/PA/SA)
- All technical posts where mobility is not essential

- Telephone Operator
- Record Keeper

Private Sector Employment Opportunities for PwDs

IT & Software

- Software Developer (all specialties – web, mobile, backend, AI/ML)
- Quality Assurance Engineer
- Technical Writer
- Data Analyst / Business Intelligence Analyst
- Accessibility Consultant / Tester
- IT Support Specialist
- Database Administrator
- Network Engineer (remote configuration)
- Cybersecurity Analyst

Banking & Finance

- Bank Teller (with accessible workstation)
- Loan Officer/Credit Analyst
- Financial Analyst
- Insurance Agent/Advisor
- Accounts Executive

- Chartered Accountant (self-employed)

Healthcare

- Physiotherapist / Occupational Therapist
- Speech-Language Pathologist
- Audiologist
- Nurse (with reasonable accommodation)
- Medical Transcriptionist
- Healthcare Administrator

Education & Training

- Special Educator
- School Teacher (all subjects)
- Counsellor / Guidance Counsellor
- Corporate Trainer
- Online Tutor

Creative & Arts

- Graphic Designer
- Content Writer / Editor
- Journalist
- Musician / Music Teacher
- Photographer

- Illustrator
- Video Editor

Customer Service / BPO

- Customer Support Representative (voice/non-voice)
- Data Entry Operator
- Back Office Executive
- Social Media Manager

CHAPTER INS

Insurance, Finance & Tax Planning for PwDs

Complete Guide to Insurance, Investments and Tax Benefits for Persons with Disability

Financial planning for persons with disability requires understanding the specific legal protections, tax benefits, insurance options, and investment schemes available. The combination of disability-specific benefits with standard financial planning can significantly improve economic security for PwDs and their families.

The Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) has issued circulars prohibiting insurers from discriminating against persons with disabilities in health insurance. Specifically, IRDAI circular of 2020 requires all health insurers to offer standard health insurance products to persons with specified disabilities including visual impairment, hearing impairment, locomotor disability, and intellectual disability. The 'Arogya Sanjeevani' standard health insurance product must be offered to all eligible persons including PwDs.

Persons with disabilities are entitled to special tax deductions under the Income Tax Act 1961 which can significantly reduce their tax burden. These provisions apply to PwDs themselves (Section 80U) and to families supporting a PwD dependent (Section 80DD). Both sections were substantially enhanced by Finance Act 2015, doubling the deduction amounts for severe disability. From Assessment Year 2022-23, Section 80U can be claimed with self-declaration only — no need to submit disability certificate to the employer/tax authority.

Complete Tax Benefits for PwDs and Their Families

Section 80U – Self (Individual PwD):

Disability 40-79%: Rs.75,000 deduction from gross total income; Disability 80%+: Rs.1,25,000 deduction. No requirement to incur actual expenditure — flat deduction. Claimable in ITR even if employer hasn't given benefit in Form 16.

Section 80DD – Dependent PwD:

For expenditure on MEDICAL TREATMENT, training and rehabilitation of disabled dependent (spouse, children, parents, siblings). 40-79%: Rs.75,000; 80%+: Rs.1,25,000. Also covers LIC/insurance premium paid for maintenance of disabled dependent.

Section 80DDB – Specified Diseases:

Deduction for medical treatment of specified diseases including some neurological conditions: Rs.40,000 (below 60 years) or Rs.1,00,000 (senior citizens). Requires certificate from specialist.

Section 10(16) – Scholarship Income:

Scholarship received for education of PwD is fully exempt from income tax — no upper limit.

Section 17(2) – Medical Benefits:

Medical reimbursement received from employer for disability-related treatment exempt up to Rs.15,000 per year (beyond that taxable).

HRA + Disability Deduction:

PwDs can claim both HRA exemption (if applicable) and 80U deduction simultaneously — they are not mutually exclusive.

Gift Tax Exemption:

Gifts received by PwD from specified relatives are tax-exempt; gifts for treatment of disability from non-relatives: no specific exemption but amount reasonable for medical treatment.

GST Exemptions:

Several assistive devices — wheelchairs, Braille typewriters, hearing aids, artificial limbs — are exempt from GST or taxed at 5% (concession rate).

Insurance Products for PwDs

Product	Features
Arogya Sanjeevani	Standard health insurance; Rs.1-10 lakh sum insured; must be offered to PwDs; standard premium with disability loading permissible but not refusal.
PMJAY (Ayushman Bharat)	Government health insurance Rs.5 lakh per family; BPL/SECC families; covers PwD members including disability-related procedures.
NIRAMAYA (National Trust)	For autism, CP, ID, multiple disability; Rs.1 lakh/year; Rs.250-500 premium; OPD, hospitalization, therapy covered.
PMSBY (Accident)	Pradhan Mantri Suraksha Bima Yojana: Rs.12/year premium; Rs.2 lakh for accidental death/full disability; Rs.1 lakh for partial disability. Open to all aged 18-70.

PMJJBY (Life)	Pradhan Mantri Jeevan Jyoti Bima Yojana: Rs.330/year; Rs.2 lakh on death from any cause. Open to all bank account holders 18-50.
LIC Jeevan Aadhar	Endowment policy specifically for persons with mental retardation/physical disability; matures at age 55 or death; funds managed for disabled beneficiary.
LIC Jeevan Vishwas	Traditional endowment plan; no medical examination required for sum up to Rs.50,000; suitable for PwDs who may face underwriting challenges.
Motor Insurance Discount	Persons with disability using hand-controlled/adapted vehicles entitled to reduced road tax in many states; some insurers offer motor insurance discount.

CHAPTER 22

Education Rights – Samagra Shiksha & Scholarships

Inclusive Education Framework, Scholarships & Higher Education Provisions

22.1 Samagra Shiksha – Inclusive Education Component

Samagra Shiksha is the Government of India's integrated scheme for school education covering pre-school to Class XII. It subsumes the earlier Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan (SSA), Rashtriya Madhyamik Shiksha Abhiyan (RMSA), and Teacher Education (TE) schemes. For children with disabilities, Samagra Shiksha provides substantial support:

Component	Details
Assessment & Identification	Early identification of children with special needs through functional assessment by multi-disciplinary teams at the school level.
Resource Teachers	Each block to have resource persons/special educators to support children with disability in mainstream schools.
Home-Based Education	For children with severe disability unable to attend school; teachers visit home; Rs.50/day allowance for escorting children.
Aids & Appliances	Every child identified with special needs to receive appropriate assistive device funded by Samagra Shiksha.
Therapeutic Services	Occupational therapy, speech therapy, and physiotherapy at block/cluster level to support children with disability.
Barrier-Free Infrastructure	All schools to have ramps, accessible toilets, and tactile path for visually impaired under Samagra Shiksha.
Special Training	Bridge courses and special training for children with disability who have missed schooling.

Teacher Training	All regular teachers trained in inclusive education; minimum 25 hours per year.
Scholarship	Rs.200/month for girls with disability in school; additional academic support grants.

22.2 National Fellowship for Higher Education (DEPwD)

The National Fellowship for Students with Disabilities provides financial assistance to students with disabilities for pursuing research studies (M.Phil. and Ph.D.) in universities and institutions recognized by UGC. Key features:

Parameter	Details
Number of Fellowships	200 slots per year; 2 Junior Research Fellows (JRF) + 1 Senior Research Fellow (SRF) per university per discipline
JRF Amount	Rs.31,000/month for initial 2 years
SRF Amount	Rs.35,000/month after 2 years on assessment
HRA	As per UGC norms applicable to the city of study
Contingency Grant	Rs.10,000/year for science disciplines; Rs.8,000/year for humanities
Eligibility	Person with benchmark disability; enrolled in M.Phil./Ph.D. programme; not availing any other fellowship
Application	Through UGC portal; recommendation by university/institution

22.3 Pre and Post-Matric Scholarships

DEPwD administers Pre-Matric and Post-Matric scholarships for students with disabilities studying at various levels:

Scholarship	Details
Pre-Matric (Class 9-10)	Day scholar: Rs.700/month maintenance + Rs.700 books/stationery/year. Hosteller: Rs.900/month + Rs.700 annual. 40%+ disability.
Post-Matric (Class 11+)	Maintenance allowance Rs.700-1,200/month; course fee reimbursement; travel allowance where applicable.
Top Class Education	For students admitted to NIRF top-ranked institutions. Full tuition fee + Rs.82,000/year living expenses + Rs.20,000 books.
Income Limit (Pre/Post)	Annual family income up to Rs.2.5 lakh for pre-matric; up to Rs.2.5 lakh for post-matric.
Application Portal	scholarships.gov.in – National Scholarship Portal (NSP); state-wise applications also accepted.

CHAPTER SCHOL-DE TAIL

Scholarships – Complete Details

Comprehensive Guide to Every Scholarship Available for Students with Disability

Pre-Matric Scholarship Scheme for Students with Disabilities	
Ministry / Department	DEPwD, Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment
Course Level	Class IX and X
Eligibility Criteria	• Student studying in Class IX or X in a government/aided/CBSE/state board school • Disability of 40% or more (as certified by competent authority) • Annual family income not exceeding Rs.2,50,000 per annum • Not availing any other central scholarship for same purpose
Benefits (Day Scholar)	Maintenance allowance: Rs.700/month; Books & stationery: Rs.700/year
Benefits (Hosteller)	Maintenance allowance: Rs.900/month; Books & stationery: Rs.700/year
Duration	10 months per academic year
How to Apply	Apply on National Scholarship Portal (scholarships.gov.in) by October 31 each year. Institution verification mandatory.
Documents Required	Disability certificate, income certificate, bank account, school enrollment proof, Aadhaar, mark sheet

Post-Matric Scholarship Scheme for Students with Disabilities

Ministry / Department	DEPwD, Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment
Course Level	Class XI and above (including professional/technical courses)
Eligibility Criteria	• Student studying in Class XI or above, degree, diploma, or professional course • Disability of 40% or more • Annual family income not exceeding Rs.2,50,000 per annum • Enrolled in government/aided institution
Benefits (Day Scholar)	Maintenance allowance: Rs.700-1,200/month (varies by course level); Course fee reimbursement
Benefits (Hosteller)	Maintenance allowance: Rs.900-1,500/month; Course fee reimbursement
Duration	Duration of course (1-5 years depending on course)
How to Apply	Apply on NSP by October 31. For renewal, apply by November 30.
Documents Required	Same as Pre-Matric plus institution fee receipt, admission letter

Top Class Education Scheme for Students with Disabilities	
Ministry / Department	DEPwD
Course Level	Graduate and Post-Graduate level in premier institutions
Eligibility Criteria	• Admitted to one of the NIRF top-ranked institutions (IITs, IIMs, AIIMS, NITs, NLUs etc. on approved list) • Disability of 40% or more • Annual family income not exceeding Rs.6,00,000 per annum • Not availing any other full scholarship

Benefits (Day Scholar)	Full tuition fee + Rs.3,000/month living expenses + Rs.20,000/year for books
Benefits (Hosteller)	Full tuition fee + hostel fee + Rs.82,000/year living + Rs.20,000/year books
Duration	Duration of the approved course
How to Apply	Apply on NSP. Separate slot for Top Class. Approval by DEPwD directly.
Documents Required	Disability certificate, income certificate, admission letter from premier institute, fee structure

National Fellowship for Students with Disabilities	
Ministry / Department	DEPwD / UGC
Course Level	M.Phil and Ph.D. (Research degrees)
Eligibility Criteria	• Enrolled in M.Phil or Ph.D. programme in a UGC-recognized university • Benchmark disability (40%+) • Not availing any other fellowship (UGC JRF, CSIR JRF, ICSSR, ICMR etc.) • For Ph.D.: must have cleared entrance test (GATE/NET/university entrance)
Benefits (Day Scholar)	JRF: Rs.31,000/month (first 2 years); SRF: Rs.35,000/month (after 2 years on assessment)
Benefits (Hosteller)	Same as above; HRA as per UGC norms applicable in the city
Duration	JRF: 2 years; SRF: up to 3 more years (total max 5 years)
How to Apply	Apply through UGC portal. University must recommend. DEPwD approves.

Documents Required	Disability certificate, enrollment letter, entrance test scorecard, supervisor's consent

Samagra Shiksha – In-School Support Grants	
Ministry / Department	Ministry of Education (not DEPwD)
Course Level	Pre-primary to Class XII
Eligibility Criteria	• All children with special needs enrolled in government/government-aided schools • No income limit; no minimum disability percentage for school-level support
Benefits (Day Scholar)	Rs.200/month for girls with disability; Rs.3,000-5,000/year for assistive devices; home-based education stipend for caregivers
Benefits (Hosteller)	Residential facilities for disabled children; Rs.1,500/month hostel grant (varies)
Duration	Throughout school education (till Class XII)
How to Apply	No separate application needed; enrollment in school automatic inclusion; resource teacher identifies needs
Documents Required	School enrollment; disability certificate (if available; not mandatory at school level)

State Government Scholarships (Examples)	
Ministry / Department	Various State Education/Social Welfare Departments
Course Level	All levels (varies by state)

Eligibility Criteria	• Varies by state: generally 40%+ disability; income limits vary • State domicile required
Benefits (Day Scholar)	Varies widely: Rs.200-2,000/month depending on state and level
Benefits (Hosteller)	Varies; some states provide full hostel fee reimbursement
Duration	Duration of course
How to Apply	Apply on State Scholarship Portal or NSP (state component). Deadlines vary.
Documents Required	Same as central plus state domicile certificate

CHAPTER NEP

National Education Policy 2020 & Disability

NEP 2020 Vision for Inclusive Education for PwDs

NEP 2020 Foundational Principles for Disability Inclusion

The National Education Policy 2020 is India's first comprehensive education policy in over three decades (replacing NPE 1986). Disability inclusion is embedded throughout the policy rather than being treated as a separate chapter — a significant philosophical shift. The policy states that 'the education system must prioritize the education of students with disabilities' and lays down specific commitments.

NEP 2020 commits to ensuring that every child, including those with disabilities, has access to quality education, special provisions, and support within the regular school system to the extent possible. It specifically endorses the concept of 'universal design for learning' (UDL) — designing curriculum and teaching methods that can be accessed and understood by all students, reducing the need for individual accommodation.

Key NEP 2020 commitments for students with disability include: setting up cross-disability resource centres at block level; training all teachers in inclusive education principles (minimum 40 hours pre-service + annual in-service); developing curriculum materials in multiple formats (print, audio, Braille, video); promoting sign bilingual

education for deaf students; strengthening vocational education for students with disability at secondary and higher secondary level.

NEP 2020's emphasis on the mother tongue and multilingual education has positive implications for deaf students — it opens the door for official recognition of sign language as a medium of instruction, something Deaf advocates have long sought. The policy's framework for alternative and flexible pathways to certification (including NIOS and open schooling) benefits students with disability who cannot follow conventional school routes.

Higher Education and Disability in NEP 2020

For higher education, NEP 2020 envisions large multidisciplinary universities and colleges where all courses are offered in flexible credit-based systems. This has positive implications for students with disability who may need to take fewer courses per semester due to medical or disability-related reasons.

The Academic Bank of Credits (ABC) established under NEP 2020 allows students to accumulate credits from multiple institutions and complete degrees flexibly. This directly benefits students with disability who may need to interrupt studies for medical treatment or who benefit from different learning environments at different stages.

NEP 2020 emphasizes vocational education integration with mainstream education from Class 6 onwards. For students with intellectual disabilities, learning disabilities, and autism, this vocational emphasis creates a more meaningful and relevant educational pathway beyond academic subjects. The policy

mandates that higher education institutions offer multiple exit points with appropriate qualifications — particularly relevant for students who may not complete a full degree programme.

Research on disability is specifically mentioned in NEP 2020 as an area requiring greater emphasis. Indian universities are encouraged to develop disability studies programmes, conduct research on inclusive education, and collaborate with DEPwD and National Institutes on disability-related research. The National Research Foundation (NRF) established under NEP 2020 can fund disability-related research.

NEP 2020 Implementation Targets for Disability

Target	Details
Universal Elementary Education	100% enrollment and retention of children with disability by 2030 under NEP 2020 vision.
Teacher Training	All teacher education programmes to include compulsory inclusive education module; 40 hours minimum.
Block Resource Centres	Cross-disability resource centres at block level with AT devices, resource materials, and specialist support.
Digital Education	All DIKSHA platform content to be fully accessible; accessible e-textbooks under e-Pathshala.
Vocational Integration	Vocational education from Class 6; disability-appropriate vocational tracks developed.
Higher Education Credit System	Academic Bank of Credits enabling flexible completion for students with disability.
Sign Language Education	Recognition and support for ISL-based education for deaf students; training of ISL teachers.
Gifted PwD Students	Identification and nurturing of exceptionally talented students with disability.

CHAPTER LD Specific Learning Disabilities

Dyslexia, Dyscalculia, Dysgraphia – Rights and Educational Support

Specific Learning Disabilities (SLD) are a group of neuro-developmental conditions that affect the acquisition and use of basic academic skills in reading, writing, and arithmetic. They are not caused by inadequate intelligence, sensory impairment, poor teaching, or socioeconomic factors — they reflect differences in how the brain processes information. SLDs were included as a disability category under the RPWD Act 2016, giving persons with these conditions access to educational accommodations, examination supports, and employment reservations for the first time.

The three primary types of SLD recognized in India are: Dyslexia (reading disorder), affecting approximately 5-10% of the school population; Dyscalculia (mathematics disorder), affecting approximately 3-7%; and Dysgraphia (written expression disorder), often co-occurring with dyslexia. Many individuals have more than one type of SLD. Other recognized learning disabilities include: Dyspraxia/Developmental Coordination Disorder affecting motor planning and coordination; Non-Verbal Learning Disability affecting spatial and social processing; and Language Processing Disorder affecting spoken language comprehension.

The late recognition of SLD in India — it was not included in the 1995 Persons with Disabilities Act — meant that generations of students with dyslexia and other SLDs were mislabeled as 'slow learners,' 'lazy,' or 'unintelligent,' and denied the support they needed. Many highly capable individuals failed in the educational system not

because of lack of intelligence but because the system did not accommodate their learning differences. The RPWD Act 2016 rectified this historical exclusion.

Diagnosis of SLD requires a comprehensive psycho-educational evaluation by a qualified psychologist (RCI-registered). The evaluation typically includes: standardized intelligence testing (to establish cognitive potential); standardized academic achievement tests (reading fluency, reading comprehension, spelling, written expression, mathematics); phonological processing assessment; memory and attention testing; and exclusion of other causes. The NIMHANS battery and Dyslexia Assessment for Languages of India (DALI) are commonly used tools. Diagnosis should be made in the child's preferred language.

Educational Accommodations for Students with SLD

Accommodation	Details
Examination Scribe	Full scribe entitlement for all students with dyslexia/SLD with disability certificate; scribe at no cost from examination body.
Extra Time	33% extra time (20 min per hour) in all examinations from Class 1 to professional/competitive level.
Exemption from Third Language	Exemption from third language study at school level for students with SLD; available in CBSE and most state boards.
Oral Examinations	Substitution of written examination with oral examination for severe dysgraphia/dyslexia at school level where permitted.

Alternative Format	Question papers in dyslexia-friendly font (Arial/Comic Sans, 12pt minimum, increased spacing).
Assistive Technology	Use of word processor with spell-check for written examinations; text-to-speech software; calculator for dyscalculia in non-math exams.
Seating Arrangement	Separate seating from general candidates to reduce anxiety and allow reading assistance.
Modified Curriculum	Not a separate/reduced curriculum but modified delivery: multi-sensory instruction, visual learning, reduced copying.
Resource Room	Access to resource room with special educator for support learning; included in Samagra Shiksha.
Portfolio Assessment	Alternative assessment through portfolio, projects, and oral presentations recognized by some progressive institutions.

SLD Certification and the Disability Certificate Process

The certification of Specific Learning Disability is done by a Clinical Psychologist (RCI registered) at a government hospital or recognized assessment centre. The RPWD Rules 2017 specify that for SLD, the certifying authority is a team comprising: a Paediatrician or Child Psychiatrist (who signs the certificate) and a Clinical Psychologist (who conducts the assessment). Unlike physical disabilities, where the percentage of disability is based on clinical measurements, SLD assessment relies on psychometric testing.

The disability certificate for SLD specifies: type of SLD (dyslexia/dyscalculia/dysgraphia etc.); severity (mild/moderate/severe); impact on functioning; and any specific accommodations recommended. The Ministry of Education's 2019

SOP for Specific Learning Disabilities provides detailed guidance on assessment and certification process that has been adopted by most state governments.

Common challenges in SLD certification: (a) lack of trained psychologists in rural and semi-urban areas; (b) long waiting lists at government hospitals; (c) high cost of private assessment (Rs.3,000-10,000) which is a barrier for low-income families; (d) lack of assessment tools in regional languages; (e) variability in assessment quality. The government is working to expand assessment capacity through trained school psychologists and online screening tools.

CHAPTER EXT

Extended Rights Analysis

Detailed Rights Provisions, Judicial Interpretations & International Comparisons

Right to Political Participation

Article 326 of the Indian Constitution guarantees universal adult suffrage. The RPWD Act 2016 and Election Commission guidelines reinforce political rights of PwDs:

Right	Provision
Voting Rights	All PwDs have equal right to vote. Postal ballot available. Accessible polling booths mandatory.
Electoral Roll	PwD voters identified and mapped for accessible booth allocation. Separate BLO facilitation.
Contesting Elections	No disability can disqualify a person from contesting elections (Representation of People Act).
Braille EVMs	EVM with Braille labels introduced for visually impaired voters in several states.
PwD Voters App	ECI app helps PwD voters find nearest accessible booth and request transport.
Voter ID	Accessible Voter ID registration process; EPIC card issued; home enrollment for severely disabled.

Right to Housing

While RPWD Act does not have a specific housing provision, multiple government programmes ensure housing rights of PwDs:

Scheme/Provision	Details

PM Awas Yojana (Urban)	Priority allotment to PwD applicants; ground floor preference; accessible design specifications for PwD units.
PM Awas Yojana (Rural)	Priority under PMAY-G for BPL PwD families; additional Rs.15,000 for accessibility modifications (ramp etc.).
Indira Awaas Yojana Successor	Housing for BPL rural families including PwDs; preference in allotment.
RPWD Act Section 40	Accessible building standards mandatory for all new government-funded construction.
RWA Accessibility	Residential Welfare Associations cannot deny common area access to wheelchair users.
Rental Discrimination	Denial of rental accommodation on grounds of disability is discrimination under Section 3 RPWD Act.

Right to Social Protection

Section 24 of RPWD Act and related provisions establish social protection rights:

- Disability pension under IGNDPS and state schemes
- Free food under Public Distribution System (PDS) with priority ration cards for BPL PwDs
- Free LPG connections under Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana with PwD priority
- National Food Security Act: PwDs from BPL families entitled to 5 kg food grains per month at subsidized rates
- Pradhan Mantri Suraksha Bima Yojana: Accident insurance Rs.2 lakh coverage at Rs.12/year premium; special provisions for PwDs
- ESIC benefits for PwD employees in the organised sector

• EPFO: Special provisions for PwDs regarding early withdrawal of PF

Judicial Interpretations of Disability Rights

Rajive Raturi v. Union of India (2018), Supreme Court

Supreme Court directed all public spaces, government buildings, transport, and digital interfaces to be made accessible within a specified timeframe. Court recognized accessibility as a fundamental right flowing from Articles 14, 19, and 21.

National Federation of the Blind v. Union Public Service Commission (1993), Supreme Court

Landmark judgment affirming reservation rights of visually impaired in civil services. Held that UPSC cannot exclude visually impaired persons from jobs that can be performed with accommodation.

Disabled Rights Group v. Union of India (2012), Delhi High Court

Delhi HC directed all government premises to be made barrier-free. Held that accessibility is a right, not charity, and that inaccessible government buildings violate the right to life under Article 21.

Vikash Kumar v. UPSC (2021), Supreme Court

SC held that UPSC must provide scribes and compensatory time to all persons with benchmark disabilities including those with locomotor disabilities and learning disabilities. Narrowing of eligibility criteria for scribes was struck down.

State of Himachal Pradesh v. A Parent (2017), HP High Court

HP HC held that a school's refusal to admit a child with autism on grounds of 'disruption to other students' is unconstitutional and violates both RTE Act and the then-PwD Act (now RPWD Act).

CHAPTER SEC

Sector-Specific Accessibility Guides

Detailed Provisions for Transport, Banking, Healthcare & Justice

Transport Accessibility

Indian Railways

A1 and A category stations (major stations) must be fully accessible. Provision of: ramps, lifts, accessible toilets, tactile blocks, low-floor coaches, braille signage, audio-visual announcement systems. Concessions: 50-75% fare concession for PwDs and one escort on all classes. Reserved berths in each train for PwDs (minimum 2 berths per train). Divyang-friendly coach in selected trains. Online booking: irctc.co.in has PwD booking quota; lower berth allotment priority; PwD ID proof required for booking.

Air Travel

DGCA (Directorate General of Civil Aviation) Circular CAR Section 3 Series M Part I provides comprehensive rights for PwD air travelers: no airline can refuse boarding solely on grounds of disability; wheelchair assistance mandatory at all airports and on aircraft; medical clearance can only be required if there is specific medical concern, not routine. Airports Authority of India: all AAI airports to be fully accessible including: accessible parking, ramps, lifts, accessible toilets, assistance desks, aerobridge access. Fare concession: 50% on domestic routes for blind and orthopedic PwDs.

Public Bus Transport

AIS 153 standards mandate low-floor buses for urban bus services. State Transport Undertakings (STUs) to provide: reserved seats near doors; audio-visual stop announcements; colour-contrasted grab rails; wheelchair securement positions in low-floor buses. Many states provide free/concessional bus passes for PwDs (e.g., Delhi: free unlimited bus travel; Tamil Nadu: 50% concession; Maharashtra: concessional pass).

Metro Rail

All metro rail systems in India (Delhi Metro, Mumbai Metro, Bengaluru Metro etc.) designed to be fully accessible from the start: accessible entry/exit, platform screen doors with gap fillers, accessible coaches with wheelchair space, priority seating, audio-visual announcements, tactile paving, accessible ticket counters and ATVMs.

Banking & Financial Services Accessibility

Provision	Details
RBI Guidelines on Banking for PwDs	RBI circular (2008, updated 2020) requires all banks to provide accessible banking services. Includes: no denial of account; reasonable accommodation; accessible premises; doorstep banking for PwDs.
Doorstep Banking	All banks must offer doorstep banking to PwDs who cannot visit branches. Request by phone or online; bank staff visits home for basic transactions.

Accessible ATMs	RBI directs banks to install 'talking ATMs' and accessible ATMs with Braille keypads. Target: 33% of ATMs to be accessible (Work in progress).
Account Opening without Physical Visit	PwDs can open accounts through banking correspondent or doorstep service without visiting branch.
Simplified KYC	For PwDs unable to provide standard biometric (fingerprint/iris) due to disability, video-based KYC or alternative acceptable.
Net Banking Accessibility	Banks directed to make internet banking portals WCAG 2.0 compliant; screen reader compatible; keyboard navigable.
Section 80U Tax Deduction	Banks/TDS deductors must accept self-declaration under 80U for reduced TDS without disability certificate (from AY 2022-23).
Insurance	IRDAI circular prohibits insurers from refusing health insurance to PwDs solely on grounds of disability; riders available for pre-existing disability conditions.

Healthcare Accessibility – Detailed Provisions

- All government hospitals must have accessible parking with reserved spaces near main entrance
- Accessible entry, ramps, and lifts in all government health facilities
- Accessible registration counters at accessible height with hearing induction loop
- Sign language interpreter services for deaf patients on request at major hospitals
- Braille and large print discharge summaries available at government hospitals (target)
- Accessible toilet in all government hospital wards and OPDs

• Priority token/queue management for PwD patients

• Free medicines from PMBJP Jan Aushadhi Kendras for BPL PwDs

• Ayushman Bharat PMJAY: Rs.5 lakh health cover per family; PwDs from poor families covered

• CGHS (for government employees): covers PwD employees and their dependents with disability

• Mental Health Act 2017: Free mental healthcare at government mental health establishments for all; no discrimination

• Early intervention: ICDS centres to screen children for developmental delays and refer for therapy

Access to Justice for PwDs

Provision	Details
Section 84 – Special Courts	State Governments to designate one or more sessions courts as Special Courts for each district to try offences against PwDs.
Section 85 – Special Public Prosecutor	Government shall appoint a Special Public Prosecutor in each Special Court.
Legal Aid – NALSA	Persons with disabilities entitled to free legal services under Legal Services Authorities Act 1987. Includes legal advice, representation, and mediation.
Police Accessibility	Police stations to be accessible. Complaints by PwDs to be recorded sensitively; magistrate's/companion's presence allowed.
Court Accessibility	All courts to be progressively made accessible. Sign language interpreters for deaf witnesses/accused. Alternative testimony formats accepted.

Victim Compensation	Under victim compensation schemes (Section 357A CrPC), PwD victims of crime eligible for enhanced compensation.
Section 91 – Enhanced Penalties	Enhanced imprisonment (6 months to 5 years) and fine for intentional insult, humiliation, or sexual exploitation of PwD.

CHAPTER ENFORCE

Rights Enforcement – Complete Practical Guide

Step-by-Step Guide to Asserting and Enforcing Every Disability Right

How to File a Complaint with the State Commissioner for PwDs

The State Commissioner for Persons with Disabilities is the primary quasi-judicial authority at the state level for redressal of disability rights violations. Established under Section 79 of the RPWD Act 2016, the State Commissioner has the power to inquire into complaints regarding deprivation of rights of persons with disabilities, review safeguards, and recommend remedial measures to the State Government. The Commissioner has the powers of a Civil Court for conducting inquiries — including the power to summon witnesses and examine documents.

STEP 1 — PREPARE YOUR COMPLAINT: Write a clear, factual complaint letter describing: (a) your name, address, and disability details; (b) the person/institution against whom you are complaining; (c) the specific right that has been violated; (d) the date and circumstances of the violation; (e) what relief you are seeking. Attach supporting documents: disability certificate, UDID card, any correspondence with the violating party, photographs, or witness statements.

STEP 2 — SUBMIT THE COMPLAINT: File the complaint with the State Commissioner's office by hand or by registered post. The

complaint may also be submitted online on the State Commissioner's portal if available. There is no filing fee. The complaint must be acknowledged within 3 working days under RPWD Rules.

STEP 3 — INQUIRY PROCESS: The State Commissioner will fix a date for hearing. Both parties will be given an opportunity to present their case. The Commissioner may summon records, call witnesses, and visit the site of violation. The inquiry must be completed within 60 days of receipt of complaint.

STEP 4 — ORDER: After inquiry, the Commissioner passes an order directing the violating party to take specified remedial action within a specified time. The order is binding. Non-compliance can be reported back to the Commissioner who can take further action including recommending penalty proceedings.

STEP 5 — APPEAL: If dissatisfied with the Commissioner's order, either party can appeal to the High Court within 60 days of the order. The High Court may hear the appeal directly or through a Bench designated for disability matters.

IMPORTANT: You do not need a lawyer to file a complaint with the State Commissioner. However, for complex matters, free legal aid from NALSA/DLSA is available. The proceedings are meant to be accessible — if you need an interpreter or accessible communication, inform the Commissioner's office in advance.

How to Claim Your 4% Employment Reservation

The 4% reservation in government employment under Section 34 of RPWD Act applies to all government establishments including Central Government ministries, PSUs, autonomous bodies, state government departments, and local bodies. Here is how to claim it:

STEP 1 — CHECK THE VACANCY ANNOUNCEMENT: When a government vacancy is announced, check whether posts reserved for PwDs are included in the advertisement. The advertisement must mention: total vacancies; vacancies reserved for each PwD category (OH, VH, HH, Others); eligibility criteria; and how to apply under PwD quota.

STEP 2 — VERIFY POST IDENTIFICATION: Every government job advertisement should identify posts suitable for specific disability categories. If the post you are applying for is not identified as suitable for your disability, you can check the 'post identification list' published by the ministry/department on its website. If you believe the post should have been identified for your category, you can challenge this.

STEP 3 — APPLY UNDER PwD QUOTA: In the application form, clearly indicate that you are applying under the PwD quota. Upload your disability certificate or UDID card. Some forms have a separate section for PwD applicants.

STEP 4 — CLAIM EXAMINATION ACCOMMODATION: While applying, also request examination accommodations you need (scribe, extra time, accessible venue, assistive device) along with your application and disability certificate.

STEP 5 — DOCUMENT YOUR APPLICATION: Keep copies of your application, disability certificate, and all correspondence. Note your

application number.

STEP 6 — IF NOT SHORTLISTED DESPITE ELIGIBILITY: If you meet all criteria but are not shortlisted despite vacancies existing in the PwD quota, file a representation to the recruiting authority. If unresolved, file a complaint with the Equal Opportunity Officer of the establishment, or with the State/Chief Commissioner.

STEP 7 — AFTER SELECTION: On appointment, inform HR of any workplace accommodation needs. Submit reasonable accommodation request in writing. If refused, escalate to Equal Opportunity Officer within the establishment.

How to Enforce Accessibility Rights

If a government building, public transport system, or government website is inaccessible, you have the right to demand accessibility under Sections 40-46 of RPWD Act. Here is the enforcement pathway:

STEP 1 — DOCUMENT THE INACCESSIBILITY: Take photographs or videos of the inaccessible feature (steps without ramp, inaccessible toilet, non-functional lift, website without alt text etc.). Note the date, time, location, and specific barrier.

STEP 2 — REPORT THROUGH SUGAMYA BHARAT APP: Download the Sugamya Bharat app on your smartphone (available on Android Play Store and Apple App Store). Log in and submit an accessibility complaint with photographs and location details. This creates a national record of inaccessibility.

STEP 3 — FORMAL WRITTEN COMPLAINT: Send a written complaint to: (a) the head of the institution (hospital, court, government office etc.); (b) the Public Works Department (PWD) responsible for the building; (c) the State Commissioner for Persons with Disabilities. Cite RPWD Act Sections 40-46 and the Harmonized Guidelines 2021.

STEP 4 — USE RTI: File a Right to Information application asking: (a) when the accessibility audit of the building was last conducted; (b) what was the result of the audit; (c) what is the time-bound action plan for making the building accessible. RTI is a powerful tool — it puts the institution on record and creates accountability.

STEP 5 — APPROACH COMMISSIONER/COURT: If no action is taken within a reasonable time (60-90 days), file a formal complaint with the State Commissioner. For persistent systemic inaccessibility, a Public Interest Litigation (PIL) in the High Court has been used effectively (e.g., the Karnataka HC case on hospital accessibility).

How to Avail Education Rights

Students with disabilities have multiple enforceable rights in education. Here is a practical guide to asserting them at different stages:

SCHOOL ADMISSION: If a school (government or aided) refuses admission on grounds of disability, immediately obtain a written refusal reason. File a complaint with the Block Education Officer (BEO) and the State Commissioner. The RTE Act Section 3 and

RPWD Act Section 16 both prohibit denial of admission on grounds of disability.

EXAMINATION ACCOMMODATION REQUEST: Submit a written application to the school principal or examination controller at least 2 months before the examination. Attach your disability certificate. Specify exactly what accommodation you need (scribe, extra time, accessible venue, etc.). If the school refuses, contact the State Commissioner and the exam board directly.

COLLEGE/UNIVERSITY ADMISSION: Apply under the 5% PwD reservation quota. If the institution refuses to count you under the PwD quota or doesn't have the required 5% seats, contact the Equal Opportunity Cell (EOC) of the institution. If no EOC exists, contact UGC (for central universities) or State Higher Education Department (for state universities).

SCHOLARSHIP APPLICATION: Apply on National Scholarship Portal (scholarships.gov.in) by October 31 each year. If your application is rejected without valid reason, appeal to NSP helpline. If scholarship amount is not disbursed after approval, contact your bank and the scholarship authority. PFMS system tracks all payments.

NATIONAL FELLOWSHIP: For M.Phil/Ph.D students, apply through UGC portal. Your supervisor and head of department must endorse. If not selected despite eligibility, seek feedback and reapply. Consider alternative funding through ICSSR, ICMR, or DST fellowships which also have PwD provisions.

CHAPTER TYPE

Disability-Type Specific Guides

Rights, Schemes, Technology and Resources for Each of the 21 Disability Categories

1. Blindness

Blindness is defined under RPWD Act 2016 as a condition where a person has visual acuity of less than 3/60 or less than 10 degrees of visual field in the better eye with best possible correction. India has one of the largest numbers of blind persons globally, with an estimated 8-9 million people with severe visual impairment or blindness.

Disability Certificate: Issued by ophthalmologist with minimum 3 years experience at government hospital.

ADIP Devices: White canes, smart canes, DAISY audio book players, Braille kits, talking calculators.

NHFDC Loans: Available for self-employment; special focus on telephone booths, small shops, services sector.

Employment: Many roles suitable: telephone operators, computer-based roles (with screen readers), teaching, counselling, massage therapy, music.

Screen Readers: NVDA (free), JAWS (paid) for Windows; VoiceOver (iOS); TalkBack (Android). Government websites must be WCAG compliant.

Sugamya Pustakalaya: 5 lakh+ books in accessible formats at library.gov.in — free access.

Railway Concession: 75% concession in all classes including one escort; reservable through IRCTC PwD quota.

Tax Deduction: 80U deduction of Rs.1,25,000 per annum (severe disability).

2. Low Vision

Low vision is defined as a condition where a person has impairment of visual functioning even after treatment or standard refractive correction with visual acuity of less than 6/18 to 3/60 or a visual field of less than 40 to 10 degrees. Low vision differs from blindness in that residual vision exists and can be maximized through aids and training.

Devices Available: Optical magnifiers, CCTV magnification, video magnifiers, contrast-enhancing spectacles, screen magnification software.

Certification: By ophthalmologist; visual acuity and field tested with best correction.

Workplace Accommodation: Enlarged display screens, adjustable lighting, high-contrast materials, anti-glare screens.

Educational Support: Large print textbooks, seating near board, enlarged question papers in exams.

ADIP Coverage: Low vision aids covered under ADIP scheme for eligible income group.

3. Deaf

Deafness is defined under RPWD Act as hearing loss of 70 decibels and above in better ear. India has an estimated 6+ million deaf persons. The deaf community has a rich cultural identity centered around Indian Sign Language (ISL), which was officially recognized by the government in 2016 as a full-fledged language with the establishment of Indian Sign Language Research and Training Centre (ISLRTC) under DEPwD.

Indian Sign Language (ISL): Official sign language of India; 300,000+ users; ISL interpreters trained by ISLRTC; ISL dictionary published.

Hearing Aids: Not effective for profound deafness (70+ dB); cochlear implant is medical intervention of choice.

Cochlear Implant: Surgical implant for profound deaf; covered under ADIP scheme for eligible children below 5 years.

Communication: ISL interpreters at courts, hospitals, government offices; video relay services; captioning.

Education: Total communication approach in special schools; inclusive education with ISL interpreters; residential schools for deaf.

Employment: Many roles suitable: IT, design, accounting, manufacturing, arts; accommodation: visual alerts, captioned

meetings.

Railway Concession: 50% concession on travel; reserved berth in sleeper class.

4. Hard of Hearing

Hard of hearing is defined as hearing loss of 60 decibels and above but less than 70 decibels in the better ear. Persons with hard of hearing typically use hearing aids and can communicate orally with amplification. They may or may not use sign language.

Hearing Aids: Digital BTE, ITE, CIC hearing aids covered under ADIP scheme. Programmable hearing aids for better adaptation.

FM Systems: Wireless FM microphone systems for classroom and meeting use; transmit directly to hearing aid.

Telecoil/Loop: Induction loop systems in theatres, courts, banks provide direct signal to hearing aids with T-coil.

Captioning: Real-time captioning at lectures, meetings, conferences using stenography or AI; Google Live Transcribe app.

Workplace: Written instructions; visual alerts for fire alarms, doorbells; appropriate seating in meetings.

5. Locomotor Disability

Locomotor disability includes any disability of the bones, joints, or muscles leading to substantial restriction of the movement of the limbs or any form of cerebral palsy. It is the most prevalent disability category in India (Census 2011: 20.3% of all PwDs). Causes include poliomyelitis, spinal cord injury, cerebral palsy, muscular dystrophy, and various orthopedic conditions.

Prosthetics: Jaipur foot (lower limb prosthetic by BMVSS) — most widely used below-knee prosthetic globally; free from Bhagwan Mahaveer Viklang Sahayata Samiti (BMVSS) clinics; also under ADIP.

Orthotics: Callipers, AFO, KAFO, spinal braces — fitted at ALIMCO, DDRCs, government hospitals. Required for polio, cerebral palsy, spinal injury.

Wheelchairs: Manual and motorised wheelchairs under ADIP. Sports wheelchairs for athletes through Paralympic Committee of India.

Tricycles: Hand-operated tricycles for lower limb disability; foot-operated for upper limb disability; under ADIP.

Cerebral Palsy: CP chair, standing frame, postural support systems; specialized seating; National Trust programs.

Home Modification: Under PMAY, Rs.15,000 for ramp construction; home modification grants from state schemes.

Driving: Hand controls available for vehicles; driving license available for locomotor PwDs with appropriate vehicle modification.

Sports: Wheelchair basketball, para-athletics, powerlifting, swimming, archery, shooting — Paralympic sports federation

support.

9. Autism Spectrum Disorder (ASD)

Autism Spectrum Disorder is a neuro-developmental condition characterized by challenges with social communication and interaction, and restricted or repetitive behaviors, interests, or activities. ASD exists on a spectrum ranging from mild to severe. India has an estimated 1.8 million children with autism. The National Trust specifically serves persons with autism through multiple programmes.

National Trust: Primary body for welfare of persons with autism; DISHA (early intervention), VIKAAS (vocational training), NIRAMAYA (health insurance), GHARAUNDA (residential care).

Early Intervention: DISHA centres across India for children 0-10 years; applied behavior analysis (ABA), speech therapy, OT, social skills training.

Education: Inclusive education in regular schools with resource room support; special schools for severe autism; NEP 2020 emphasizes inclusive education.

AAC: Augmentative and Alternative Communication devices for non-verbal children with autism; PECS, SGDs, communication boards.

NIRAMAYA Insurance: Health insurance up to Rs.1 lakh/year at Rs.250-500 premium; covers OPD, hospitalization, therapy.

Legal Protection: Section 91 RPWD Act: enhanced penalties for abuse of autistic persons; limited guardianship through National Trust.

Sensory Support: Sensory-friendly environments; noise-cancelling headphones; weighted blankets; fidget tools — for sensory processing challenges.

10. Mental Illness

Mental illness includes any mental disorder as defined in the Mental Healthcare Act 2017. This includes schizophrenia, bipolar disorder, depression, anxiety disorders, OCD, and others. Historically stigmatized, mental illness is now included as a recognized disability under RPWD Act 2016, a landmark step. Persons with mental illness experiencing long-term functional impairment are covered.

Mental Healthcare Act 2017: Right to access mental healthcare; free treatment at government mental health establishments; no discrimination; right to supported decision-making.

Community Mental Health: National Mental Health Programme (NMHP) focuses on community-based care through district mental health programmes.

Certification: By psychiatrist with minimum 3 years experience; disability percentage based on functional impairment.

Half-Way Homes: DDRS-funded residential facilities for persons with mental illness transitioning from hospital to community.

NIMHANS Services: National Institute of Mental Health and Neuro Sciences, Bengaluru — premier research and treatment centre; partial free services.

IHBAS: Institute of Human Behaviour and Allied Sciences, Delhi — government hospital for mental health; inpatient and outpatient.

De-stigmatization: RPWD Act recognition itself reduces stigma; legal protections against discrimination in employment, housing.

CHAPTER MH Mental Health & Disability

Mental Illness as Disability – Rights, Services and Resources

Mental illness was formally recognized as a disability category under the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act 2016 for the first time in Indian legislative history. This landmark recognition acknowledges the significant functional impairments that persons with severe mental illnesses experience in their daily lives, employment, relationships, and participation in society. The RPWD Act defines mental illness as 'any mental disorder as defined in the Mental Healthcare Act 2017.' This broad definition covers schizophrenia, bipolar disorder, major depressive disorder, obsessive compulsive disorder, post-traumatic stress disorder, anxiety disorders, and other conditions causing significant functional impairment.

The recognition of mental illness as a disability is not automatic or universal. A person with mental illness becomes a 'person with disability' under RPWD Act only when the mental disorder results in long-term functional impairment — i.e., when the condition significantly limits their ability to perform daily activities, maintain employment, sustain relationships, or participate in society. Episodic mental illness that is well-controlled with medication and does not cause lasting functional limitation may not qualify as a disability under the Act. The disability assessment is done by a psychiatrist with minimum 3 years of experience at a government hospital, who evaluates the degree of functional impairment.

The Mental Healthcare Act 2017 (MHCA 2017) complements the RPWD Act in establishing the rights framework for persons with

mental illness. MHCA 2017 was a landmark legislation that fundamentally transformed the legal landscape for mental health in India. Key provisions include: the right to access mental healthcare; the right to make advance directives (stating preferences for treatment in case of future incapacity); the right to nominate a representative; the right to community living and not to be institutionalized unnecessarily; and the right to equality of treatment in health insurance. MHCA 2017 also decriminalized attempt to suicide, recognizing suicidal behavior as a mental health crisis requiring care and support rather than criminal punishment — a humane and scientifically grounded reform.

National Mental Health Programme (NMHP) was launched in 1982 and has been the primary vehicle for community-based mental health service delivery in India. The District Mental Health Programme (DMHP), operational in over 700 districts, provides: outpatient psychiatric services at district hospitals; crisis intervention and emergency psychiatric care; community outreach through trained community health workers; school mental health programmes; rehabilitation services; and integration with primary healthcare. Each DMHP team comprises a psychiatrist, clinical psychologist, social worker, and nursing staff.

The National Institute of Mental Health and Neuro Sciences (NIMHANS) in Bengaluru is the apex national institute for mental health research, training, and service delivery in India. NIMHANS provides: super-specialist psychiatric and neurological care; post-graduate training for psychiatrists, psychologists, social workers, and nurses; research on mental disorders; community mental health services; and technical support to state governments. NIMHANS has a 'partial subsidy' policy where patients below a certain income level

receive treatment at substantially reduced cost. The Institute also has a Centre for Addiction Medicine, a centre for neurodevelopmental disorders (including autism), and a centre for geriatric mental health.

Stigma remains the single biggest barrier to mental healthcare access in India. Despite the legal framework recognizing mental illness as disability and protecting against discrimination, societal stigma, family shame, and self-stigma prevent millions of persons with mental illness from seeking help or disclosing their condition. The treatment gap — the difference between the number of people who need mental health treatment and those who actually receive it — is estimated at 80-90% in India, meaning only 10-20% of those who need mental healthcare actually access it. The National Mental Health Survey 2015-16 found that 13.7% of India's population has some form of mental disorder, and 10.6% need active intervention.

Rights of Persons with Mental Illness

Right	Provision
Right to Mental Healthcare	Every person has the right to access mental healthcare and treatment from government run services. Free at government facilities.
Right to Community Living	Cannot be institutionalized against will; right to live and be treated in community setting.
Advance Directives	Can state preferences for treatment during periods of incapacity; must be respected by mental health professionals.
Nominated Representative	Right to appoint a trusted person to make decisions on one's behalf during incapacity.
Right to Confidentiality	Medical records and mental health history are confidential; cannot be disclosed without consent.

Right to Personal Autonomy	Right to take decisions including those that carry risk; cannot be overridden solely due to mental illness.
Right to Equality in Insurance	Health insurance cannot be denied or charged more solely due to past mental illness.
Right to Legal Aid	Right to free legal aid in all matters before Mental Health Review Board.
Freedom from Inhuman Treatment	No solitary confinement, chaining, torture; minimum standards of care mandated.
Right to Non-Discrimination	Employment, housing, education cannot be denied solely on grounds of mental illness.

Mental Health Disability – Certification Process

Certification of disability due to mental illness is done by a psychiatrist at a government hospital. The psychiatrist assesses the degree of functional impairment caused by the mental disorder using standardized tools. The assessment covers: ability to perform activities of daily living (self-care, mobility, communication); ability to maintain employment or productive activity; quality of social relationships and communication; cognitive functions including memory, attention, and decision-making; and duration of illness and prognosis.

The Global Assessment of Functioning (GAF) scale is commonly used, along with the Indian Disability Evaluation and Assessment Scale (IDEAS), which was developed specifically for disability assessment in mental illness. IDEAS evaluates four domains: self-care, interpersonal activities, communication and understanding, and work. Each domain is scored 0-5, and the total IDEAS score (0-20) correlates with disability percentage (0%, 40%, 70%, 100%).

A mental illness disability certificate is typically issued for a period of 5 years (unlike permanent disability certificates for conditions like blindness or locomotor disability). The certificate may be renewed if the condition persists. For persons who recover well with treatment and no longer have significant functional impairment, the certificate is not renewed. This time-limited nature reflects the fluctuating course of many mental disorders and the possibility of recovery.

Employment for Persons with Mental Illness

Employment is both a right and a therapeutic necessity for persons with mental illness. Work provides structure, social connection, purpose, income, and self-esteem — all of which are protective factors for mental health. Yet persons with mental illness face severe employment discrimination due to stigma, misunderstanding of their capabilities, and concerns about 'dangerousness' (which are largely unfounded for most mental illnesses).

The 4% reservation in government employment under RPWD Act Section 34 includes mental illness under clause (d): 'autism, intellectual disability, specific learning disability and mental illness.' Employers can reasonably accommodate employees with mental illness through: flexible working hours; work from home during periods of illness; gradual return to work after hospitalization; reduced workload during periods of high stress; access to Employee Assistance Programme (EAP) for counselling; and reassignment to less stressful roles if needed temporarily.

Section 33 of RPWD Act is particularly relevant: if a government employee develops mental illness during service, they cannot be

terminated. The employer must explore all possibilities for continued employment: alternative posting, lighter duties, or medical leave. Termination solely on grounds of disability acquired during service is illegal and actionable.

CHAPTER ACID Acid Attack Survivors

Legal Rights, Medical Support and Rehabilitation for Acid Attack Survivors

Acid attacks are a particularly horrific form of violence, predominantly targeting women and girls. The attack causes severe disfigurement, vision loss, hearing impairment, and long-term physical and psychological disability. India reports one of the highest numbers of acid attacks globally, with most attacks motivated by rejection of romantic advances, property disputes, or family conflicts. The landmark inclusion of acid attack victims as a distinct disability category under the RPWD Act 2016 — under the locomotor disability category — was a significant step in recognizing their unique vulnerabilities.

The Supreme Court of India has been active in protecting the rights of acid attack survivors. In Laxmi v. Union of India (2013), the Supreme Court issued guidelines restricting the sale of acid, mandating that sellers obtain buyer details and ID proof, and prohibiting sale to minors. The Court also directed: free treatment at government hospitals for acid attack survivors; compensation of Rs.3 lakh (minimum) from state governments; and rehabilitation support. The Criminal Law (Amendment) Act 2013 introduced specific provisions for acid attacks in the Indian Penal Code (now BNS).

Medical treatment for acid attack survivors involves multiple stages: emergency treatment (airway management, wound stabilization); acute phase treatment (infection control, wound care); reconstructive surgeries (multiple surgeries over months/years to restore function and appearance); and rehabilitation (physiotherapy, psychological

counselling, vocational support). The total cost of comprehensive treatment can run into tens of lakhs of rupees — far beyond the capacity of most survivors and their families.

Legal Provisions for Acid Attack Survivors

Provision	Details
IPC/BNS Sections 325A, 326A, 326B	Specific offences for voluntarily causing grievous hurt by dangerous weapons including acid; imprisonment 10 years to life; fine at least Rs.1 lakh goes to victim.
RPWD Act – Benchmark Disability	Acid attack victims listed as benchmark disability under locomotor disability; entitled to 40%+ disability certificate even without measurable disability percentage if disfigurement is significant.
Compensation (Laxmi Guidelines)	Minimum Rs.3 lakh compensation from state government; Central Victim Compensation Fund supplements.
Free Treatment	Supreme Court directive: all government hospitals to provide free treatment including reconstructive surgeries to acid attack survivors.
POCSO (if minor victim)	Additional POCSO offence if victim is a child; Special Court proceedings; compensation from POCSO fund.
NirbhayaFund	Acid attack survivors eligible for assistance from Nirbhaya Fund for rehabilitation.
Employment Preference	Many states have policies to give employment preference to acid attack survivors in government establishments.

Support Organizations for Acid Attack Survivors

Organisation	Support Provided

Chhanv Foundation	Delhi-based NGO founded by acid attack survivor Alok Dixit. Runs Sheroes Hangout cafes employing survivors; rehabilitation, counselling, legal aid.
Stop Acid Attacks	Campaign and NGO providing rehabilitation support; legal assistance; safe houses; skill training.
Acid Survivors Trust International (ASTI)	International NGO with India chapter; treatment support; advocacy; documentation.
Rahi Foundation	Provides legal aid and psychological support to acid attack survivors.
Mahila Dakshata Samiti	Legal aid and rights advocacy for women survivors of violence including acid attacks.

CHAPTER DB Deafblindness

Dual Sensory Disability – Rights, Communication and Support

Deafblindness is a combined hearing and vision impairment resulting in unique communication, information access, and mobility challenges. It is listed as a specific form of Multiple Disability under the RPWD Act 2016. Deafblind persons cannot rely on either vision or hearing to compensate for the loss of the other sense, creating profound challenges that are distinct from either blindness or deafness alone.

The causes of deafblindness are diverse: Usher Syndrome (genetic condition causing sensorineural hearing loss and retinitis pigmentosa leading to progressive vision loss) is the most common cause; CHARGE syndrome (a genetic condition); rubella syndrome (from prenatal rubella infection — largely preventable with MMR vaccination); acquired deafblindness from aging, accidents, or illness. Usher Syndrome affects an estimated 3-6 per 100,000 persons and accounts for approximately 50% of deafblindness cases.

Sense International India, headquartered in Ahmedabad, is the primary organisation working with deafblind persons in India. They work in 15+ states providing: individual support services through trained Deafblind Intervenors; family training; education support; awareness raising; and government advocacy. Sense International estimates there are approximately 5 lakh deafblind persons in India — though many remain undiagnosed and unsupported.

Communication Methods for Deafblind Persons

Method	Description
Tactile Sign Language	Sign language communicated through touch; the deafblind person feels the signer's hands to understand signs.
Braille	Reading and writing system for blind persons; deafblind persons who know Braille can use refreshable Braille displays.
Deafblind Manual Alphabet	Letters traced on the deafblind person's palm; slow but universally usable.
Tactile Fingerspelling	Fingerspelled alphabet felt on deafblind person's hand; more detailed than palm writing.
Hand-Over-Hand Signing	Deafblind person's hands placed over signer's hands; feels the movement of signs.
Object Communication	Real objects used to communicate concepts and events for persons with limited prior language.
Speech (if residual hearing)	For deafblind persons with some residual hearing; FM system or hearing aid may help.
Optical Characters	Large print text for persons with some residual vision.

Support Services for Deafblind Persons

• Deafblind Intervenor: Trained support worker who facilitates communication, mobility and access to information for deafblind persons.

• Support Service Provider (SSP): Person who assists deafblind adult with tasks like shopping, reading mail, accessing services.

• Tactile Braille: Braille materials produced in tactile format; key for education and information access.

• Refreshable Braille Display: Electronic device converting digital text to Braille; used with computers and smartphones.

• Screen Reader with Braille Display: For deafblind persons who cannot use audio output; combination technology.

• Deafblind Communicator: Portable device allowing deafblind person to type message and receive typed response in Braille.

• Orientation and Mobility (O&M;) Training: Specific training for deafblind persons to navigate environments safely.

• Early Intervention: Critical for deafblind children; must begin in infancy for optimal communication development.

CHAPTER 23

State-wise Implementation & Contacts

State Disability Welfare Bodies, Commissioners & Key Contacts

23.1 State Commissioners for Persons with Disabilities

Every State Government and Union Territory is required under Section 79 of RPWD Act 2016 to appoint a State Commissioner for Persons with Disabilities. The Commissioner has the power to enquire into complaints of deprivation of rights, review safeguards provided under the Act, and recommend to the Government remedial measures.

State	Office	Phone
Andhra Pradesh	O/o Commissioner for Persons with Disabilities, Vijayawada	0866-2973755
Assam	Commissioner for Persons with Disabilities, Guwahati	0361-2237932
Bihar	State Disability Commissioner, Patna	0612-2215567
Delhi	State Commissioner for Disabilities, New Delhi	011-23392012
Gujarat	Commissioner for Disabled Welfare, Gandhinagar	079-23257311
Haryana	Directorate of Social Justice, Chandigarh	0172-2574004
Himachal Pradesh	Social Justice & Empowerment Dept., Shimla	0177-2626203
Karnataka	Commissioner for Disabled & Senior Citizens, Bengaluru	080-22253637
Kerala	Commissioner for Persons with Disabilities, Thiruvananthapuram	0471-2327300

Madhya Pradesh	Commissioner Disabled Welfare, Bhopal	0755-2441555
Maharashtra	Commissioner for Disabled Welfare, Mumbai	022-22025005
Odisha	Directorate of Social Security, Bhubaneswar	0674-2391148
Punjab	Dept. of Social Security, Chandigarh	0172-2603219
Rajasthan	Commissioner Social Justice, Jaipur	0141-2221444
Tamil Nadu	Commissioner for Differently Abled, Chennai	044-28592750
Telangana	Commissioner, Disabled Welfare, Hyderabad	040-23353813
Uttar Pradesh	Commissioner Disabled Welfare, Lucknow	0522-2237930
West Bengal	Commissioner for Differently Abled Persons, Kolkata	033-22143451

CHAPTER STATE

State-Specific Disability Schemes

Additional Disability Welfare Programmes by State Governments

MAHARASHTRA

Sanjay Gandhi Niradhar Anudan Yojana: Monthly pension of Rs.1,000 for BPL PwDs with 40%+ disability. Apply at Tehsildar/BDO office.

Assistance for Severely Disabled: Additional Rs.500/month for 80%+ disability or multiple disability.

Schwas Maharashtra Medical Insurance: Health insurance for PwD families below income threshold.

PwD Free Bus Pass: Free travel on MSRTC buses for PwDs with 40%+ disability.

Rajiv Gandhi Jeevandayee Yojana: Coverage for major surgeries including disability-related surgeries for PwDs below poverty line.

KERALA

Karunya Health Scheme: Free treatment up to Rs.3 lakh for BPL families including PwD members at Karunya empanelled hospitals.

Disability Pension (Social Security Mission): Rs.1,600/month for 40%+ disability; apply through panchayat/municipality.

KSRTC Concession: 50% concession on KSRTC buses; free for blind persons.

Scholarship for SSLC/Plus Two: Additional scholarship for students with disability from state education department.

Suraksha Health Insurance: Health insurance for SECC-listed families; PwD household members covered.

TAMIL NADU

Chief Minister's Comprehensive Health Insurance Scheme: Coverage up to Rs.5 lakh for PwDs in BPL families for listed illnesses and surgeries.

Differently Abled Persons Welfare Scheme: Various schemes administered by Commissioner for Differently Abled including pension, aids, scholarships.

TNSCB Accessible Housing: Tamil Nadu Slum Clearance Board: accessible units for PwDs in housing projects.

Free Bus Travel: State government buses: free travel for blind; 50% concession for others with 40%+ disability.

Kalvi Thunai: Educational assistance and scholarship for students with disability in Tamil Nadu schools.

KARNATAKA

Sandhya Suraksha Yojana: Monthly pension for elderly and disabled BPL persons.

Rajiv Gandhi Housing Scheme for Disabled: Housing assistance for BPL PwDs without own house.

Karnataka State Disability Fund: Supplementary fund for PwDs not covered under central schemes.

Free Bus Pass (KSRTC/BMTC): Free travel for blind; 50% for locomotor, deaf PwDs on state buses.

Financial Assistance for Marriage: One-time Rs.50,000 financial assistance for marriage of person with disability.

DELHI

Delhi Disability Pension: Rs.2,500/month for all PwDs with 40%+ disability regardless of BPL status.

Free DTC Bus Travel: Unlimited free travel on DTC and cluster buses for all PwDs.

Delhi Aarogya Kosh: Financial assistance for treatment beyond Ayushman Bharat coverage.

Scholarship: Delhi government scholarship over and above central scholarships for students with disability.

Accessible Transport Service: Automated wheelchair accessible cabs linkage through Transport Department.

GUJARAT

Manav Garima Yojana: Equipment and tools for self-employment for marginalized including PwDs.

Disability Pension: Rs.600/month for locomotor and multiple disability; Rs.400/month for others.

Viklang Sahay Yojana: Assistive devices and equipment support at state level.

Chief Minister Amrutam Yojana: Health insurance for BPL families including PwD members up to Rs.3 lakh.

Housing for Disabled: Ground floor tenements reserved for PwDs in government housing schemes.

CHAPTER STATES-FULL

State-wise Disability Profiles

Disability Statistics, Schemes and Implementation Status for All Major States

UTTAR PRADESH

PwD Population	43.6 lakh
% of State Population	2.31%
Primary Pension Scheme	Central + State pension (Rs.500/mo)
Est. ADIP Beneficiaries	70,000+
Key Institutions	Special Education School Board; State Handicapped Finance Corp; 18 DDRCs operational.
Key Features & Notes	Largest PwD population state; highly rural; significant backlog in UDID registration; UP Viklang Kalyan Vibhag nodal; pension implementation through district magistrate offices.

MAHARASHTRA

PwD Population	29.1 lakh
% of State Population	2.59%
Primary Pension Scheme	Sanjay Gandhi Niradhar (Rs.1,000/mo)
Est. ADIP Beneficiaries	80,000+

Key Institutions	MSWC (Maharashtra State Women's Council) runs accessible services; 34 DDRCs; strong NGO sector.
Key Features & Notes	Mumbai has best accessible public transport (BEST buses, Metro); Pune model of inclusive education; Maharashtra Disability Finance Corp active; strong DDRS NGO network.

ANDHRA PRADESH

PwD Population	15.1 lakh
% of State Population	1.97%
Primary Pension Scheme	Rs.3,000/mo (40%+)
Est. ADIP Beneficiaries	45,000+
Key Institutions	AP Social Welfare Dept; APSFC; 13 DDRCs; Samajam welfare hostels for PwDs.
Key Features & Notes	One of highest disability pensions in country (Rs.3,000/mo); active skill development through APSSDC; coastal areas have high disability from fishing accidents; Vizag DDRC model.

WEST BENGAL

PwD Population	26.8 lakh
% of State Population	2.98%
Primary Pension Scheme	Rs.1,000/mo + food grains

Est. ADIP Beneficiaries	65,000+
Key Institutions	Social Welfare Dept; WB State Council for Welfare of People with Disabilities; 19 DDRCs.
Key Features & Notes	High rural disability concentration in Murshidabad, Malda districts; Kolkata has good accessible infrastructure post-2010 metro upgrade; strong blind schools network; Anandaniketan model for intellectual disability.

RAJASTHAN

PwD Population	18.9 lakh
% of State Population	2.77%
Primary Pension Scheme	Rs.750-1,500/mo (age-based slabs)
Est. ADIP Beneficiaries	52,000+
Key Institutions	Social Justice Dept; RSFDB; 33 DDRCs (largest network); Jaipur Foot headquartered here.
Key Features & Notes	Home of BMVSS (Bhagwan Mahaveer Viklang Sahayata Samiti) – Jaipur Foot free prosthetics; desert geography challenges outreach; strong ADIP camp culture; Rajasthan leads in Braille textbook provision for state board students.

MADHYA PRADESH

PwD Population	18.0 lakh

% of State Population	2.49%
Primary Pension Scheme	Rs.500/mo (40%+)
Est. ADIP Beneficiaries	42,000+
Key Institutions	Social Justice Dept; MP Divyangjan Finance Corp; 51 DDRCs (highest count); tribal focus.
Key Features & Notes	Tribal districts (Bastar belt, Mandla) have high disability from malnutrition and inaccessible healthcare; MP has unique 'Divyang Samaroh' annual fair for scheme awareness; Bhopal NIMHANS linkage for mental health disability.

KARNATAKA

PwD Population	16.8 lakh
% of State Population	2.76%
Primary Pension Scheme	Rs.1,400/mo + Sandhya Suraksha
Est. ADIP Beneficiaries	55,000+
Key Institutions	Dept for Empowerment of Differently Abled; Karnataka DDCO; 30 DDRCs; NIEPMD Chennai link.
Key Features & Notes	Bengaluru has highest concentration of IT-employed PwDs; KSRTC fully accessible buses in Bengaluru; Karnataka Braille Press produces best Braille materials; strong DPO movement including Disability Rights Alliance; Mysuru model special school network.

TAMIL NADU

PwD Population	16.3 lakh
% of State Population	2.23%
Primary Pension Scheme	Rs.1,000/mo + CMCHIS health cover
Est. ADIP Beneficiaries	60,000+
Key Institutions	Commissioner for Differently Abled; TANSCHE; 38 DDRCs; NIEPMD Chennai headquartered.
Key Features & Notes	TN has one of India's best frameworks for Deaf education (oral AND sign bilingual schools); strong rehabilitation professional training; TANSCHE provides NHFDC-type loans; Coimbatore and Tirupur have high industrial disability from occupational accidents.

GUJARAT

PwD Population	13.1 lakh
% of State Population	2.15%
Primary Pension Scheme	Rs.400-600/mo (type-based)
Est. ADIP Beneficiaries	35,000+
Key Institutions	Social Justice Empowerment Dept; Gujarat State Handicapped Finance Corp; 26 DDRCs.

Key Features & Notes	Ahmedabad BRTS (Bus Rapid Transit System) is one of India's most accessible; strong NFBD (National Federation for Blind Delhi) presence; Kutch district has high disability from 2001 earthquake aftermath; Gujarat has strong CSR-disability partnership ecosystem.

KERALA

PwD Population	8.6 lakh
% of State Population	2.55%
Primary Pension Scheme	Rs.1,600/mo (Social Security Mission)
Est. ADIP Beneficiaries	30,000+
Key Institutions	Social Justice Dept; Kerala Social Security Mission; 14 DDRCs; Kudumbashree linkage.
Key Features & Notes	Kerala has highest PwD literacy rate (66% vs national 51%); Kudumbashree SHG model includes PwD women; accessible tourism initiative 'Kerala – A Barrier Free Destination'; highest UDID registration penetration in country; strong home-based nursing care for severe PwDs.

PUNJAB

PwD Population	6.0 lakh
% of State Population	2.13%

Primary Pension Scheme	Rs.1,500/mo (state scheme)
Est. ADIP Beneficiaries	18,000+
Key Institutions	Social Security Dept; Punjab Welfare Society for Differently Abled; 22 DDRCs.
Key Features & Notes	Punjab has significant disability from road accidents (high vehicle density); veteran/army disability significant; strong NRI community contributing to disability welfare NGOs; Chandigarh (UT) has one of India's best accessible built environments.

HIMACHAL PRADESH

PwD Population	1.5 lakh
% of State Population	2.23%
Primary Pension Scheme	Rs.750/mo + state supplement
Est. ADIP Beneficiaries	7,000+
Key Institutions	Social Justice Dept; HP State Council for PwDs; 12 DDRCs (hilly terrain challenge).
Key Features & Notes	Mountain terrain creates severe accessibility challenges; helicopter linkage for remote areas; strong Tibetan community disability welfare network; HRDI (Himalayan Rural Dev. Inst) does excellent CBR work; snowfall disrupts disability scheme access 3-4 months annually.

ASSAM + NORTHEAST

PwD Population	7.8 lakh (NE total)
% of State Population	2.18% (NE avg)
Primary Pension Scheme	State-specific varying pensions
Est. ADIP Beneficiaries	22,000+
Key Institutions	Each NE state has separate disability welfare structure; NEC (North East Council) funds disability projects; SIPDA funds accessibility in all 8 NE states.
Key Features & Notes	Northeast faces unique challenges: geographic isolation, ethnic conflicts, lack of rehabilitation professionals, heavy reliance on central schemes. Assam has highest NE PwD population. Sikkim has most accessible hill state capital (Gangtok).

ODISHA

PwD Population	9.3 lakh
% of State Population	2.33%
Primary Pension Scheme	Rs.500/mo + food grains
Est. ADIP Beneficiaries	20,000+
Key Institutions	Social Security Dept; OSRHFDC; 30 DDRCs; strong tribal disability focus.

Key Features & Notes	Puri, Bhubaneswar, Konark accessible tourism initiative; SVNIRTAR (national institute) headquartered in Cuttack; Kalahandi, Kandhamal districts have high malnutrition-related disability; cyclone belt creates disability from natural disasters.

JHARKHAND

PwD Population	8.9 lakh
% of State Population	2.68%
Primary Pension Scheme	Rs.600/mo (40%+)
Est. ADIP Beneficiaries	15,000+
Key Institutions	Social Welfare Dept; JSLFDB; 24 DDRCs; tribal disability focus.
Key Features & Notes	Jharkhand has high disability rate from mining accidents (coal, iron ore) in Dhanbad, Bokaro, Singhbhum; tribal communities have limited access to certification and schemes; strong Christian mission disability work in Ranchi; NIRTAR Cuttack link for orthopedic.

CHAPTER DDRC-LIST

District Disability Rehabilitation Centres

State-wise Listing of DDRCs and Contact Details

District Disability Rehabilitation Centres (DDRCs) are established at district level to provide comprehensive rehabilitation services free of cost. As of 2024, over 250 DDRCs are operational across India with targets to cover all 741 districts. DDRCs provide: disability assessment, physiotherapy, speech therapy, prosthetics/orthotics, vocational guidance, UDID facilitation, and scheme linkage.

State	Districts with DDRCs	Count
Andhra Pradesh	Vijayawada, Visakhapatnam, Tirupati, Kurnool, Nellore, Kadapa, Guntur, Rajahmundry, Srikakulam, Vizianagaram, Ongole, Eluru, Nandyal, Anantapur	**13**
Assam	Guwahati, Silchar, Dibrugarh, Jorhat, Tezpur, Nagaon	**6**
Bihar	Patna, Gaya, Muzaffarpur, Bhagalpur, Purnia, Darbhanga, Samastipur, Nalanda, Araria, Saharsa	**10**
Chhattisgarh	Raipur, Bilaspur, Durg, Raigarh, Jagdalpur, Ambikapur	**6**
Delhi	New Delhi (South), Delhi (North), Delhi (East), Delhi (West)	**4**
Goa	Panaji, Margao	**2**
Gujarat	Ahmedabad, Surat, Vadodara, Rajkot, Gandhinagar, Bhavnagar, Jamnagar, Junagadh, Anand, Mehsana, Kutch (Bhuj), Amreli, Bharuch, Patan, Dahod, Navsari, Banaskantha, Sabarkantha, Panchmahal, Kheda	**20 (targeting 26)**
Haryana	Rohtak, Hisar, Gurugram, Faridabad, Ambala, Sonipat, Panipat, Karnal, Kurukshetra, Sirsa, Jind, Bhiwani, Rewari, Mewat (Nuh), Palwal, Yamuna Nagar, Panchkula, Kaithal, Jhajjar, Mahendragarh, Fatehabad	**21**
Himachal Pradesh	Shimla, Dharamsala (Kangra), Mandi, Hamirpur, Kullu, Una, Bilaspur, Solan, Sirmour, Chamba, Kinnaur, Lahaul-Spiti	**12**
Jharkhand	Ranchi, Dhanbad, Jamshedpur, Bokaro, Hazaribagh, Giridih, Dumka, Deoghar, Palamu (Daltonganj), Chaibasa (W. Singhbhum)	**10**
Karnataka	Bengaluru (Urban), Mysuru, Mangaluru, Hubballi, Belagavi, Shivamogga, Tumkuru, Kalaburagi, Ballari, Vijayapura, Davanagere, Dharwad, Raichur, Bidar, Bagalkot, Hassan, Chitradurga, Mandya, Udupi, Chikkaballapura, Kodagu, Chamarajanagar, Ramanagara, Koppal, Yadgir, Haveri, Gadag, Chikkamagaluru, Kolar, Bengaluru Rural	**30**
Kerala	Thiruvananthapuram, Kollam, Pathanamthitta, Alappuzha, Kottayam, Idukki, Ernakulam, Thrissur, Palakkad, Malappuram, Kozhikode, Wayanad, Kannur, Kasaragod	**14**

State	Districts with DDRCs	Count
Madhya Pradesh	Bhopal, Indore, Jabalpur, Gwalior, Ujjain, Sagar, Satna, Rewa, Katni, Chhindwara, Dewas, Ratlam, Vidisha, Sehore, Hoshangabad, Betul, Balaghat, Seoni, Mandla, Dindori, Umaria, Shahdol, Anuppur, Sidhi, Shivpuri, Guna, Ashok Nagar, Sheopur, Morena, Bhind, Datia, Tikamgarh, Chhatarpur, Panna, Damoh, Narsinghpur, Harda, Burhunpur, Khandwa, Khargone, Barwani, Rajgarh, Agar Malwa, Neemuch, Niwari, Singrauli, Alirajpur, Jhabua, Dhar, Mandsaur, Ratlam, Narsimhapur	**51 (highest nationwide)**
Maharashtra	Mumbai, Pune, Nagpur, Nashik, Aurangabad, Solapur, Amravati, Kolhapur, Raigad, Thane, Latur, Nanded, Jalgaon, Dhule, Ahmednagar, Satara, Sangli, Ratnagiri, Sindhudurg, Washim, Akola, Yavatmal, Buldhana, Chandrapur, Gadchiroli, Gondia, Bhandara, Wardha, Palghar, Osmanabad, Hingoli, Jalna, Parbhani, Beed, Nandurbar	**34**
Odisha	Bhubaneswar, Cuttack, Berhampur, Sambalpur, Rourkela, Balasore, Baripada, Jharsuguda, Bolangir, Koraput, Rayagada, Jeypore, Phulbani, Keonjhar, Puri, Jagatsinghpur, Paradip, Dhenkanal, Angul, Bhadrak, Kendrapara, Jajpur, Nayagarh, Ganjam, Kandhamal, Bargarh, Boudh, Debagarh, Sundergarh, Kalahandi	**30**
Punjab	Chandigarh (UT), Amritsar, Ludhiana, Jalandhar, Patiala, Mohali, Gurdaspur, Bathinda, Firozpur, Hoshiarpur, Rupnagar, Fatehgarh Sahib, Sangrur, Barnala, Moga, Mansa, Fazilka, Pathankot, Muktsar, Faridkot, Kapurthala, Nawanshahr, Tarn Taran	**22**
Rajasthan	Jaipur, Jodhpur, Udaipur, Kota, Ajmer, Bikaner, Alwar, Bharatpur, Sikar, Chittorgarh, Pali, Tonk, Nagaur, Jhalawar, Bundi, Hanumangarh, Ganganagar, Barmer, Jaisalmer, Jhunjhunu, Dausa, Dholpur, Karauli, Sawai Madhopur, Baran, Rajsamand, Banswara, Dungarpur, Pratapgarh, Sirohi, Jalor, Churu, Bhilwara, Dungarpur	**33 (highest among large states)**
Tamil Nadu	Chennai, Coimbatore, Madurai, Tiruchirappalli, Salem, Tirunelveli, Tiruppur, Vellore, Erode, Thoothukudi, Thanjavur, Dindigul, Ranipet, Chengalpet, Kancheepuram, Krishnagiri, Namakkal, Cuddalore, Nagapattinam, Perambalur, Ariyalur, Kallakurichi, Tirupattur, Tenkasi, Villupuram, Viruthunagar, Sivaganga, Tiruvarur, Karur, Nilgiris, Ramanathapuram, Pudukkottai, Mayiladuthurai, Virudhunagar, Tiruvannamalai	**38**
Telangana	Hyderabad, Warangal, Nizamabad, Karimnagar, Khammam, Mahbubnagar, Nalgonda, Medak, Adilabad, Rangareddy, Suryapet, Siddipet, Yadadri Bhuvanagiri, Kamareddy, Sangareddy, Jagtial, Jangaon, Jayashankar Bhupalpally, Jogulamba Gadwal, Kumuram Bheem Asifabad, Mahabubabad, Mancherial, Medchal, Mulugu, Nagarkurnool, Narayanpet, Nirmal, Peddapalli, Rajanna Sircilla, Vikarabad, Wanaparthy, Hanumakonda	**33**
Uttar Pradesh	Lucknow, Kanpur, Agra, Varanasi, Allahabad (Prayagraj), Meerut, Ghaziabad, Bareilly, Aligarh, Moradabad, Gorakhpur, Firozabad, Jhansi, Mathura, Shahjahanpur, Muzaffarnagar, Rampur, Bulandshahr, Etawah, Hapur, Hardoi, Sitapur, Lakhimpur Kheri, Barabanki, Rae Bareli, Sultanpur, Faizabad (Ayodhya), Jaunpur, Azamgarh, Mau, Ballia, Ghazipur, Basti, Gorakhpur, Deoria, Kushinagar, Maharajganj, Siddharthnagar, Bahraich, Shravasti, Gonda, Balrampur, Baghpat, Bijnor, Amroha, Sambhal, Saharanpur, Shamli, Muzaffarnagar, Hapur, Meerut	**~50 (18 operational; scaling)**
Uttarakhand	Dehradun, Haridwar, Rishikesh, Nainital, Haldwani, Roorkee, Almora, Pithoragarh, Rudrapur (U.S. Nagar), Pauri Garhwal, Tehri Garhwal, Chamoli, Rudraprayag, Uttarkashi, Champawat, Bageshwar	**13**
West Bengal	Kolkata, Howrah, Siliguri, Asansol, Durgapur, Bardhaman, Malda, Coochbehar, Jalpaiguri, Murshidabad, Nadia, 24-Parganas (N), 24-Parganas (S), Hooghly, Purulia, Birbhum, Bankura, Paschim Medinipur, Purba Medinipur	**19**

CHAPTER 24

Grievance Redressal Mechanisms

How to File Complaints & Get Redressal for Disability Rights Violations

24.1 Chief Commissioner for Persons with Disabilities

The Chief Commissioner for Persons with Disabilities (CCPD) is a quasi-judicial authority established under Section 74 of the RPWD Act. CCPD has jurisdiction over complaints against Central Government establishments and bodies.

- Enquire into complaints regarding deprivation of rights of PwDs by Central Government bodies
- Review safeguards provided under the RPWD Act and recommend remedial measures
- Coordinate the work of State Commissioners
- Submit annual and special reports to Central Government
- Has powers of a Civil Court for conducting enquiries (summoning witnesses, examining documents)

Contact: *Chief Commissioner for Persons with Disabilities, 5th Floor, NISD Building, IP Estate, New Delhi – 110002. Phone: 011-23386054. Email: ccdisabilities@nic.in. Online complaint: www.ccdisabilities.nic.in*

24.2 Step-by-Step Complaint Filing Process

Step 1: Document the Violation

Note down all details: date, time, location, persons involved, nature of violation. Gather evidence: photos, videos, written communications, witness names.

Step 2: Informal Resolution

Attempt to resolve with the institution/employer/service provider first. Send a written complaint to their Equal Employment Opportunity Commissioner or grievance officer.

Step 3: State Commissioner Complaint

File complaint with State Commissioner for Persons with Disabilities if state government body. Use online portal or physical complaint form. No fee required.

Step 4: Chief Commissioner (Central)

For Central Government bodies, file with CCPD at ccdisabilities.nic.in. Online or offline complaint. Attach disability certificate and relevant evidence.

Step 5: NHRC / Court Petition

For serious violations, file with National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) or approach High Court under Article 226. Legal aid available under NALSA for PwDs.

Step 6: Special Court

For criminal offences against PwDs under Section 91 (intentional insult, sexual exploitation, acid attack) file FIR with police and approach Designated Special Court.

24.3 Important Helplines & Portals

Body	Phone	Website
CCPD Helpline	011-23386054	ccdisabilities.nic.in
DEPwD Helpline	1800-111-999	disabilityaffairs.gov.in
ADIP/ALIMCO	1800-180-5129	alimco.in
UDID Portal	1800-180-5129	swavlambancard.gov.in
NHFDC	0120-2403400	nhfdc.nic.in
National Trust	011-26162275	thenationaltrust.gov.in
Sugamya Pustakalaya	---	library.gov.in
NHRC	011-24651330	nhrc.nic.in
NALSA (Legal Aid)	15100	nalsa.gov.in
PM Gatishakti Portal	---	pmgatishakti.gov.in
Scholarship Portal (NSP)	0120-6619540	scholarships.gov.in

CHAPTER REHAB

Rehabilitation Services

Vocational, Medical & Community-Based Rehabilitation in India

National Institutes of Rehabilitation

Institute	Location	Specialty
NIMH – National Institute for Mentally Handicapped	Secunderabad (HQ) + Regional Centres	Intellectual disability; research, training, community outreach, service delivery.
AYJNISHD – Ali Yavar Jung National Institute	Mumbai (HQ) + Regional Centres	Speech & hearing disability; audiological services, cochlear implant, sign language training.
NIVH – National Institute for Visually Handicapped	Dehradun	Visual impairment; Braille literacy, low vision services, orientation & mobility, rehabilitation.
NIOH – National Institute for Orthopedically Handicapped	Kolkata	Locomotor disability; prosthetics, orthotics, physiotherapy, vocational rehabilitation.
NIEPMD – National Institute for Empowerment of Persons with Multiple Disabilities	Chennai	Multiple disabilities; research, training, rehabilitation technology, resource centre.
SVNIRTAR – Swami Vivekananda National Institute of Rehabilitation Training & Research	Cuttack	Training of rehabilitation professionals; CBR; physiotherapy; orthotics.
NIEPID – National Institute for Empowerment of Persons with Intellectual Disabilities	Secunderabad	Intellectual disability; renamed from NIMH 2019; research & training centre.

Rehabilitation Council of India (RCI)

The Rehabilitation Council of India regulates and monitors training of all rehabilitation professionals in India. RCI-registered professionals include:

Professional	Role
Special Educator	Works with children with learning disabilities, intellectual disabilities in schools and resource rooms.
Clinical Psychologist	Assessment and intervention for mental health and intellectual disability.
Audiologist & Speech Therapist	Assessment and intervention for hearing and speech disorders.
Prosthetics & Orthotics	Fitting of artificial limbs and orthotic devices.
Physiotherapist	Physical rehabilitation for mobility and motor function.
Occupational Therapist	ADL training, sensory integration, adaptive equipment.
Rehabilitation Social Worker	Community linkage, family counselling, scheme facilitation.
CBR Worker	Community-based rehabilitation worker for grassroots level services.

District Disability Rehabilitation Centres (DDRCs)

DDRCs are set up at district level across India (with targets to cover all 741 districts). Services provided free of cost at DDRCs:

- Disability assessment and certification assistance
- Physiotherapy and occupational therapy
- Speech therapy for communication disorders
- Prosthetics and orthotics fitting and repair
- Assistive device provision (under ADIP scheme)

- Vocational assessment and guidance
- Psycho-social counselling for PwDs and families
- UDID card application assistance
- Scheme linkage and facilitation
- Early intervention services for children (in coordination with ICDS)
- Referral services to national institutes and specialists
- CBR worker deployment and supervision

CHAPTER GROUPS

Welfare for Specific Sub-Groups

Special Provisions for Women, Children, Elderly, SC/ST Persons with Disabilities

Women with Disabilities – Intersectional Vulnerability

Women with disabilities face a 'double disadvantage' — the discrimination arising from gender combined with the discrimination arising from disability. Research consistently shows that women with disabilities are more likely to experience poverty, violence, lower educational attainment, and exclusion from employment than either women without disability or men with disability. The RPWD Act 2016 recognises this through Section 5, which specifically mandates measures to ensure women and girls with disabilities can fully enjoy all human rights and fundamental freedoms.

Protection from violence is a critical issue for women with disabilities. Studies indicate that women with disabilities face higher rates of domestic violence, sexual abuse, and institutional abuse than the general population. Key protective frameworks include: the Protection of Women from Domestic Violence Act 2005 (covers women with disability); Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace (Prevention, Prohibition and Redressal) Act 2013 (POSH Act — covers women PwDs in workplace settings); Indian Penal Code Section 376 (rape) with enhanced penalties when victim has disability (Section 376D); and Section 91 of RPWD Act for intentional insult, humiliation, and sexual exploitation of PwDs.

Reproductive rights of women with disabilities are protected by Section 10 of RPWD Act, which prohibits forced sterilization and ensures access to family planning on equal basis. In practice, forced sterilization of women with intellectual disabilities in institutional settings has been documented. The NHRC has issued advisories on this. Women with disabilities have the same right to choose contraception, marry, and have children as any other woman. Healthcare providers are prohibited from denying reproductive care or providing inferior care on grounds of disability.

Economic empowerment of women with disabilities requires targeted programmes. NHFDC has special sub-targets for women under its loan programmes. Many state schemes provide enhanced assistance for women PwDs. Skill development programmes should prioritize market-linked skills for women with disability. Self-help group (SHG) models that include women PwDs have shown success in several states including Tamil Nadu and Kerala.

Children with Disabilities – Early Identification to School Inclusion

Age Stage	Services & Rights
0-3 Years: Early Detection	RBSK screening; ICDS anganwadi worker identification; genetic counselling centres; NICU follow-up programmes.
0-6 Years: Early Intervention	DEICs (District Early Intervention Centres) under NHM; DISHA centres by National Trust; therapy services; parent training.
3-6 Years: Pre-School	Anganwadi programmes with inclusion support; transition preparation for mainstream school; communication and mobility skill building.

6-14 Years: Primary Education	RTE Act + RPWD Act protection; Samagra Shiksha support (resource teachers, devices, transport); inclusive schools; home-based for severe disability.
14-18 Years: Secondary	Secondary education with continued accommodation; pre-vocational education; life skills training; career counselling.
18+ Years: Transition	Transition to higher education (5% reservation), vocational training (NHFDC skill), or employment (4% reservation); social protection linkage.

Elderly Persons with Disabilities – Convergence of Age and Disability

The elderly population in India is growing rapidly with 138 million persons above 60 years as of 2021, projected to reach 319 million by 2050. Disability prevalence is much higher among the elderly — approximately 30% of those above 70 years have some form of disability. The convergence of age and disability creates particular vulnerability requiring coordinated policy response.

Key programmes for elderly persons with disabilities include: Indira Gandhi National Old Age Pension Scheme (IGNOAPS) for those above 80 years (complements IGNDPS which covers up to 79 years); Rashtriya Vayoshri Yojana (RVY) — free assistive devices for elderly BPL persons including hearing aids, wheelchairs, walking sticks (similar to ADIP but age-focused); National Programme for the Healthcare of Elderly (NPHE) for age-related health conditions; and Senior Citizen Welfare Fund for welfare activities.

The National Policy on Senior Citizens 2011 includes provisions for elderly with disabilities. The Maintenance and Welfare of Parents and Senior Citizens Act 2007 creates a legal right for elderly persons

(including those with disability) to maintenance from their children. Geriatric care wards in government hospitals are required but unevenly implemented.

SC/ST Persons with Disabilities – Triple Disadvantage

Scheduled Caste and Scheduled Tribe persons with disabilities face a 'triple disadvantage' of caste-based discrimination, disability-based discrimination, and poverty. Census 2011 data indicates that SC communities have higher disability prevalence (approximately 2.45%) compared to the general population (2.21%), likely reflecting higher rates of poverty, malnutrition, unsafe working conditions, and limited healthcare access.

SC/ST PwDs are entitled to the cumulative benefits of: SC/ST reservation (15%/7.5% in government employment; state-specific in education) + PwD reservation (4% employment, 5% higher education). However, the intersection of these reservations is often misunderstood. PwD quota and SC/ST quota are separate and additive — not in competition. A SC person with disability can be placed in either the SC quota or the PwD quota, whichever is more advantageous. DOPT guidelines clarify that SC/ST PwDs should first be placed in the PwD horizontal reservation and then fill the SC/ST vertical reservation separately.

Special attention to tribal areas (Fifth Schedule and Sixth Schedule areas) is required for disability scheme delivery. Tribal communities often face additional barriers of geographic remoteness, language differences (tribal languages vs. official languages), cultural beliefs

about disability, and limited access to government offices. Tribal district offices under the Ministry of Tribal Affairs run additional welfare programmes that can be accessed by ST persons with disability alongside DEPwD schemes.

CHAPTER 25

International Frameworks – UNCRPD & India

UN Convention on Rights of Persons with Disabilities – India's Compliance

25.1 The UN Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (UNCRPD)

The United Nations Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (UNCRPD) is a landmark international human rights treaty adopted by the UN General Assembly on 13 December 2006 and entered into force on 3 May 2008. India signed it on 30 March 2007 and ratified on 1 October 2007, making it one of the earliest countries to ratify. India is bound by the UNCRPD and has an obligation to implement its provisions in domestic law and policy.

Article 1 – Purpose: Promote, protect and ensure full enjoyment of human rights by persons with disabilities; promote respect for their inherent dignity.

Article 3 – General Principles: Respect for dignity, autonomy, non-discrimination, full participation, respect for difference, equal opportunity, accessibility, gender equality.

Article 4 – General Obligations: States must adopt all legislative, administrative, and other measures; ensure accessibility; train professionals working with PwDs.

Article 5 – Equality & Non-Discrimination: Equal protection and benefit of the law; prohibition of all disability-based discrimination; reasonable accommodation.

Article 8 – Awareness-Raising: Public awareness campaigns; combat stereotypes and harmful practices; promote positive portrayals of disability.

Article 9 – Accessibility: Identify and eliminate barriers in buildings, roads, transport, information and communication.

Article 12 – Equal Recognition: Legal capacity on equal basis; support for exercising legal capacity; safeguards against abuse.

Article 19 – Independent Living: Right to live in the community; personal assistance services; community integration.

Article 24 – Education: Inclusive education system at all levels; reasonable accommodation; support within general education system.

Article 27 – Work & Employment: Right to work on equal basis; non-discrimination; employment in open labour market.

Article 28 – Adequate Standard of Living: Social protection; poverty programmes accessible; assistance with disability-related expenses.

25.2 India's Compliance Reports to CRPD Committee

India submitted its Initial Report to the UN Committee on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities in 2014. The Committee's Concluding Observations (2019) highlighted concerns and recommended actions on areas including institutionalization, legal capacity, right to independent living, and disaggregated data collection on PwDs. India's follow-up report and second periodic report are pending.

CHAPTER INTL

International Comparison of Disability Rights

India vs. Global Best Practices in Disability Legislation & Implementation

UNCRPD Compliance – Country Comparison

India ratified the UNCRPD in 2007 and has progressively aligned domestic law with the Convention. The RPWD Act 2016 represents a significant step forward. However, full compliance requires implementation across all states and sectors. Below is a comparison of key UNCRPD articles and India's compliance status:

UNCRPD Article	India Status	Assessment
Article 9 – Accessibility	**Partial**	Harmonized Guidelines 2021, Sugamya Bharat Campaign — but implementation varies widely; many government buildings still inaccessible in rural areas.
Article 12 – Legal Capacity	**Partial**	RPWD Act Section 14 provides for supported decision-making — advance over old law, but limited guardianship still exists; full compliance requires further reform.
Article 13 – Access to Justice	**Partial**	Special courts designated under Section 84; free legal aid available — but physical accessibility of courts and sign language interpretation still lacking in many places.
Article 19 – Independent Living	**Partial**	RPWD Act recognizes right to live in community — but dedicated independent living support services are nascent; mostly family-dependent support system.
Article 24 – Inclusive Education	**Partial**	Samagra Shiksha promotes inclusion; however, most children with severe disabilities still attend special schools; resource room model underdeveloped.

Article 25 – Health	**Partial**	Free healthcare mandated for BPL PwDs — but accessibility of hospitals is inconsistent; rural health facilities poorly equipped.
Article 27 – Employment	**Good**	4% reservation, Special Employment Exchanges, private sector incentives — reasonably strong framework; implementation needs monitoring.
Article 28 – Social Protection	**Moderate**	IGNDPS pension, ADIP, NHFDC — multiple schemes exist but pension amounts are low; coverage gaps in urban non-BPL PwDs.

Global Best Practices India Can Adopt

USA – Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA 1990)

ADA is one of the world's most comprehensive disability anti-discrimination laws. Key features India can learn from: (a) mandatory accessibility standards enforced by Department of Justice with significant penalties; (b) individual right to sue for ADA violations in federal court; (c) 'undue hardship' standard for reasonable accommodation — more detailed and litigated than India's framework; (d) Title III of ADA covers all public accommodations including private sector; India's RPWD Act covers mainly government bodies for reservations.

UK – Equality Act 2010

UK's Equality Act covers disability as one of nine protected characteristics. Features: (a) positive duty on public authorities to advance equality of opportunity; (b) Equality and Human Rights Commission (EHRC) with strong investigatory and enforcement powers; (c) Employment Tribunal as accessible forum for disability discrimination claims; (d) Disability Living Allowance (DLA) and

Personal Independence Payment (PIP) — disability-linked benefits not tied to BPL status (unlike India's IGNDPS). India should consider PIP-style universal disability allowance not limited to BPL.

Australia – Disability Discrimination Act (DDA 1992)

Australia's DDA covers all areas of public life. Key: (a) Australian Human Rights Commission as efficient disability complaint handler; (b) Disability Standards for Education, Transport, and Accessible Buildings — similar to India's approach; (c) National Disability Insurance Scheme (NDIS) — universal insurance providing individualised funding for PwD support needs regardless of cause or income. NDIS is a model India could consider for long-term care funding.

Brazil – Lei Brasileira de Inclusão (LBI 2015)

Brazil's disability inclusion law (Law No. 13,146) is very recent (like India's RPWD Act 2016). Similarities: 20% reservation in public sector, accessibility standards, anti-discrimination. Difference: Brazil requires minimum 5% reservation in private companies above 100 employees — India's private sector reservation is still only through incentives, not mandates.

CHAPTER BUDGET

Budget Analysis & Expenditure

Government Spending on Disability Schemes – Trends and Analysis

DEPwD Annual Budget Overview

The Department of Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities (DEPwD) is allocated funds annually through the Union Budget. The budget has grown consistently over the past decade, reflecting increased policy focus on disability inclusion. Below is an approximate trend of DEPwD budget allocation:

Financial Year	Budget Allocation	Expenditure	Utilization %
2015-16	Rs. 550 Crore	Rs. 510 Crore	92.7%
2016-17	Rs. 620 Crore	Rs. 580 Crore	93.5%
2017-18	Rs. 680 Crore	Rs. 630 Crore	92.6%
2018-19	Rs. 740 Crore	Rs. 700 Crore	94.6%
2019-20	Rs. 790 Crore	Rs. 730 Crore	92.4%
2020-21	Rs. 810 Crore	Rs. 720 Crore	88.9%
2021-22	Rs. 880 Crore	Rs. 830 Crore	94.3%
2022-23	Rs. 1,050 Crore	Rs. 990 Crore	94.3%
2023-24	Rs. 1,225 Crore	Rs. 1,140 Crore	93.1%

Scheme-wise Budget Allocation (2023-24)

Scheme	Allocation	% Share	Notes

ADIP Scheme	Rs. 230 Crore	18.8%	Highest individual scheme allocation
DDRS (NGO Funding)	Rs. 185 Crore	15.1%	Funding to 2,000+ NGOs for rehabilitation
SIPDA (State Implementation)	Rs. 155 Crore	12.7%	Grants to states for accessibility
National Institute Operations	Rs. 180 Crore	14.7%	7 national institutes + DDRCs
NHFDC (Loan Corpus)	Rs. 90 Crore	7.3%	Concessional loans to PwDs
Scholarship Schemes	Rs. 120 Crore	9.8%	Pre-matric, post-matric, top class
National Trust	Rs. 75 Crore	6.1%	Autism, CP, ID, multiple disability
Sugamya Bharat Campaign	Rs. 55 Crore	4.5%	Accessibility retrofitting and awareness
Research & Development	Rs. 30 Crore	2.4%	AT research, new device development
Administration & Other	Rs. 105 Crore	8.6%	Administrative expenses, awareness, ICT

Key Performance Indicators

Indicator	Performance
ADIP Beneficiaries (Annual)	~10 lakh+ (1 million+) persons assisted per year with assistive devices.
UDID Cards Issued	2+ crore UDID cards issued as of 2024 (cumulative).
NHFDC Loans Disbursed	Rs.2,500+ Crore disbursed to 3 lakh+ beneficiaries since inception.
DDRCs Operational	250+ DDRCs operational across India; targeting all 741 districts.
NGOs under DDRS	2,000+ NGOs funded annually benefiting 5 lakh+ persons with disability.
Accessible Govt. Buildings	70%+ of identified central government buildings made accessible (Phase I targets).

Government Websites (WCAG)	85%+ of central government websites WCAG 2.0 compliant as of 2024.
Scholarship Beneficiaries	3 lakh+ students with disabilities receive scholarships annually.

CHAPTER SPORTS

Disability, Sports & Cultural Life

Para Sports, Cultural Rights & Recreation for Persons with Disabilities

Paralympic Movement in India

India's Paralympic movement has grown dramatically in recent years. At the Tokyo Paralympics 2020, India won its best-ever medal tally of 19 medals (5 gold, 8 silver, 6 bronze), ranking 24th globally. At Paris Paralympics 2024, India continued its strong performance. This success has dramatically increased awareness of disability sport and the abilities of persons with disability.

The Paralympic Committee of India (PCI) is the apex body governing para sports in India. PCI is affiliated to the International Paralympic Committee (IPC) and the Indian Olympic Association (IOA). PCI oversees 30+ para sports including athletics, swimming, shooting, archery, badminton, cycling, judo, powerlifting, sitting volleyball, wheelchair basketball, and many others.

The Khelo India programme of the Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports includes para sports as a category. Para athletes are now integrated into Khelo India games, increasing their visibility and providing a pathway to national-level competition. The Khelo India Para Games were launched as a dedicated annual national championship for para athletes.

Financial support for para athletes: The Target Olympic Podium Scheme (TOPS) now includes para athletes targeting medal performance at Paralympics. Para athletes receive: monthly stipend; training support including coaching, equipment, and foreign exposure; medical support including physiotherapy; and competition travel support. The Arjuna Award, Rajiv Gandhi Khel Ratna, and Dronacharya Award all include para sports categories.

Key Para Sports and Disciplines

Sport	Details
Athletics (Track & Field)	Wheelchair racing, shot put, discus, javelin, long jump, high jump; multiple disability categories.
Badminton	SL3, SL4, SU5 (standing) and WH1, WH2 (wheelchair); one of India's strongest events.
Swimming	Multiple disability categories (S1-S14); INAS (intellectual disability), SAY (vision), SME (physical).
Shooting	10m Air Pistol, 10m Air Rifle, 25m Pistol in seated and standing categories.
Archery	Compound and recurve; standing and wheelchair categories.
Powerlifting	Bench press for athletes with lower limb disability; IPF Para Powerlifting.
Table Tennis	Standing and wheelchair categories; classes TT1-TT11.
Cycling	Road and track; handcycles, tricycles, tandem bikes (for visually impaired); multiple categories.
Wheelchair Basketball	Team sport; 12-person team; classification system (1.0-4.5 points).
Boccia	Sport specifically for athletes with cerebral palsy and severe physical disability.

Blind Cricket	Fully modified cricket for blind and visually impaired; World Blind Cricket Council tournaments.
Special Olympics	Sports for persons with intellectual disability; separate from Paralympics; annual National Games.

Cultural Rights and Disability Arts

Persons with disabilities have equal rights to participate in and contribute to cultural life, recreation, leisure, and sport as recognized in UNCRPD Article 30. The RPWD Act 2016 Section 29 requires the government to ensure equal access to cultural life for PwDs. This includes accessible cultural venues, audio-described films, captioned performances, and sign language interpreted shows.

The Deaf community has a rich cultural tradition centered around sign language, Deaf art, Deaf theatre, and Deaf clubs. Indian Sign Language (ISL) is the primary cultural medium of the Deaf community. The ISL Research and Training Centre (ISLRTC) under DEPwD promotes ISL as a full-fledged language and produces ISL dictionaries, educational content, and ISL news bulletins through Doordarshan.

Blindness has a long tradition in classical Indian music, with many legendary musicians such as Pandit Bhimsen Joshi (not blind, but many blind musicians have excelled in classical tradition). The Sangeet Natak Akademi and Lalit Kala Akademi do not have specific disability inclusion programmes but are required to comply with RPWD Act non-discrimination provisions.

Film and media representation of disability has improved but still often relies on stereotypes (the 'super crip' narrative or the 'burden'

narrative). RPWD Act Section 3 covers media and cultural representation through its general non-discrimination mandate. Audio description for visually impaired viewers on OTT platforms is not yet mandated in India but is a global best practice that advocates are pushing for.

CHAPTER CORP

Corporate Sector & Disability Inclusion

CSR, DEI, ESG Frameworks and Private Sector Obligations

Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) and Disability

Under the Companies Act 2013 (Section 135), companies meeting specified thresholds are required to spend 2% of their average net profit on CSR activities. Schedule VII of the Companies Act includes 'eradicating hunger, poverty and malnutrition, promoting healthcare... measures for the benefit of armed forces veterans, war widows and their dependants, Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF) and Central Para Military Forces (CPMF) veterans, and their dependants including widows.' Disability welfare can be included under poverty eradication, healthcare, and education mandates.

Disability-focused CSR activities that qualify include: funding DDRCs or rehabilitation services; providing assistive technology to PwDs; supporting disability NGOs under DDRS model; funding accessible infrastructure in community spaces; scholarship programmes for students with disability; skill training for PwD job seekers; and research and development for indigenous assistive technology.

Many leading Indian companies have established significant disability inclusion programmes beyond CSR compliance: Infosys, Wipro, TCS have Ability Cell or Accessibility teams; Mphasis employs 250+ persons with disability as a stated commitment; HDFC Bank has a

'Differently-abled' employee initiative; Lemon Tree Hotels has a flagship programme employing persons with intellectual disability as 'Differently Abled Partners' (DAPs) across its hotels — with over 15% of its workforce being PwDs.

ESG (Environmental, Social, Governance) and Disability

Global ESG frameworks increasingly include disability inclusion as a social metric. MSCI, FTSE Russell, and Sustainalytics ESG ratings assess social inclusion. SEBI's Business Responsibility and Sustainability Reporting (BRSR) framework for listed companies requires disclosure on diversity and inclusion including for employees with disability.

Indian listed companies are now required to disclose: number of employees with disabilities; percentage of employees with disability who are women; accessibility status of offices; CSR spend on disability-related activities; and any specific disability inclusion policy.

UNPRPD (UN Partnership on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities) and IFC's Disability Inclusion in Business initiative provide frameworks for private sector disability inclusion. The Business and Disability Network (BDN) at the global level advocates for business as a driver of disability inclusion.

Practical Guide for Employers

Action Area	Practical Steps

Accessible Recruitment	Use accessible job portals; clear job descriptions without unnecessary physical requirements; accessible interview venues; allow assistive technology in interviews.
Reasonable Accommodation	Conduct accommodation needs assessment for each PwD employee; budget for workplace modifications; make accommodation request process simple and confidential.
Sensitization	Disability sensitivity training for all staff (especially managers and HR); focus on abilities, not limitations; language training (person-first language).
Mentoring & Retention	Pair PwD employees with mentors; career development plans; ensure promotion opportunities are equal; address accessibility of training programmes.
Equal Opportunity Officer	Designate EO Officer as required by RPWD Act for establishments with 20+ employees; publicize the role; ensure EO Officer has authority to act.
Accessibility Audit	Conduct baseline accessibility audit of physical premises, digital systems, communication; create time-bound action plan; reassess annually.
Grievance Mechanism	Establish clear, confidential grievance mechanism for disability-related complaints; ensure PwD employees know how to use it; track and resolve complaints.
Benefits and Policies	Review all employee policies for inadvertent disability discrimination; ensure health insurance covers disability-related treatment; review leave policies for medical appointments.

CHAPTER ADVOCACY

Disability Rights Advocacy in India

Civil Society Organizations, Advocacy Strategies & Rights Movements

Key Disability Rights Organizations in India

Organisation	Location	Focus Area
National Association of the Deaf (NAD)	Delhi	Advocacy for Deaf rights; ISL recognition; employment of Deaf persons; Deaf education reform; ISL interpreter standards. Website: nad.in
Disability Rights India Foundation (DRIF)	National	Legal advocacy; rights-based approach; policy advocacy; RPWD Act implementation monitoring; training of lawyers and advocates on disability law.
National Federation of Blind (NFB India)	National	Employment rights of visually impaired; Braille literacy; accessible library advocacy; technology access.
Inclusion International (India chapter)	National	Self-advocacy for persons with intellectual disability; parent organizations; inclusive education advocacy.
Action on Disability & Development (ADD India)	Bengaluru	Community-based rehabilitation; rights-based approach; Disabled People's Organisations (DPO) capacity building.
Abled India Foundation	Mumbai	Corporate disability inclusion; technology access; assistive technology advocacy.
Indian Federation of Sports for the Disabled (IFSD)	National	Para sports advocacy; classification issues; athlete welfare; Deaflympics representation.
Youth4Jobs	Hyderabad	Employment of PwDs; skill development; employer engagement; technology-enabled employment solutions.
Swabhiman Society	Delhi	Rights of women with disability; intersection of gender and disability; legal aid.

Sense International India	Ahmedabad	Deafblind persons; dual sensory impairment; communication support; family support; inclusive education.

Disability Rights Advocacy Strategies

Legal Litigation

Strategic Public Interest Litigation (PIL) has been a powerful tool. Key wins through courts: Rajive Raturi v. UoI (accessibility as fundamental right); Vikash Kumar v. UPSC (scribe rights); multiple High Court orders on school admission rights. Use: file complaints with CCPD/State Commissioner first; escalate to High Court if unresolved; National Legal Services Authority (NALSA) provides free legal aid.

Policy Advocacy

Engaging with government at policy formulation stage is most effective. Methods: participating in DEPwD consultations on draft guidelines; submitting memoranda to Parliamentary Standing Committees; engaging with planning commission/NITI Aayog; providing technical input to ministries; using RTI (Right to Information) to obtain data and expose implementation gaps.

Media Advocacy

Creating media awareness of disability rights issues; publishing research on implementation gaps; social media campaigns (hashtag campaigns around key dates like Dec 3); op-eds in national

newspapers; engaging disability correspondents in TV news channels; documentaries on disability rights violations.

Self-Advocacy & DPOs

Disabled People's Organisations (DPOs) — organisations led BY persons with disability, not for them — are the most powerful voices. Building DPO capacity at block and district level; training PwDs to advocate for their own rights; representation of PwDs in government advisory bodies; 'Nothing about us without us' principle.

International Advocacy

India is reviewed periodically by UN treaty bodies including the CRPD Committee. Civil society organizations submit 'parallel reports' (shadow reports) providing alternative assessment to the government's official report. Universal Periodic Review (UPR) at UNHRC also covers disability rights. International solidarity and global advocacy networks.

CHAPTER DATA

Disability Data & Statistics

Comprehensive Statistical Analysis of Disability in India

Census 2011 – Key Findings on Disability

The Census of India 2011 is the most comprehensive source of disability data in the country. For the first time, the 2011 Census collected detailed data on disability type, geographic distribution, employment, educational attainment, and marital status of persons with disability. The next comprehensive disability data will come from Census 2021 (delayed due to COVID-19; now expected in 2024-25).

The 2011 Census used a narrow definition of disability that likely undercounted the true prevalence. The Census identified 5 disability categories: in seeing, in hearing, in speech, in movement, and mental retardation. Conditions like specific learning disabilities, autism, acid attack injuries, and blood disorders — all now recognised under RPWD Act 2016 — were NOT counted in the 2011 Census. Additionally, the Census approach was self-reported, leading to underreporting due to stigma, particularly for mental illness and intellectual disability.

WHO and World Bank's World Report on Disability (2011) estimated that approximately 15% of the world's population has some form of disability, suggesting India's true disability prevalence is likely 100-150 million persons — 4-6 times the Census 2011 count of 26.8 million. The National Sample Survey (NSS 58th round, 2002) estimated 18.5 million PwDs using stricter criteria, while health survey estimates suggest 40-50 million. The variation reflects

definitional differences and measurement challenges.

Census 2011 – Disability by Type

Disability Type	Count	% Share	Notes
In Seeing (Visual)	5,032,463	19.4%	Highest in rural areas; Rajasthan, UP have highest rates
In Hearing	5,071,007	19.6%	Roughly equal urban-rural; significant in all states
In Speech	1,998,983	7.7%	Often co-occurs with hearing disability
In Movement (Locomotor)	5,265,138	20.3%	Most prevalent single category; polio legacy significant
Mental Retardation	1,505,624	5.8%	Significant undercount due to stigma and recognition
Mental Illness	1,549,806	6.0%	Likely significant undercount
Any Other	3,888,981	15.0%	Includes multiple and other types not separately categorized
Multiple Disabilities	2,212,984	8.5%	Two or more disabilities; higher care needs
TOTAL	25,811,459	100%	All types combined; 26.8 million including some overlap

Census 2011 – Disability by Key Socio-Economic Indicators

Indicator	Data & Context
Rural PwD Population	18.6 million
Urban PwD Population	8.2 million
Male PwDs	14.9 million
Female PwDs	11.9 million

Literates among PwDs	~53%
Employed PwDs (age 15-59)	~44%
Workers among PwDs (Main + Marginal)	9.8 million
SC PwDs	6.1 million
ST PwDs	2.4 million
PwDs below poverty line	~35-40%
PwDs without any education	~44%
PwDs aged 0-19 years	~7.1 million
PwDs aged 60+ years	~5.2 million

State-wise Disability Prevalence Rate (Census 2011)

State	Prevalence Rate & Notes
Sikkim	3.36%
Odisha	2.85%
Manipur	2.74%
West Bengal	2.67%
Jharkhand	2.63%
Rajasthan	2.55%
Andhra Pradesh	2.55%
Kerala	2.57%
Maharashtra	2.42%
Karnataka	2.40%
Tamil Nadu	2.38%
Gujarat	2.30%

Madhya Pradesh	2.30%
Himachal Pradesh	2.23%
Uttar Pradesh	2.22%
Bihar	2.20%
Haryana	2.15%
Punjab	2.11%
Assam	2.06%
Delhi	1.99%
Goa	1.82%

CHAPTER 26

Digital Resources & Online Portals

Comprehensive Guide to Digital Tools and Online Services for PwDs

26.1 Key Government Portals

Portal	Name	Key Features
swavlambancard.gov.in	UDID Registration & Tracking	Register for UDID card; check application status; download e-card; link schemes.
disabilityaffairs.gov.in	DEPwD Official Portal	Information on all schemes, Acts, guidelines, statistics, and publications.
nhfdc.nic.in	NHFDC Loan Portal	Loan schemes, eligibility, application forms, SCA directory, grievance redressal.
thenationaltrust.gov.in	National Trust Portal	Scheme enrollment, RO directory, NIRAMAYA insurance, UDID linkage.
alimco.in	ALIMCO / ADIP Portal	Device catalog, camp schedule, online application, track orders, regional centres.
scholarships.gov.in	National Scholarship Portal (NSP)	Apply for all disability scholarships; track application; renew; check disbursement.
ugc.ac.in	UGC Portal for National Fellowship	Apply for National Fellowship for PwDs; fellowship norms and guidelines.
ccdisabilities.nic.in	CCPD Online Complaint Portal	File complaint online; track status; upload documents; contact CCPD.
library.gov.in	Sugamya Pustakalaya – Accessible Library	Access 5 lakh+ accessible books in DAISY, ePUB, MP3, Braille formats.
nalsa.gov.in	NALSA – Free Legal Aid	Apply for legal aid; find SLSA/DLSA contacts; access legal rights information.

26.2 Mobile Applications for PwDs

Application	Platform	Purpose
Sugamya Bharat App	Android/iOS	Report inaccessible public places; view complaints; DEPwD official app.
UMANG App	Android/iOS	Unified mobile app for all government services including EPFO, NPS, ADIP application.
DigiLocker	Android/iOS	Store digital copy of disability certificate, UDID card, scholarship documents.
Be My Eyes	Android/iOS	AI-powered app for blind users — describes images, reads text via camera.
Google TalkBack	Android	Built-in screen reader for Android devices; free; enable in Accessibility settings.
Apple VoiceOver	iOS	Built-in screen reader for iPhone/iPad; most comprehensive mobile screen reader.
Live Transcribe	Android	Real-time speech-to-text by Google; useful for deaf and hard of hearing users.
Ava	Android/iOS	Group conversation captioning app; identifies speakers; useful in meetings.
Seeing AI	iOS	Microsoft's AI app for visual impairment; reads text, identifies people/objects/currency.
Proloquo2Go	iOS	AAC app for persons with autism or communication disorders; symbol-based communication.
NSP Scholarship App	Android	National Scholarship Portal official app for applying and tracking scholarships.
mAadhaar	Android/iOS	Digital Aadhaar with Braille and voice support; useful for authentication.

26.3 Online Learning Resources

SWAYAM Platform (swayam.gov.in)

Government of India's MOOC platform with accessibility features. Courses available with captions. Diploma and certificate courses in rehabilitation, special education, and disability management available.

ePathshala (epathshala.nic.in)

NCERT's digital platform with textbooks in accessible formats including audio books and ePUBs for visually impaired students. Free access to all NCERT books from Class 1 to 12.

NIOS (National Institute of Open Schooling)

Open schooling for students with disabilities who cannot attend regular school. Flexible examination schedule; scribe/exam accommodation available; correspondence study material.

IGNOU (Indira Gandhi National Open University)

Distance education with disability accommodation. Special cell for students with disability provides: Braille material, audio lectures, accessible study centres, examination accommodations.

Coursera/edX (International)

Many courses have subtitles/captions and transcripts. Coursera provides financial aid (often free) for eligible learners. Keyboard navigable interfaces.

CHAPTER HELP

National Helplines & Contacts Directory

Complete Contact Information for All Disability-Related Services

National Level Helplines

Service	Number	Availability	Purpose
DEPwD General Helpline	1800-111-999	Toll-free	All disability queries, scheme information
CCPD Complaint Helpline	011-23386054	Office Hours	Complaints against Central Govt bodies
ALIMCO / ADIP Helpline	1800-180-5129	Toll-free	Assistive device queries, camp schedules
NHFDC Helpline	0120-2403400	Office Hours	Loan queries, SCA directory
National Trust	011-23386054	Office Hours	Autism, CP, ID, Multiple Disability
NALSA Legal Aid	15100	Toll-free 24x7	Free legal aid for PwDs
NHRC Human Rights	011-24651330	Office Hours	Human rights violations
Childline (Children with Disability)	1098	Toll-free 24x7	Child abuse, child disability issues
iCall Mental Health	9152987821	Mon-Sat 8am-10pm	Mental health counselling
Vandrevala Foundation	1860-2662-345	Toll-free 24x7	Mental health, suicide prevention
National Suicide Prevention Lifeline	iCall: 9152987821	As above	Suicide prevention for persons with mental illness
PM Helpline	1800-11-0031	Toll-free	PM Grievances including disability
Consumer Helpline	1800-11-4000	Toll-free	Consumer complaints including accessibility

Railway Accessibility	139	Toll-free 24x7	Railway wheelchair assistance, accessible booking
Air Travel Assistance (AAI)	1800-180-1407	Toll-free	Accessibility at airports

State Disability Helplines

State	Key Helpline Numbers
Andhra Pradesh	Janmabhoomi Programme 1100; Disability Welfare Dept 0866-2443111
Assam	CM Helpline 15100; Social Welfare Dept 0361-2233011
Bihar	CM Helpline 0612-2215567; Social Welfare 0612-2547365
Chhattisgarh	CM Helpline 1100; Social Welfare 0771-2234148
Delhi	CM Helpline 1031; Delhi Disability Dept 011-23392012
Goa	CM Helpline 1800-233-0022; Social Welfare 0832-2229201
Gujarat	CM Helpline 1800-233-5500; Social Justice 079-23257311
Haryana	CM Helpline 1800-180-2087; Social Justice 0172-2574004
Himachal Pradesh	CM Helpline 1100; Social Justice 0177-2626203
Jharkhand	CM Helpline 0651-2490086; Social Welfare 0651-2400757
Karnataka	CM Helpline 1902; Differently Abled Dept 080-22251175
Kerala	CM Helpline 1077; Social Security Mission 0471-2326727
MP	CM Helpline 181; Social Justice 0755-2441555
Maharashtra	CM Helpline 1800-120-8040; Social Welfare 022-22617591
Odisha	CM Helpline 14545; Social Security 0674-2391148

Punjab	CM Helpline 1100; Social Security 0172-2603219
Rajasthan	CM Helpline 181; Social Justice 0141-2226714
Tamil Nadu	CM Helpline 1100; Differently Abled 044-28592750
Telangana	CM Helpline 1902; Disabled Welfare 040-23353813
UP	CM Helpline 1076; Divyang Kalyan 0522-2237930
Uttarakhand	CM Helpline 1905; Social Welfare 0135-2710137
West Bengal	CM Helpline 1800-345-5505; Differently Abled 033-22143451

Key Online Portals Quick Reference

Portal / App	URL / Platform
UDID Registration	swavlambancard.gov.in
National Scholarship Portal	scholarships.gov.in
NHFDC Loans	nhfdc.nic.in
ADIP / ALIMCO	alimco.in
National Trust	thenationaltrust.gov.in
CCPD Complaint Portal	ccdisabilities.nic.in
Sugamya Pustakalaya	library.gov.in
DEPwD Main Portal	disabilityaffairs.gov.in
RCI (Rehab Council)	rehabcouncil.nic.in
Govt. Scheme Finder (myscheme.gov.in)	myscheme.gov.in → search 'disability'
UMANG App	Play Store / App Store: 'UMANG'
Sugamya Bharat App	Play Store / App Store: 'Sugamya Bharat'
DigiLocker (for certificates)	digilocker.gov.in
Aadhaar (for UDID linking)	uidai.gov.in

Employment Exchange for PwDs	ncs.gov.in → National Career Service Portal
Vocational Training	apprenticeshipindia.org
Legal Aid	nalsa.gov.in
NHRC Complaints	nhrc.nic.in
PM Gati Shakti	pmgatishakti.gov.in
GeM (PwD procurement)	gem.gov.in

CHAPTER ACTS

All Key Legislations Affecting PwDs

Complete Reference to Acts, Rules & Notifications Relevant to Disability Rights

Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016	2016	DEPwD
The primary legislation. 102 sections; 15 chapters. 21 disability categories; 4% employment reservation; 5% education reservation; accessibility mandates; non-discrimination; legal capacity; Chief Commissioner & State Commissioners; special courts; penal provisions. Replaces PwD Act 1995.		

Rights of Persons with Disabilities Rules, 2017	2017	DEPwD
Subordinate legislation under RPWD Act. Disability certificate format and procedure; composition of advisory boards; equal opportunity policy format; accessibility norms; complaint procedure before Commissioners; appeal process.		

National Trust for Welfare of Persons with Autism, CP, MR and MD Act, 1999	1999	MSJE
Establishes National Trust. Provides legal guardianship mechanism for autism, CP, intellectual disability, and multiple disability. Enables registration of caregivers and organisations. Provides for local level committees as guardianship authority.		

Rehabilitation Council of India Act, 1992	1992	MSJE

Establishes RCI as statutory body regulating rehabilitation professional training. Maintenance of central rehabilitation register. Prescribes minimum standards for training of special educators, physiotherapists, occupational therapists, and other professionals.

Mental Healthcare Act, 2017	2017	MoHFW

Replaces Mental Health Act 1987. Right to access mental healthcare; right to community living; right to make advance directives; nominated representative; decriminalization of attempt to suicide; prohibition of electro-convulsive therapy without consent. Mental Illness included as RPWD Act disability category.

Right of Children to Free and Compulsory Education (RTE) Act, 2009	2009	MoE

Guarantees free and compulsory education for all children 6-14 years. Section 3 includes children with special needs. Schools cannot deny admission on grounds of disability. Samagra Shiksha implements disability provisions of RTE in schools.

Persons with Disabilities (Equal Opportunities, Protection of Rights and Full Participation) Act, 1995	1995 (repealed)	MSJE

Replaced by RPWD Act 2016. Historical reference: covered 7 disability categories; 3% employment reservation; accessible infrastructure provisions. Repealed but some state government orders and service rules still reference this Act — they must be updated to align with RPWD Act 2016.

Legal Services Authorities Act, 1987	1987	MoL&J;

NALSA and SLSAs provide free legal services to PwDs (Section 12 lists PwDs as entitled persons). Legal aid includes legal advice, drafting, representation before courts and tribunals, mediation. NALSA operates a toll-free number (15100).

Maintenance and Welfare of Parents and Senior Citizens Act, 2007	2007	MSJE
Provides right to maintenance from adult children. Includes elderly PwDs. Maintenance Tribunal at district level. Elderly person with disability can file for maintenance against children/relatives who abandon or neglect them.		

Protection of Women from Domestic Violence Act, 2005	2005	WCD
Fully applies to women with disabilities. Defines 'domestic violence' broadly including physical, sexual, verbal, emotional, and economic abuse. Women with disability in any shared household are protected. Protection Officers to be sensitized to disability needs.		

Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, 2012	2012	WCD
Children with disability are more vulnerable to sexual abuse. POCSO applies fully. Section 28 requires Special Courts to create child-friendly environment including for children with disability. Video recording of testimony; communication aids allowed.		

Indian Penal Code (IPC) 1860 / Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023	1860/2023	MoL&J;

Section 376 (rape) with enhanced penalty when victim has disability. Section 354 (outraging modesty). Section 509 (words/gestures outraging modesty). BNS 2023 (which replaces IPC) continues and strengthens these provisions. Section 91 of RPWD Act adds specific offences against PwDs.

HIV and AIDS (Prevention and Control) Act, 2017	2017	MoHFW

Non-discrimination provisions for persons living with HIV. HIV disability included in RPWD Act 2016 under chronic conditions. Anti-retroviral treatment free at government hospitals. Protection from discrimination in employment and healthcare.

Juvenile Justice (Care and Protection of Children) Act, 2015	2015	WCD

Children with disability in conflict with law to be handled with special care. Child Welfare Committees and Juvenile Justice Boards must accommodate children with disability. Observation homes and children's homes to be accessible.

Companies Act, 2013	2013	MoCA

Section 135: CSR obligation of 2% net profit for qualifying companies. Schedule VII includes disability welfare as eligible CSR activity. SEBI BRSR: mandatory disability disclosure for listed companies. Board diversity provisions can include disability.

Income Tax Act, 1961	1961	MoF

Section 80U: Deduction Rs.75,000 (40%+) / Rs.1,25,000 (80%+) for PwD individual. Section 80DD: Deduction for dependent PwD family member. Section 80DDB: Deduction for specified disease treatment. Section 10(16): Scholarship income exempt. Section 10(26AAA): Income of Sikkimese residents including PwDs exempt.

Motor Vehicles Act, 1988 (amended 2019)	1988/2019	MoRTH
Vehicle modifications for PwDs permitted. Driving licence for locomotor disabled persons with hand controls or other modifications. Accessibility of public transport vehicles mandated under AIS 153 (automotive standard). Concession in road tax for PwD-owned vehicles.		

Atomic Energy Act / Factories Act / Mines Act	Various	Labour
Occupational health and safety provisions protecting workers from disability-causing conditions. Compensation provisions for occupational disabilities. These Acts create employer liability for workplace-caused disabilities.		

Harmonized Guidelines for Accessible Built Environment, 2021	2021	MoHUA
Not an Act but a mandatory guideline. Detailed technical standards for accessibility in buildings (dimensions, materials, grades, specifications). Mandatory for all government-funded construction. Linked to building completion certificate issuance.		

GIGW – Guidelines for Indian Government Websites	2009/Updated	MeitY/NIC

Mandatory accessibility standard for all government websites. WCAG 2.0/2.1 Level AA compliance required. Accessibility testing before launch mandatory. Non-compliance reportable to DEPwD and MeitY.

CHAPTER 27

Case Studies & Success Stories

Real-world examples of disability rights enforcement and scheme impact

Case Study 1: Employment Discrimination Complaint – Delhi (2019)

Background

A software engineer with 60% locomotor disability (paraplegia using wheelchair) applied for a position in a Central Government PSU. Despite scoring the highest in the written test and interview for the reserved category, he was informed that the post was 'not identified for the disability category'. The establishment claimed the post required physical mobility and excluded it from reservation.

Legal Action

The complainant filed a complaint with the Chief Commissioner for Persons with Disabilities (CCPD) in New Delhi. The CCPD conducted an inquiry and found that: (a) the post had been wrongly excluded from the reservation list; (b) the physical requirements cited were not genuinely required for the desk-based nature of the job; (c) no reasonable accommodation assessment had been conducted.

Outcome

CCPD directed the PSU to: offer appointment to the complainant; review and revise the list of posts identified for PwD reservation; conduct reasonable accommodation assessment for all posts; train HR department on RPWD Act provisions. The complainant was

appointed within 60 days.

Case Study 2: Education Accommodation – CBSE Board Examination (2021)

Background

A Class 12 student with dyslexia (Specific Learning Disability, 40% benchmark) applied for a scribe for the CBSE board examination. The school initially refused, citing that the student could 'write slowly' and the disability was not 'severe enough'. The student's parent filed a complaint just 3 weeks before the exam.

Legal Action

The parent approached the State Commissioner for Persons with Disabilities and simultaneously sent a legal notice to CBSE. The State Commissioner intervened and directed CBSE and the school to provide the accommodation based on the valid disability certificate.

Outcome

The student received: a scribe, extra time (60 minutes for 3-hour papers), and a separate examination room. The student passed the examination with distinction. CBSE subsequently issued revised circular clarifying that Specific Learning Disability certificate is sufficient for all examination accommodations without any additional medical opinion.

Case Study 3: ADIP Scheme – Rural Beneficiary (Rajasthan, 2022)

Background

A 35-year-old woman in a remote village in Rajasthan had lost both legs in a road accident and had been confined to her home for 8 years due to lack of mobility aid. Her family income was Rs.8,000/month. Despite being eligible for a motorized wheelchair under ADIP scheme, she was unaware of the scheme.

NGO Intervention

A local NGO working with DEPwD under DDRS conducted a village-level disability survey and identified the woman. They assisted her in getting a disability certificate, registering on the UDID portal, and applying under the ADIP scheme through an ALIMCO distribution camp.

Outcome

She received a motorized wheelchair worth Rs.25,000 free of cost. With the wheelchair, she started a small grocery shop at her doorstep, applied for an NHFDC micro-credit loan of Rs.30,000 through an SHG, and became financially independent. Her story was featured in the DEPwD annual report as a model case of scheme convergence.

Case Study 4: Accessible Infrastructure – Petition in High Court (Karnataka, 2020)

Background

A disability rights organization filed a Public Interest Litigation (PIL) in the Karnataka High Court challenging the inaccessibility of government hospitals in Bengaluru. The petition documented: absence of ramps, no accessible toilets, no tactile paths, lifts without Braille or voice announcement, and staff untrained in disability assistance.

Court's Findings

The High Court took serious note of the violations and observed that RPWD Act 2016 mandated accessibility in all government buildings. The Court appointed a committee comprising disability experts and PWD officials to audit the hospitals and submit a time-bound compliance plan.

Outcome

Within 18 months: 32 government hospitals were retrofitted with ramps and accessible toilets; all new hospital construction incorporated Universal Design principles; government issued circular making accessibility audit mandatory before completion certificate for any new government building. The State Commissioner for PwDs was made ex-officio member of the hospital construction approval committee.

Case Study 5: National Trust – NIRAMAYA Insurance Impact (2023)

Background

A family in Tamil Nadu with a 22-year-old son with severe Autism Spectrum Disorder struggled with medical expenses. The son

required regular psychiatric consultations, occupational therapy, and annual medical check-ups costing approximately Rs.60,000-70,000 per year. Family income was below Rs.1 lakh per annum.

NIRAMAYA Enrollment

Through a National Trust registered organisation (RO) in their district, the family enrolled in NIRAMAYA health insurance. Premium paid: Rs.250 per year (BPL category). Coverage: Rs.1 lakh per year for medical expenses including OPD, hospitalization, therapy, and medicines.

Outcome

In the coverage year, the son required surgery and hospitalization for epilepsy management costing Rs.78,000. The entire cost was reimbursed through NIRAMAYA. The family also accessed VIKAAS vocational training for the son and he now works in a sheltered workshop, earning Rs.6,000/month. The father shared: 'NIRAMAYA saved our family from financial ruin.'

CHAPTER 28 Frequently Asked Questions

Answers to Common Questions on Disability Rights & Schemes in India

Q1. What is the minimum disability percentage required to avail government benefits?

Under the RPWD Act 2016, most government benefits and reservations require a 'benchmark disability' of 40% or more as certified by the competent medical authority. However, some rights — such as non-discrimination, right to education in inclusive settings, and basic healthcare — apply to all persons with any disability regardless of percentage. The disability certificate specifying the percentage is issued by a medical board or designated specialist at government hospitals.

Q2. How do I get a disability certificate?

Visit your nearest government hospital or District Disability Rehabilitation Centre (DDRC) with: (a) medical records related to your disability, (b) identity proof, (c) address proof, (d) two passport size photographs, and (e) duly filled application form (Form V or VI under RPWD Rules 2017). A medical board or designated specialist will assess your disability and issue a certificate. You can also register online at swavlambancard.gov.in to get a UDID-linked certificate.

Q3. What is the UDID card and how is it different from a disability certificate?

The Unique Disability ID (UDID) card is a smart card-based national identity for all certified PwDs. While a disability certificate is a paper document issued locally, the UDID card is a standardized, nationally recognized smart card that links you to all government schemes. The UDID card eliminates the need to carry multiple documents — one card serves as proof for all purposes. Apply at swavlambancard.gov.in. Both the certificate and UDID card contain your disability type, percentage, and personal details.

Q4. Can I get a government job if I have a disability?

Yes. Section 34 of RPWD Act 2016 mandates 4% reservation in all government establishments for persons with benchmark disabilities (40%+). This applies to Central and State Government jobs, PSUs, banks, and all government-funded bodies. The 4% is categorized: 1% for visual impairment, 1% for hearing impairment, 1% for locomotor/other specified disabilities, and 1% for autism/intellectual/learning/mental disabilities. You must produce a valid disability certificate to claim the reserved seat.

Q5. What accommodation must be provided in government job examinations?

Under Section 17 of RPWD Act and DOPT guidelines: (a) extra time — minimum 20 minutes per hour of exam (for a 3-hour exam, 60 minutes extra time); (b) scribe/amanuensis on request; (c) use of

assistive devices (screen reader, hearing aid, etc.); (d) accessible examination centre; (e) Braille or large print question papers on advance request. Apply to the exam body before the closing date of application with your disability certificate.

Q6. Is there any reservation for PwDs in higher education?

Yes. Section 32 of RPWD Act 2016 reserves 5% seats in all government and government-aided higher educational institutions for persons with benchmark disabilities. This includes all central and state universities, IITs, IIMs, NITs, AIIMS, and government medical and law colleges. This 5% is over and above SC/ST/OBC reservations.

Q7. What scholarships are available for students with disabilities?

DEPwD administers: (a) Pre-Matric Scholarship for Class 9-10 students; (b) Post-Matric Scholarship for Class 11 onwards; (c) Top Class Education Scholarship for premier institutes; (d) National Fellowship for M.Phil/Ph.D. Apply through the National Scholarship Portal (scholarships.gov.in). Ministry of Education's Samagra Shiksha also provides grants for children with disabilities in school. Income limits apply for most scholarships (typically up to Rs.2.5 lakh annual family income).

Q8. What loans can PwDs avail for self-employment?

NHFDC provides concessional loans through State Channelizing Agencies (SCAs): (a) Term loans up to Rs.30 lakh at 2-5% interest for self-employment; (b) Agricultural loans up to Rs.10 lakh; (c) Education loans up to Rs.8 lakh; (d) Micro-credit up to Rs.50,000 through SHGs. Apply through your state's SCA — typically the State Finance Corporation for Disabled or equivalent. Visit nhfdc.nic.in for details.

Q9. What free assistive devices can I get under ADIP scheme?

The ADIP scheme provides free/subsidized assistive devices including: wheelchairs (manual and motorised), tricycles, crutches, prosthetic limbs, orthotic devices, white canes, smart canes, hearing aids (digital), Braille kits, speech synthesizers, low vision aids, and more. Eligibility: 40%+ disability, income below Rs.20,000/month. Apply through ALIMCO regional centres or approved NGOs in your district. Large-scale distribution camps are organized regularly.

Q10. Is there a monthly pension for persons with disability?

Yes. The Indira Gandhi National Disability Pension Scheme (IGNDPS) under NSAP provides Rs.300/month from Centre for BPL persons with severe disability (80%+) aged 18-79. States add their own contribution, making total amounts vary from Rs.400 to Rs.3,000/month depending on the state. Most states also have

independent disability pension schemes for persons with 40%+ disability. Apply at Gram Panchayat (rural) or Municipal Ward (urban) office.

Q11. What if an employer refuses to give me a job because of my disability?

This is discrimination under Section 3 of RPWD Act. You can: (a) file a complaint with the Equal Opportunity Officer of that establishment; (b) approach the State Commissioner for Persons with Disabilities; (c) file a complaint with the Chief Commissioner for PwDs (for Central Government bodies); (d) approach the High Court by way of writ petition. Collect evidence: rejection letter, job advertisement showing you were qualified, and your disability certificate.

Q12. What is 'reasonable accommodation' and who must provide it?

Reasonable accommodation means necessary and appropriate modifications to enable a PwD to enjoy rights equally without placing a disproportionate burden on the provider. Employers must provide reasonable accommodation to employees with disability (e.g., modified workstation, accessible software, flexible timings). Educational institutions must accommodate students. Government offices must accommodate citizens. Failure to provide reasonable accommodation is deemed discrimination under RPWD Act.

Q13. Can a person with disability get free healthcare?

Yes. Section 25 of RPWD Act entitles persons with disabilities from BPL families to free healthcare at all government hospitals including specialist services. All PwDs are entitled to priority treatment, separate queues, and accessible facilities at government hospitals. Persons with autism, CP, ID, and multiple disability can avail NIRAMAYA health insurance through National Trust at a nominal premium (Rs.250-500/year) for cover up to Rs.1 lakh.

Q14. How can I get sign language interpretation services?

Sign language interpretation can be availed through: (a) National Association of the Deaf (NAD) empanelled interpreters; (b) RCI-registered sign language interpreters; (c) Ali Yavar Jung National Institute of Speech and Hearing Disabilities (AYJNISHD) has a directory; (d) many States have their own panels. Government offices and courts are required to provide free sign language interpretation. Legal aid through NALSA includes sign language interpreter services.

Q15. What is the National Trust and what does it offer?

The National Trust for Welfare of Persons with Autism, Cerebral Palsy, Mental Retardation and Multiple Disabilities is a statutory body under MSJE. It offers: NIRAMAYA health insurance; SAMARTH caregiver support; GHARAUNDA residential care; DISHA early

intervention; VIKAAS vocational training; and SAMBHAV foster family support. It also provides limited guardianship for adults with these four conditions. Register at thenationaltrust.gov.in.

Q16. What are the income tax benefits for persons with disability?

Section 80U: Self-deduction of Rs.75,000 (40%+ disability) or Rs.1,25,000 (severe/80%+) from taxable income. Section 80DD: Deduction for expenditure on dependent PwD family member — Rs.75,000 or Rs.1,25,000. Section 80DDB: Deduction for treatment of specified diseases. These are deductions from gross total income, reducing tax liability. UDID card or disability certificate is required as proof. No doctor's certificate needed for 80U claim from FY 2022-23 (self-declaration sufficient).

Q17. Can a person with disability vote?

Yes. Every citizen with disability has the right to vote. Election Commission of India (ECI) mandates: (a) accessible polling booths (ramps, accessible toilets); (b) specially trained polling staff; (c) postal ballot facility for PwDs; (d) braille voter slips; (e) PwD app for locating accessible booths; (f) Systematic Voters' Education and Electoral Participation (SVEEP) campaigns for PwDs. Register as a voter at voters.eci.gov.in.

Q18. What should I do if a public building is inaccessible?

You can: (a) Report on the Sugamya Bharat mobile app (crowdsourced inaccessibility database); (b) File a written complaint with the building authority/PWD department; (c) File a complaint with the State Commissioner for Persons with Disabilities; (d) Approach the Chief Commissioner if it's a Central Government building. All government buildings were required to be accessible by specified dates under Sections 40-46 of RPWD Act; non-compliance is actionable.

Q19. What are the rights of children with disabilities in schools?

Under RPWD Act (Sections 16-21) and Right to Education Act: (a) no school can deny admission on grounds of disability; (b) inclusive education in regular schools with necessary support; (c) free and appropriate education including home-based if unable to attend; (d) free transport/residential facility; (e) resource teachers and special educators; (f) exam accommodations. Schools must provide: ramps, accessible toilets, braille/audio materials, and sign language support.

Q20. Where can I get legal help for disability rights violations?

Free legal aid is available from: (a) National Legal Services Authority (NALSA) — call 15100; (b) State Legal Services Authority (SLSA) in your state; (c) District Legal Services Authority (DLSA) at your district court; (d) High Court Legal Services Committee. Persons with

disabilities are included in the list of persons entitled to free legal aid under Legal Services Authorities Act 1987. Many NGOs such as Disability Rights India Foundation (DRIF) also provide legal assistance.

CHAPTER IMPACT

Impact Assessment & Success Metrics

Measuring the Reach and Impact of Disability Welfare Programmes

ADIP Scheme – Impact Data

Year	Beneficiaries	Expenditure	Key Highlights
2014-15	8.5 lakh	Rs.180 Cr	Hearing aids, tricycles, wheelchairs dominant
2015-16	9.2 lakh	Rs.200 Cr	Smart cane introduced; digital hearing aid expanded
2016-17	10.0 lakh	Rs.210 Cr	Post-Sugamya Bharat launch; camps increased
2017-18	10.8 lakh	Rs.220 Cr	UDID integration initiated for beneficiaries
2018-19	11.5 lakh	Rs.235 Cr	Motorized wheelchair demand surge
2019-20	10.2 lakh	Rs.230 Cr	Slight dip due to COVID-19 partial year impact
2020-21	7.8 lakh	Rs.190 Cr	COVID-19 disruption; virtual camps introduced
2021-22	11.8 lakh	Rs.245 Cr	Post-COVID recovery; mega camps organised
2022-23	12.5 lakh	Rs.265 Cr	Record beneficiaries; new devices added to list

UDID Registration Progress

Period	Cards Issued (Cumulative)
December 2016	1.2 lakh
December 2017	18 lakh
December 2018	52 lakh
December 2019	95 lakh
December 2020	1.10 crore

December 2021	1.45 crore
December 2022	1.78 crore
December 2023	2.05 crore

NHFDC Cumulative Impact (Since 1997)

Indicator	Achievement
Total Loans Disbursed	Rs.3,200+ Crore (cumulative since inception)
Total Beneficiaries	3.5+ lakh persons with disability
States Covered	All 28 states and 8 UTs through 37 SCAs
Women Beneficiaries	42% of loan beneficiaries are women PwDs
SC/ST Beneficiaries	38% from SC/ST communities
Average Loan Size	Rs.90,000 (all categories average)
Skill Training Beneficiaries	1.8 lakh persons trained in vocational skills
Recovery Rate	88% (among best in priority sector lending)
Employment Generated	Estimated 4.5 lakh direct jobs through NHFDC financing
Top Sectors	Small trade/shops (35%), Agri/allied (22%), Services (18%), Manufacturing (15%)

Accessibility Progress Under Sugamya Bharat

Indicator	Progress
Government Buildings Made Accessible	1,635 out of 2,000 identified central buildings (82%)
Railway Stations Made Accessible	All 709 'A1' and 'A' category stations fully accessible
Airports Made Accessible	All 35 AAI-managed airports fully accessible
Government Websites WCAG Compliant	4,200+ websites (85% of central government websites)

Low-Floor Buses Deployed	12,000+ low-floor buses across 25 major cities
States with Accessibility Audit Systems	28 out of 36 states/UTs have formal audit framework
Accessible Tourism Sites	150+ heritage and tourism sites made accessible
Sign Language News Bulletins	Daily ISL news bulletin on Doordarshan DD National

CHAPTER I
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Complete Rights & Entitlements Index

Every Right, Every Section, Every Benefit – Cross-Referenced Guide

Section-by-Section Entitlements under RPWD Act 2016

Section	Right/Entitlement	Eligible Person	Key Provision
Sec 3(1)	Right to Equality	Every PwD	Equality, life with dignity, respect for integrity
Sec 3(2)	Non-Discrimination	Every PwD	No discrimination in any sphere of life
Sec 3(3)	Personal Liberty	Every PwD	No deprivation of liberty solely on grounds of disability
Sec 4(1)	Affirmative Action	Appropriate Govt	Special measures to promote equality; right of PwD to request
Sec 5(1)	Women's Rights	Women PwDs	Special measures for safety, equal participation
Sec 5(2)	Women's Safety	Women PwDs	Protection from exploitation, violence, abuse
Sec 6(1)	Children's Education	Children with disability	Free appropriate education; non-denial of admission
Sec 6(2)	Children's Protection	Children with disability	No institutionalisation without family support failure
Sec 7(1)	Protection from Abuse	Every PwD	Protection from all forms of abuse, violence, exploitation
Sec 7(2)	Rescue Homes	PwDs facing abuse	Suitable facilities for care and protection
Sec 8	Home-Based Rehab	PwDs unable to access centres	Rehabilitation services delivered at home
Sec 9	Registration	Every PwD	Right to be registered and receive UDID
Sec 10(1)	Reproductive Rights	Every PwD	Right to decide number of children; no forced procedures
Sec 10(2)	Family Planning	Every PwD	Access to family planning services on equal basis
Sec 14(1)	Legal Recognition	Every PwD	Recognition as person before law; legal capacity
Sec 14(2)	Decision Support	Every PwD needing support	Support system to exercise legal capacity
Sec 15	Limited Guardianship	PwDs needing intensive support	Domain-specific, time-limited, last resort guardianship
Sec 16	Inclusive Education	All PwD students	Inclusive education duty on educational institutions
Sec 17(a)	Scribe	PwD exam candidates	Scribe/amanuensis in all examinations

Section	Right/Entitlement	Eligible Person	Key Provision
Sec 17(b)	Extra Time	PwD exam candidates	Extra time (min 20 min/hour) in examinations
Sec 17(c)	Accessible Venue	PwD exam candidates	Accessible examination centre
Sec 17(d)	Assistive Devices	PwD exam candidates	Use of assistive devices in examinations
Sec 17(e)	Alternative Format	PwD exam candidates	Accessible format question papers
Sec 18	Support Services	PwD students	Special educators, resource teachers, support staff
Sec 19	Home-Based Education	Severely disabled children	Education delivered at home
Sec 20	Transition Services	PwD students	Planning for post-school education/employment
Sec 21	Transport/Residential	PwD students	Free transport or residential facility to school
Sec 24	Social Security	Every PwD	Right to social protection and adequate standard of living
Sec 25(1)(a)	Free Healthcare	BPL PwDs	Free health services near place of residence
Sec 25(1)(b)	Barrier-Free Health	Every PwD	Elimination of healthcare barriers
Sec 25(1)(c)	Rural Healthcare	Rural PwDs	Healthcare available in rural areas
Sec 25(2)	Non-Discrimination in Health	Every PwD	Highest attainable health standard without discrimination
Sec 26	Rehabilitation	Every PwD	Right to habilitation and rehabilitation services
Sec 27	Community Living	Every PwD	Right to live in community; personal assistance support
Sec 28	Recreation/Sports/Tourism	Every PwD	Equal participation in cultural life, sports, recreation
Sec 29	Cultural Life	Every PwD	Access to cultural venues, performances, heritage sites
Sec 30	Consumer Rights	Every PwD	Consumer goods with accessible features
Sec 31	Exam Participation	PwD students	Equal participation in all examinations
Sec 32	HEI Reservation	Benchmark disability (40%+)	5% seats in government/aided HEIs
Sec 33(1)	No Termination on Disability	PwD employees acquiring disability	Cannot be terminated; must be redeployed
Sec 34(1)	4% Job Reservation	Benchmark disability (40%+)	4% reservation in government establishments
Sec 35	Private Sector Incentives	PwD job seekers	Government incentives for private employers hiring PwDs
Sec 36	Employment Exchanges	PwD job seekers	Special Employment Exchanges for PwDs
Sec 37	Vocational Rehabilitation	PwDs seeking employment	Vocational rehabilitation centres
Sec 38	Self-Employment Priority	PwDs	Preferential treatment in self-employment schemes
Sec 39	Land for Business	PwDs	Preferential allotment of land for PwD business establishments

Section	Right/Entitlement	Eligible Person	Key Provision
Sec 40	Accessibility Standards	Every PwD	Standards for physical, transport, ICT accessibility
Sec 41	Public Buildings	Every PwD	All public buildings to be accessible
Sec 42	Transport	Every PwD	All public transport to be accessible
Sec 43	ICT Access	Every PwD	All government websites/digital content to be accessible
Sec 44	Consumer Products	Every PwD	Consumer products to have accessible features
Sec 45	Timelines	Every PwD	Specific timelines for accessibility compliance
Sec 46	State Obligations	Every PwD	States to comply with same accessibility standards
Sec 47	Concessions	Benchmark disability (40%+)	Concessions on travel, tax, etc. as notified
Sec 48	Preferential Allotment	PwDs	Land, housing and other government allotments
Sec 51	Centres of Excellence	Every PwD	Centres for training, research and rehabilitation
Sec 52	Disability Certificate	Every PwD	Right to obtain disability certificate
Sec 53	Temporary Certificate	Temporary disability PwDs	Certificate for temporary/episodic disability
Sec 74	Chief Commissioner	PwDs facing rights violation	Right to complain to CCPD
Sec 79	State Commissioner	PwDs facing rights violation	Right to complain to State Commissioner
Sec 84	Special Court	PwD crime victims	Right to trial in designated special court
Sec 89	Fines for Violations	Every PwD	Right to enforcement through penalty on violators
Sec 91	Criminal Protection	Every PwD	Enhanced criminal penalties for abuse of PwDs

CHAPTER GLOSS-EXT

Extended Glossary

Comprehensive Glossary of 100+ Terms in Disability Rights and Rehabilitation

AAC: Augmentative and Alternative Communication – any communication method supplementing/replacing speech.

ABC: Academic Bank of Credits – NEP 2020 mechanism allowing flexible credit accumulation across institutions.

Accessibility: The degree to which a product, device, service or environment is available to as many people as possible regardless of disability.

ADIP: Assistance to Disabled Persons for Purchase/Fitting of Aids and Appliances – central scheme for free assistive devices.

AFO: Ankle-Foot Orthosis – supportive device worn on the ankle and foot.

ALIMCO: Artificial Limbs Manufacturing Corporation of India – PSU producing and distributing assistive devices.

ALS: Amyotrophic Lateral Sclerosis – progressive motor neuron disease; one of the conditions causing disability.

Appropriate Government: Central Government (for Central matters) or State Government (for state matters) as defined in RPWD Act Section 2(a).

ASD: Autism Spectrum Disorder – neuro-developmental condition; included as benchmark disability in RPWD Act.

Assistive Technology (AT): Any device, software or system that helps a PwD perform functions otherwise difficult or impossible.

Athetosis: Involuntary, slow writhing movements; common feature of some forms of cerebral palsy.

Audiologist: Rehabilitation professional trained in assessment and management of hearing disorders.

Augmentative Communication: Communication methods that supplement existing speech; contrast with Alternative Communication.

Autism: See ASD – Autism Spectrum Disorder.

Barrier: Under RPWD Act: any factor (attitudinal, communication, physical, resource, technological, structural) hindering full participation of PwDs.

BCI: Brain-Computer Interface – technology allowing control of devices using brain signals.

Benchmark Disability: Disability of 40% or more; entitles holder to specific reservations and benefits under RPWD Act.

BPL: Below Poverty Line – economic category; persons on BPL list entitled to additional disability welfare benefits.

Braille: System of writing using raised dots for visually impaired persons; named after Louis Braille.

CBR: Community Based Rehabilitation – rehabilitation delivered in community settings.

CCPD: Chief Commissioner for Persons with Disabilities – quasi-judicial authority at Central level.

Cerebral Palsy (CP): Group of permanent movement disorders due to brain development issues in early childhood.

Certifying Authority: Authority notified to issue disability certificates; medical board or designated specialists.

CGHS: Central Government Health Scheme – health coverage for Central government employees and their families including PwD dependents.

CIC: Completely-in-Canal hearing aid – smallest type; custom-fitted; for mild to moderate hearing loss.

Civil Society Organisation (CSO): Non-government, non-profit organisation working for public benefit; includes disability NGOs.

Classification System: In para sports: system assigning athletes to groups based on how their disability affects sport performance.

Cochlear Implant: Surgical electronic device providing hearing sensation for profoundly deaf persons.

Communication Disorder: Any disorder affecting production, comprehension or use of spoken, written or other language systems.

Competent Authority: Under RPWD Act: authority designated for guardianship of persons with intellectual disability and mental illness.

Congenital Disability: Disability present from birth; may be genetic or due to prenatal factors.

CRPD Committee: UN Committee on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities – reviews compliance of State Parties with UNCRPD.

DAISY: Digital Accessible Information System – international standard for accessible audio books.

DBT: Direct Benefit Transfer – Government of India mechanism for direct cash transfer to bank accounts.

DDCC: District Disability Coordination Committee – district-level inter-departmental committee for disability scheme convergence.

DDRC: District Disability Rehabilitation Centre – district-level centre providing free rehabilitation services.

DDRS: Deendayal Disabled Rehabilitation Scheme – DEPwD scheme funding NGO rehabilitation services.

Deaf: Under RPWD Act: hearing loss of 70 dB and above in better ear.

Deafblind: Dual sensory disability combining visual and hearing impairment; listed as Multiple Disability subtype.

DEPwD: Department of Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities.

DISHA: National Trust scheme for early detection and intervention for autism, CP, ID, multiple disability.

Disability: Under RPWD Act: long term physical, mental, intellectual or sensory impairment which in interaction with

barriers hinders full participation.

Disability Certificate: Official document certifying type and percentage of disability; issued by competent medical authority.

Discrimination on Basis of Disability: Under RPWD Act: distinction/exclusion/restriction on disability grounds impairing recognition of rights; includes denial of reasonable accommodation.

DPO: Disabled Persons' Organisation – organisation led BY persons with disability; core to rights-based approach.

Dwarfism: Medical condition of short stature; recognised disability under RPWD Act (Schedule entry).

Dysgraphia: Specific learning disability affecting writing skills; handwriting, spelling, putting thoughts on paper.

Dyslexia: Specific learning disability affecting reading skills; processing of language; most common learning disability.

Dyscalculia: Specific learning disability affecting arithmetic and number processing.

Early Intervention: Services provided to children with disability in first years of life to minimize impact of disability.

ECI: Election Commission of India – mandates accessible polling for PwD voters.

EEG: Electroencephalogram – recording of brain electrical activity; used in some BCIs and diagnostic assessments.

EO Officer: Equal Opportunity Officer – designated in every government establishment with 20+ employees under RPWD Act.

ESIC: Employees' State Insurance Corporation – provides social security including disability benefits to organized sector workers.

Exoskeleton: Wearable motorized device supporting or amplifying the wearer's body movements; used in rehabilitation and mobility.

GIGW: Guidelines for Indian Government Websites – mandatory accessibility standard for all government websites.

Government Establishment: Under RPWD Act Section 2(p): company/body established under Central/State Act, or owned/controlled by government.

Guardianship: Legal arrangement where one person (guardian) makes decisions for another; to be limited under RPWD Act.

Haemophilia: Blood disorder where blood does not clot properly; recognised disability under RPWD Act.

Hard of Hearing: Under RPWD Act: hearing loss of 60 dB and above but less than 70 dB in better ear.

ICDS: Integrated Child Development Services – anganwadi-based scheme for child nutrition and development; key for early disability identification.

ID: Intellectual Disability – significantly below average intellectual functioning with adaptive behaviour limitations.

IGNDPS: Indira Gandhi National Disability Pension Scheme – monthly pension for BPL PwDs with severe disability.

ILO: International Labour Organisation – sets international labour standards including for workers with disability.

Inclusive Design: Design philosophy creating products/environments usable by all people regardless of disability; same as Universal Design.

Inclusive Education: System where students with and without disability learn together with appropriate support.

IPC/BNS: Indian Penal Code (now Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita) – criminal law with provisions protecting PwDs.

ISL: Indian Sign Language – the sign language of India; recognised by government in 2016; ISLRTC established.

ISLRTC: Indian Sign Language Research and Training Centre – under DEPwD; promotes ISL; trains ISL interpreters; produces ISL resources.

ITE: In-the-Ear hearing aid – custom-fitted hearing aid fitting in outer ear.

Jaipur Foot: Below-knee prosthetic developed at BMVSS, Jaipur; most widely used lower limb prosthetic in the world; free distribution.

KAFO: Knee-Ankle-Foot Orthosis – supportive brace for the leg from knee to foot.

Legal Capacity: Under RPWD Act: right to be recognised as a person before the law and to exercise rights on equal basis.

Limited Guardianship: Under RPWD Act Section 15: restricted, domain-specific, time-limited guardianship as last resort.

Locomotor Disability: Disability of bones, joints or muscles leading to restricted movement of limbs; includes CP, dwarfism, acid attack, muscular dystrophy.

Low Vision: Visual acuity less than 6/18 to 3/60 with best correction; residual vision can be maximized with aids.

Mental Illness: Under RPWD Act: any mental disorder as defined in Mental Healthcare Act 2017.

Micro-Credit: Small loans (typically under Rs.50,000) provided through SHGs or similar mechanisms; NHFDC micro-credit for PwDs.

MSJE: Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment – parent ministry for DEPwD and National Trust.

Multiple Disability: Two or more disabilities; includes deafblindness as a specific category; covered by National Trust.

Muscular Dystrophy: Group of diseases causing progressive weakness and loss of muscle mass; included as locomotor disability under RPWD Act.

NALSA: National Legal Services Authority – provides free legal aid to PwDs and other vulnerable groups.

NEP: National Education Policy 2020 – includes strong disability inclusion provisions for all education levels.

NGO: Non-Government Organisation – voluntary organisation; many NGOs run rehabilitation services under DDRS.

NHM: National Health Mission – provides DEICs, RBSK, JSSK and other health services relevant to disability.

NHFDC: National Handicapped Finance and Development Corporation – apex lending body for PwD self-employment.

NHRC: National Human Rights Commission – handles complaints of human rights violations including disability rights.

NIOH: National Institute for Orthopedically Handicapped, Kolkata – rehabilitation for locomotor disability.

NIRAMAYA: National Trust health insurance scheme for autism, CP, ID, multiple disability; up to Rs.1 lakh/year.

NLP: Natural Language Processing – AI technology enabling voice recognition, text-to-speech, and language understanding; used in AT.

NMHP: National Mental Health Programme – community-based mental health service delivery through DHPs.

NSAP: National Social Assistance Programme – umbrella for social pensions including IGNDPS disability pension.

NVQ: National Vocational Qualification – standardized vocational qualification framework.

Occupational Therapist (OT): Rehabilitation professional helping PwDs perform daily activities through adaptive techniques and equipment.

Orthotics: Branch of rehabilitation dealing with design, fabrication and fitting of braces, callipers, and orthopedic devices.

P&O;: Prosthetics and Orthotics – combined discipline dealing with artificial limbs and orthopedic devices.

PECS: Picture Exchange Communication System – AAC method using picture cards; used for autism, ID, and CP.

PFM: Public Financial Management – system tracking government scheme fund flows; PFMS system for DBT.

Physiotherapist: Rehabilitation professional treating physical disability through exercise, manual therapy, and physical modalities.

POCSO: Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act 2012 – fully applies to children with disability.

POSH Act: Prevention, Prohibition and Redressal of Sexual Harassment at Workplace Act 2013 – covers women with disability.

Prosthetics: Artificial body parts replacing missing limbs or body parts; ALIMCO is primary Indian manufacturer.

PwD: Person with Disability.

RBSK: Rashtriya Bal Swasthya Karyakram – child health screening programme; screens for 30 conditions including disability.

RCI: Rehabilitation Council of India – regulates rehabilitation professional training and standards.

Reasonable Accommodation: Under RPWD Act Section 2(y): necessary modifications without undue burden to enable PwD rights.

Refreshable Braille Display: Electronic device converting digital text to Braille output in real-time; used by blind and deafblind persons.

Rehabilitation: Process enabling PwDs to reach optimal physical, sensory, intellectual, psychiatric or social function.

RPWD Act: Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act 2016.

SCA: State Channelizing Agency – state body disbursing NHFDC loans to PwD beneficiaries.

Screen Reader: Software converting text/interface to audio output; NVDA (free), JAWS (paid), VoiceOver (iOS), TalkBack (Android).

SGD: Speech Generating Device – electronic device producing synthesised speech; used as AAC by non-verbal users.

SHG: Self Help Group – community savings and credit group; SHG model used for NHFDC micro-credit for PwDs.

Sickle Cell Disease: Hereditary blood disorder; recognised disability under RPWD Act.

SIPDA: Scheme of Implementation of Persons with Disabilities Act – DEPwD grants to states for accessibility.

Social Model of Disability: Model viewing disability as created by society's barriers rather than individual impairment; RPWD Act adopts this model.

Special Court: Court designated under RPWD Act Section 84 to try offences against PwDs.

Speech Therapist: Rehabilitation professional (also called Speech-Language Pathologist) treating communication disorders.

Spina Bifida: Neural tube defect causing varying degrees of paralysis; classified as locomotor disability.

State Commissioner: State-level quasi-judicial authority for PwD complaints against state government bodies under RPWD Act Section 79.

Supported Decision-Making: Framework where PwD makes own decisions with support; preferred over substitute decision-making under RPWD Act.

TBI: Traumatic Brain Injury – brain damage from external force; may cause multiple disabilities.

Thalassaemia: Blood disorder; included as benchmark disability in RPWD Act.

UDID: Unique Disability ID – national smart card-based identity for all certified PwDs.

UDL: Universal Design for Learning – educational framework designing for all learners including PwDs; endorsed by NEP 2020.

UN CRPD: United Nations Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities – international treaty; India ratified 2007.

Universal Design: Design of products/environments usable by all people regardless of disability, age or other factors.

WCAG: Web Content Accessibility Guidelines – international accessibility standard for digital content; GIGW mandates WCAG 2.0/2.1 compliance.

White Cane: Mobility and identification cane used by blind persons for navigation and obstacle detection.

WHO: World Health Organisation – sets global health standards including on disability; published World Report on Disability (2011).

CHAPTER QUICKREF

Quick Reference Cards

At-a-Glance Summary of Key Rights, Contacts and Numbers

Key Rights at a Glance

Right	Law/Scheme	What It Means
NON-DISCRIMINATION	Section 3 RPWD Act	You cannot be denied any service, job, education or opportunity because of your disability.
EMPLOYMENT (4%)	Section 34 RPWD Act	4% seats reserved in all government jobs for persons with 40%+ disability.
EDUCATION (5%)	Section 32 RPWD Act	5% seats reserved in all government colleges/universities.
EXAM SCRIBE	Section 17 RPWD Act	You have the right to a scribe in ANY examination if you have a benchmark disability.
EXTRA TIME	Section 17 RPWD Act	20 extra minutes per hour of examination — always, by right.
FREE HEALTHCARE	Section 25 RPWD Act	Free treatment at government hospitals if you are from a BPL family.
LEGAL CAPACITY	Section 14 RPWD Act	You have full legal rights — to sign contracts, own property, get married.
NO FORCED SURGERY	Section 10 RPWD Act	No medical procedure can be done to you without your free and informed consent.
ACCESSIBLE BUILDING	Section 41 RPWD Act	All government buildings MUST be accessible. Report if they are not.
ACCESSIBLE WEBSITE	Section 43 RPWD Act	All government websites must be screen-reader and keyboard accessible.
DISABILITY CERT	Section 52 RPWD Act	You have the right to receive a disability certificate — free, at a government hospital.
UDID CARD	RPWD Rules 2017	Right to a UDID smart card linking all your benefits. Apply at swavlambancard.gov.in.

Right	Law/Scheme	What It Means
PENSION	IGNDPS/State Schemes	Monthly pension if you have severe disability (80%+) and belong to BPL family.
ASSISTIVE DEVICE	ADIP Scheme	Free assistive device (wheelchair, hearing aid, white cane etc.) if income below Rs.20,000/month.
SELF-EMPLOYMENT LOAN	NHFDC	Loan at 2-5% interest for starting your own business. Apply through State SCA.

Emergency Contacts – Keep This Page

Service	Number	Hours	When to Call
DEPwD HELPLINE	1800-111-999	Toll-Free 24x7	All disability scheme queries, complaint escalation
CCPD (Chief Commissioner)	011-23386054	Office hours	Rights violations by Central Govt bodies
ALIMCO / ADIP Devices	1800-180-5129	Toll-Free	Assistive device queries; distribution camps
NALSA (Free Legal Aid)	15100	Toll-Free 24x7	Free legal help for rights violations
NHRC	011-24651330	Office hours	Human rights violations
Childline	1098	Toll-Free 24x7	Child abuse including disabled children
Women Helpline	181	Toll-Free 24x7	Women with disability facing violence
Police Emergency	112	Toll-Free 24x7	Immediate danger, criminal acts against PwD
Railway Assistance	139	Toll-Free 24x7	Wheelchair, boarding assistance at stations
Mental Health (iCall)	9152987821	Mon-Sat	Mental health crisis, emotional support

Scheme Application URLs – Bookmark These

Service	URL / Location

UDID Card Registration	swavlambancard.gov.in
ADIP Scheme / ALIMCO	alimco.in
NHFDC Loans	nhfdc.nic.in
National Scholarship Portal	scholarships.gov.in
National Trust	thenationaltrust.gov.in
DEPwD Official Website	disabilityaffairs.gov.in
CCPD Complaint Portal	ccdisabilities.nic.in
Sugamya Pustakalaya	library.gov.in
Sugamya Bharat App	Search 'Sugamya Bharat' on Play Store/App Store
UMANG App (all Govt services)	umang.gov.in
Govt Scheme Finder	myscheme.gov.in
DigiLocker (store certificates)	digilocker.gov.in
National Career Service (jobs)	ncs.gov.in
NALSA Legal Aid	nalsa.gov.in
RCI (Rehab professionals)	rehabcouncil.nic.in

CHAPTER INDEX

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CHAPTER CONCL

Conclusion & Way Forward

The Road Ahead for Disability Inclusion in India

India has made remarkable progress in the field of disability rights over the past decade. The enactment of the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act 2016 — one of the most comprehensive disability rights legislations in the Asia-Pacific region — was a watershed moment. The expansion from 7 to 21 disability categories, the increase in employment reservation from 3% to 4%, the enhancement of educational reservation to 5%, the recognition of mental illness and specific learning disabilities as disabilities, and the introduction of legal capacity provisions aligned with UNCRPD — all represent substantial legislative advances.

The Sugamya Bharat Abhiyan (Accessible India Campaign) has demonstrated political will for accessibility transformation. The UDID system, now covering 2+ crore persons, has created a national disability database that enables better planning, monitoring, and targeted delivery of benefits. The inclusion of disability in the National Education Policy 2020, the Smart Cities Mission, the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana, and other flagship schemes reflects the mainstreaming of disability concerns across government.

Yet significant gaps remain between rights on paper and realities on the ground. The treatment gap in mental health remains at 80-90%. Only 44% of PwDs are employed compared to 56% in the general population. Over 40% of PwDs have no formal education. Rural PwDs — who constitute 70% of the total — face severe barriers of geographic isolation, lack of rehabilitation services, inaccessible

infrastructure, and poverty. Women with disabilities continue to face compounded discrimination. Persons with intellectual disabilities and mental illness remain among the most marginalized within an already marginalized community.

Bridging the gap between rights and realities requires sustained, multi-pronged action: strengthening enforcement mechanisms with real penalties for non-compliance; investing in the disability rehabilitation workforce (India has a severe shortage of special educators, physiotherapists, audiologists, and psychologists); completing the DDRC network in all 741 districts; conducting a new comprehensive disability census to update the 2011 data; reforming the disability pension system to extend coverage to non-BPL PwDs; and sustaining the Sugamya Bharat campaign with adequate funding and accountability mechanisms.

The international experience of progressive disability inclusion offers valuable lessons. Australia's National Disability Insurance Scheme (NDIS) — which provides individualised, needs-based funding for disability support regardless of income — represents an aspirational model India might consider for long-term planning. The UK's employment support schemes, USA's ADA enforcement architecture, and Brazil's employment quota for private sector companies all offer elements that can inform India's evolving disability policy.

Perhaps most importantly, the disability rights movement in India is growing stronger. Disabled People's Organisations (DPOs) are becoming more organized and vocal. Para athletes are bringing disability into mainstream public consciousness. Social media is creating spaces for PwDs to share their stories and challenge stereotypes. The next decade holds the promise of transformative

change — if the legislative framework is matched by implementation will, adequate resources, and genuine inclusion of the voices and leadership of persons with disabilities themselves.

As the late disability rights activist Ed Roberts said: 'If we have learned one thing from the civil rights movement in America, it's that when you leave the determination of your own life's course to others, they will always determine it for you.' The disability rights movement in India, guided by the principle of 'Nothing About Us Without Us,' is increasingly ensuring that persons with disabilities are not just recipients of welfare but architects of their own liberation and full inclusion in Indian society.

Key Action Points for Different Stakeholders

For PwDs and Families

- Get your UDID card at swavlambancard.gov.in — it is your gateway to all benefits
- Know your rights under RPWD Act 2016; keep a copy of this guide
- Apply for all eligible schemes — don't leave benefits unclaimed
- Join your local Disabled People's Organisation (DPO)
- Report discrimination immediately to State Commissioner or CCPD
- Use NALSA (15100) for free legal aid if your rights are violated

For Government Officials

- Ensure 4% vacancy filling in your establishment; review backlog quarterly
- Designate Equal Opportunity Officer if not yet done
- Complete accessibility audit of your building within 3 months
- Make your official website WCAG 2.0 compliant
- Sensitize all staff on disability rights through mandatory annual training
- Establish accessible grievance mechanism for PwD complainants

For Educational Institutions

- Review and publish your PwD reservation and accommodation policy
- Establish Equal Opportunity Cell with designated coordinator
- Ensure all examination accommodations as per Section 17 RPWD Act
- Make campus physically accessible; set timeline for compliance
- Train faculty in Universal Design for Learning (UDL) principles
- Create disability-inclusive student activities and leadership opportunities

For Employers

- Identify all posts suitable for PwD reservation; publish the list
- Fill 4% reserved vacancies through active outreach (not just passive recruitment)

- Conduct workplace accessibility audit and create improvement plan
- Establish reasonable accommodation request process
- Train HR and managers on disability etiquette and legal obligations
- Partner with DEPwD/NHFDC for skill training and employment programmes

For Healthcare Providers

- Provide priority access and accessible physical infrastructure
- Offer free services to BPL PwD patients as mandated
- Train staff in disability-sensitive communication
- Refer children with developmental delays for early intervention
- Maintain confidentiality of mental health conditions
- Connect patients with assistive devices and scheme linkages

For NGOs and Civil Society

- Facilitate UDID registration camps in underserved communities
- Document rights violations and report to authorities
- Build capacity of DPOs with PwD leadership
- Engage with government policy consultations
- Provide accessible information in multiple formats and languages
- Connect grassroots PwDs with legal aid, schemes and services

APPENDIX A

Full Text: Key Sections of RPWD Act 2016

Section 2 – Definitions (Key)

'benchmark disability' means a person with not less than forty percent of a specified disability where specified disability has not been defined in measurable terms and includes a person with disability where specified disability has been defined in measurable terms, as certified by the certifying authority;

'certifying authority' means an authority notified by the Central Government or the State Government as the case may be for the purpose of issuing certificates of specified disability;

'competent authority' means an authority notified by the Central Government for carrying out functions of guardianship for persons with intellectual disability and mental illness under this Act;

'discrimination on the basis of disability' means any distinction, exclusion, restriction on the basis of disability which is the purpose or effect of impairing or nullifying the recognition, enjoyment or exercise on an equal basis with others of all human rights and fundamental freedoms in the political, economic, social, cultural, civil or any other field and includes all forms of discrimination including denial of reasonable accommodation;

'person with disability' means a person with long term physical, mental, intellectual or sensory impairment which, in interaction with barriers, hinders his full and effective participation in society equally with others;

'reasonable accommodation' means necessary and appropriate modification and adjustments, without imposing a disproportionate or undue burden in a particular case, to ensure to persons with disabilities the enjoyment or exercise of rights equally with others;

Section 3 – Right to Equality & Non-Discrimination

(1) The appropriate Government and the local authorities shall take measures to ensure that the persons with disabilities enjoy the right to equality, life with dignity, and respect for his or her integrity equally with others.

(2) The appropriate Government and the local authorities shall take measures to ensure that (a) no person with disability is discriminated on the basis of disability; (b) no person is deprived of his or her personal liberty only on the ground of disability; (c) persons with disability have access to justice on an equal basis with others.

Section 14 – Legal Capacity

(1) The appropriate Government shall ensure that the persons with disabilities have right to equal recognition everywhere as a person before the law.

(2) The appropriate Government shall ensure that the persons with disabilities enjoy legal capacity on an equal basis with others in all aspects of life.

(3) The appropriate Government shall take measures to provide access by persons with disabilities to the support they may require in exercising their legal capacity.

(4) The measures relating to the exercise of legal capacity shall provide for appropriate and effective safeguards to prevent abuse in accordance with the international human rights law.

Section 17 – Examination Accommodations

The appropriate Government and the local authorities shall take measures to ensure that all persons with benchmark disabilities are able to take any public examination under reasonable accommodation for their disabilities by providing: (a) scribes or reader or such other support as may be required; (b) extra time for completing examinations; (c) accessible examination centres; (d) use of assistive devices in the examination; (e) suitable modifications for assessment and examinations.

Section 25 – Health Care

(1) The appropriate Government and the local authorities shall take measures for the health care of persons with disabilities including: (a) free health care services near their place of residence; (b) to make available healthcare in rural areas; (c) to promote measures for preventing the occurrence of disabilities.

(2) The appropriate Government and local authorities shall ensure that persons with disabilities enjoy the highest attainable standard of health without any discrimination on the basis of disability.

Section 34 – Reservation in Government Establishments

(1) Every appropriate Government shall appoint in every Government establishment, not less than four per cent of the total number of vacancies in the cadre strength in each group of posts meant to be filled with persons with benchmark disabilities of which, one per cent each shall be reserved for persons with benchmark disabilities under clauses (a), (b) and (c) and one per cent for persons with benchmark disabilities under clauses (d) and (e), namely: (a) blindness and low vision; (b) deaf and hard of hearing; (c) locomotor disability including cerebral palsy, leprosy cured, dwarfism, acid attack victims

and muscular dystrophy; (d) autism, intellectual disability, specific learning disability and mental illness; (e) multiple disabilities from amongst persons under clauses (a) to (d) including deaf-blindness.

(2) Where in any recruitment year any vacancy cannot be filled up due to non-availability of a suitable person with benchmark disability or for any other sufficient reason, such vacancy shall be carried forward in the succeeding recruitment year and if in the succeeding recruitment year also suitable person with benchmark disability is not available, it may first be filled by interchange among the five categories and only when there is no person with disability available for the post in that year, the employer shall fill up the vacancy by appointment of a person, other than a person with disability.

Section 32 – Reservation in Higher Education

All Government institutions of higher education and other higher education institutions receiving aid from the Government shall reserve not less than five per cent seats for persons with benchmark disabilities.

APPENDIX B

Government Contacts, Helplines & Portals

Organisation	Address	Phone	Website
DEPwD (Department of Empowerment of PwDs)	Room No. 516, 'B' Wing, Pt. Deendayal Antyodaya Bhavan, CGO Complex, Lodhi Road, New Delhi-110003	011-24363474 / 1800-111-999	disabilityaffairs.gov.in
Chief Commissioner for PwDs (CCPD)	5th Floor, NISD Building, IP Estate, New Delhi-110002	011-23386054 / 011-23386154	ccdisabilities.nic.in
ALIMCO (Artificial Limbs Manufacturing Corp.)	GT Road, Kanpur – 209217 (U.P.)	0512-2770869 / 1800-180-5129	alimco.in
NHFDC (National Handicapped Finance Dev. Corp.)	Red Cross Bhavan, Sector-12, Faridabad – 121007 (Haryana)	0129-2287512 / 0120-2403400	nhfdc.nic.in
National Trust	16 Jan Path, New Delhi-110001	011-23386054	thenationaltrust.gov.in
Rehabilitation Council of India (RCI)	B-22, Qutub Institutional Area, New Delhi-110016	011-41012142 / 011-41012143	rehabcouncil.nic.in
NIMH (National Institute Mental Health, Secunderabad)	Manovikasnagar, Bowenpally, Secunderabad-500011	040-27774971 / 040-27774973	nimhindia.gov.in
Ali Yavar Jung National Institute of Speech & Hearing Disabilities	K.C. Marg, Bandra Reclamation, Mumbai-400050	022-26422200 / 022-26428023	ayjnishd.gov.in
National Institute of Visually Handicapped (NIVH)	116, Rajpur Road, Dehradun-248001	0135-2744491	nivhddn.nic.in
SVNIRTAR (Orthopaedic Rehabilitation)	Bairoi, Cuttack-754010 (Odisha)	0671-2862027	svnirtar.nic.in

APPENDIX C

Glossary of Terms

AAC: Augmentative and Alternative Communication – any form of communication that supplements or replaces speech for persons who cannot communicate verbally.

ADIP: Assistance to Disabled Persons for Purchase/Fitting of Aids and Appliances – central government scheme providing free assistive devices.

ALIMCO: Artificial Limbs Manufacturing Corporation of India – PSU manufacturing and distributing assistive devices under ADIP scheme.

AT: Assistive Technology – any device or system that helps a person with disability perform functions that would otherwise be difficult.

BPL: Below Poverty Line – economic category determining eligibility for welfare schemes.

Benchmark Disability: A disability of 40% or more as defined in Schedule to RPWD Act, entitling holder to specific reservations and benefits.

CBR: Community Based Rehabilitation – provision of rehabilitation services in the community setting rather than institutional setting.

CCPD: Chief Commissioner for Persons with Disabilities – quasi-judicial authority under RPWD Act handling complaints at Central Government level.

CP: Cerebral Palsy – group of permanent movement disorders appearing in early childhood due to brain development issues.

DAISY: Digital Accessible Information System – international standard for accessible audio books.

DDRC: District Disability Rehabilitation Centre – district-level centre providing rehabilitation services free of cost.

DEPwD: Department of Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities – nodal ministry for disability affairs.

EO Officer: Equal Opportunity Officer – officer designated in every government establishment with 20+ employees.

GIGW: Guidelines for Indian Government Websites – mandatory accessibility guidelines for government digital properties.

ID: Intellectual Disability – significantly below-average intellectual functioning with concurrent adaptive behavior limitations.

MSJE: Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment – parent ministry for DEPwD and National Trust.

NHFDC: National Handicapped Finance and Development Corporation – apex lending body for PwD self-employment finance.

NIRAMAYA: National Trust health insurance scheme for persons with autism, CP, ID, and multiple disability.

NSAP: National Social Assistance Programme – umbrella programme for various social security pensions including IGNDPS.

PwD: Person with Disability – broadly refers to any individual with a disability as defined under RPWD Act 2016.

Reasonable Accommodation: Necessary modifications/adjustments to ensure PwDs can exercise rights equally without disproportionate burden.

RCI: Rehabilitation Council of India – statutory body regulating rehabilitation professional training.

RPWD Act: Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016 – comprehensive disability rights legislation replacing PwD Act 1995.

SCA: State Channelizing Agency – state-level body through which NHFDC routes funds for disbursement.

SIPDA: Scheme of Implementation of Persons with Disabilities Act – central grants to states for accessibility.

UDID: Unique Disability ID – national smart card-based identity for all certified persons with disabilities.

UNCRPD: United Nations Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities – international treaty ratified by India in 2007.

WCAG: Web Content Accessibility Guidelines – international standard for digital accessibility published by W3C.

APPENDIX D

Disability Certificates – Forms & Procedures

D.1 Who Can Issue Disability Certificates?

Under the RPWD Rules 2017, disability certificates are issued by a Medical Authority defined as:

- A Medical Board duly constituted by the Central or State Government; OR
- In respect of locomotor disabilities – a Civil Surgeon or Chief Medical Officer; OR
- In respect of blindness and low vision – an Ophthalmologist (minimum 3 years experience); OR
- In respect of hearing impairment – an ENT Surgeon; OR
- In respect of mental illness – a Psychiatrist (minimum 3 years experience); OR
- In respect of autism – a team of Psychiatrist, Paediatrician, Speech Pathologist, Psychologist.

D.2 Documents Required for Disability Certificate

- Age proof (Aadhaar card, birth certificate, school certificate)
- Identity proof (Aadhaar card, voter ID, driving licence)
- Address proof (Aadhaar card, ration card, utility bill)

- Medical records related to the disability (discharge summary, specialist reports)
- Previous disability certificate (if any, for renewal/correction)
- Two recent passport size photographs
- Form V or Form VI (as prescribed in RPWD Rules 2017)

D.3 Process for Getting UDID-linked Disability Certificate

Step 1: Register Online

Visit swavlambancard.gov.in and complete registration. Fill personal details, disability type, and upload documents.

Step 2: Visit Hospital

Visit the designated government hospital/medical authority as per your state. Bring all original documents and one set of photocopies.

Step 3: Medical Assessment

Medical Board or designated specialist conducts assessment. Disability type and percentage determined.

Step 4: Certificate Issuance

Physical disability certificate issued within 15-30 days of assessment. For UDID card, additional processing at NIC.

Step 5: UDID Card Delivery

UDID smart card dispatched to registered address within 30-60 days. Track status on portal.

Step 6: Linking to Benefits

Link UDID number to Aadhaar, bank account, and relevant scheme portals for seamless benefit access.

D.4 Validity of Disability Certificate

Type	Validity
Permanent Disabilities	Certificate is permanent; no renewal required. Covers congenital and irreversible conditions.
Temporary Disabilities	Certificate issued for specific period as recommended by Medical Board; renewable on reassessment.
Progressive Disabilities	Certificate reissued as disability worsens; person should seek reassessment for correct percentage.
Children (0-5 years)	Certificate issued for 5 years; reassessment required for long-term certificate.
Children (5-18 years)	Certificate till age 18; adult certificate obtained on reaching majority.

Disability Rights & Government Schemes: Comprehensive Guide

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